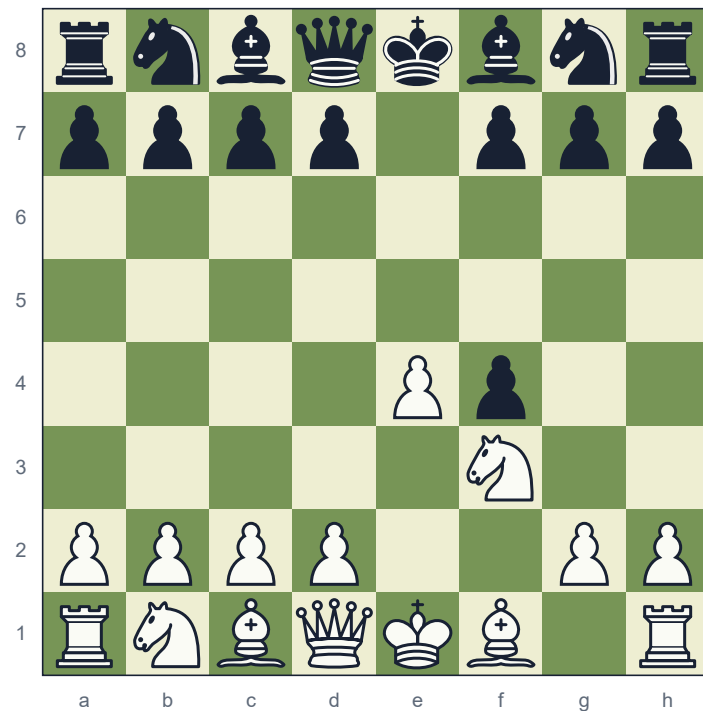


King's Gambit

A complete practical curriculum from the ground up

After 1.e4 e5 2.f4 White offers the f-pawn to challenge e5, build a center and accelerate development. The price is a more exposed king. This is an ambitious practical choice, not a promise of an objective opening advantage.



The reference position - Black to move

YOUR PERSPECTIVE

White is at the bottom of every diagram. Coordinates remain explicit and all pieces stay upright.

WHAT YOU WILL LEARN

32 opening branches, six middlegame laboratories, 48 exercises with explained answers, and a 12-week practice plan. Each subject also appears in one combined volume.

START HERE

Read this booklet first. Then learn one line from each family in Booklet 01. Use 02 for plans, 03 for practice positions, 04 for retrieval and 05 for study schedules and reference.

How to use this course

YOUR FIRST PASS

Use a real or digital board. Read the foundations, then learn only the first line of each opening family. Play slow practice games before trying to remember every variation. A useful opening lesson ends with a decision you can explain, not a string of moves you can recite.

YOUR SECOND PASS

Return to the branch your opponent actually played. Replay it from move one and stop before each move by your side. Name the threat, two plausible replies and the reason for your choice. Check the printed continuation only after committing to an answer.

YOUR THIRD PASS

Use the middlegame laboratories and exercise book. These are original illustrative positions and engine-assisted continuations, not attributed master games. Switch colors in training so you experience the opponent's space, defensive resources and attacking chances.

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This is a broad practical curriculum from basic rules to common opening decisions, middlegames and typical transitions. Chess has too many legal branches for a finite course to exhaust. The course teaches a decision process for unfamiliar replies and marks alternatives, warnings and entry-route boundaries explicitly.

The board and the object of the game

COORDINATES

Files are a through h from White's left to right. Ranks are 1 through 8 from White's side toward Black. A square such as e4 has one file letter and one rank number. White has a light square at the near right corner, h1. Black-oriented diagrams reverse the coordinate display, not the movement rules.

URNS AND CHECK

White moves first; the players alternate one move each. A move may not leave your own king attacked. Check means that the king is attacked; answer by moving the king, capturing the attacker or blocking a line attack when possible. A knight check cannot be blocked.

CHECKMATE AND STALEMATE

Checkmate means the player to move is in check and has no legal reply. Stalemate means the player has no legal move but is not in check; it is a draw. Before announcing mate, examine every king move, capture and possible block. Kings are never actually captured.

MATERIAL IS A GUIDE

For beginner decisions, a pawn is roughly 1, a knight or bishop 3, a rook 5 and a queen 9. These are rough comparisons, not a scoring rule. A king has no exchange value. Activity, safety, passed pawns and immediate tactics can outweigh a small material difference.

How the pieces move

ROOK AND BISHOP

A rook moves along a rank or file. A bishop moves diagonally and stays on its starting square color. Neither can jump over any piece. A sliding piece controls only as far as the first occupied square on each ray; do not count an attack through your own pawn.

QUEEN AND KNIGHT

A queen combines rook and bishop movement. A knight moves two squares in one direction and one at right angles, changing square color. The knight may jump over pieces. A knight on f3 can move to d2, d4, e1, e5, g1, g5, h2 or h4 if the destination and king-safety rules allow.

KING

A king moves one square in any direction and cannot enter an attacked square. The kings cannot stand next to each other. A pinned enemy piece can still restrict the king's legal squares; the rules about attacked squares are more subtle than whether that enemy piece could legally move away from its own king.

PAWN

White pawns move toward higher rank numbers; Black pawns toward lower. A pawn moves one square straight ahead into an empty square, or two from its starting rank if both squares are empty. It captures one square diagonally forward. It cannot move backward or capture straight ahead.

Castling, promotion and en passant

CASTLING

Castling moves the king two squares toward a rook and places that rook on the square the king crossed. The king and that rook must never have moved, the intervening squares must be empty, and the king must not be in check or cross or land on an attacked square. A rook being attacked does not by itself prevent castling.

RIGHTS DO NOT RETURN

If a king or rook moves out and back, the relevant castling right is still lost. A king moved to f1 in the King's Gambit must coordinate its rooks another way. In queenless positions the loss of castling may be less serious, but the legal right remains lost.

PROMOTION

A pawn reaching the last rank must promote to a queen, rook, bishop or knight of its color. It need not choose a previously captured piece. A second queen is legal. Underpromotion can avoid stalemate or create a knight fork, so inspect the exact position before always choosing a queen.

EN PASSANT

Immediately after an opposing pawn advances two squares from its starting rank and lands beside your pawn on your fifth rank, you may capture it as though it had advanced one square. The opportunity lasts only for your next move. The capture is illegal if removing those pawns exposes your own king to check.

Reading moves and navigating branches

ALGEBRAIC NOTATION

K means king, Q queen, R rook, B bishop and N knight. Pawns have no piece letter: e4 is a pawn move. Bc4 means a bishop moves to c4. Nxe5 captures on e5. exd5 is an e-file pawn capturing on d5. A plus sign is check; # is checkmate; O-O is kingside castling and O-O-O queenside castling.

WHICH PIECE MOVED

If two identical pieces can legally reach the same square, notation distinguishes them: Nbd2 means the knight from the b-file; R1e2 means the rook from rank 1. The board, not the notation alone, determines which capture or check is legal. Promotion is written e8=Q, with + or # when appropriate.

MOVE NUMBERS

1.e4 e5 is White's first move and Black's first reply. A line beginning 7...Nf6 starts with Black's seventh move. All main opening lines in this course begin at the initial position; laboratory continuations display their starting diagram and exact move number.

ONE LINE IS NOT FORCED

An example to move ten is one route through the position. It is not a claim that every reply is compulsory. The authored anchor and its illustrative continuation are distinguished. Each line has an ID that also appears in the PGN files and exercises.

Your thinking routine on every move

1. INSPECT THE LAST MOVE

Ask what the opponent's move changed. Did it attack a piece, unmask a bishop, release a rook file, threaten mate or leave something undefended? A remembered opening move is only a candidate until it survives this inspection.

2. EXAMINE FORCING MOVES

Check all checks, serious captures and direct threats for both sides. Calculate the opponent's best reply, not the reply you hope for. Stop the line at a position you can assess: material, king safety and the resulting pawn structure.

3. GENERATE CANDIDATES

Usually compare two or three useful moves: one forcing move, one developing or improving move, and one central response if relevant. In a cramped position ask which exchange or pawn break creates room. In an attacking position ask whether the center can open against your king.

4. BLUNDER CHECK

Before moving, visualize the new position. Is your queen or another piece loose? Have you removed a defender or opened a diagonal to your king? Can the opponent answer with a check, fork or intermediate capture? A ten-second check often saves more points than memorizing another opening branch.

Center, development and time

OCCUPY AND INFLUENCE

Pawns on d4 and e4 occupy central space; bishops and knights can influence those squares from a distance. A restrained setup needs a plan to challenge the opponent's center. Space becomes useful when it gives your pieces safe squares and restricts the opponent.

DEVELOPMENT

Bring knights and bishops into useful play, protect the king and connect the rooks. Avoid moving the same piece repeatedly without a concrete gain. An exception must be explained: a queen retreat in the Scandinavian or a knight escape in the King's Gambit can be compulsory.

A TEMPO

A tempo is one move of useful time. Attacking a queen while developing often gains time, but a check that helps the opponent develop can fail to do so. Count actual useful moves and threats instead of assuming every attack is a gain.

OPENING THE CENTER

If your king is safer and your pieces are ready, opening files can exploit a development lead. If your king is exposed, central exchanges may be dangerous. A closed center often allows maneuvering or a wing attack, but first verify that the opponent cannot open it with a pawn break.

Pawn structures and planning vocabulary

BREAK AND TENSION

A pawn break challenges an enemy pawn structure: c4 against d5 or ...c5 against d4. Tension exists when pawns can capture each other but neither side has committed. Before exchanging, ask which pieces become active, which file opens and which pawn becomes weak.

CHAIN AND BASE

A pawn chain is a diagonal line of mutually supporting pawns. In a white d4-e5 chain, d4 is the base and e5 the head. An attack on either end may work, but the calculation differs: ...c5 usually challenges d4, while ...f6 challenges e5.

WEAK SQUARES AND OUTPOSTS

A square is a useful outpost when a piece can occupy it securely and create meaningful pressure, often because enemy pawns cannot chase it. An outpost with no targets may be less valuable than a flexible central piece. Check whether exchanges eliminate its support.

FILES, DIAGONALS AND LEVERS

A file without pawns is open; one with no pawn of your color is half-open for you. A fianchetto bishop can be excellent on an open diagonal and restricted behind blocked pawns. A lever changes that reality. Name the pawn move that makes your plan possible.

Playing, recording and analyzing a game

CHOOSE A USEFUL TIME CONTROL

For course practice use at least 15 minutes with an increment, or a longer control if available. Blitz is useful for pattern recognition after the basic decisions are learned. It is a poor substitute for calculating an unfamiliar sharp opening carefully.

ANALYZE YOURSELF FIRST

After the game, mark the first unfamiliar position and write your candidates without an engine. Identify the first important mistake, not only the final blunder. Separate opening memory, tactical calculation, strategic judgment and time-management errors.

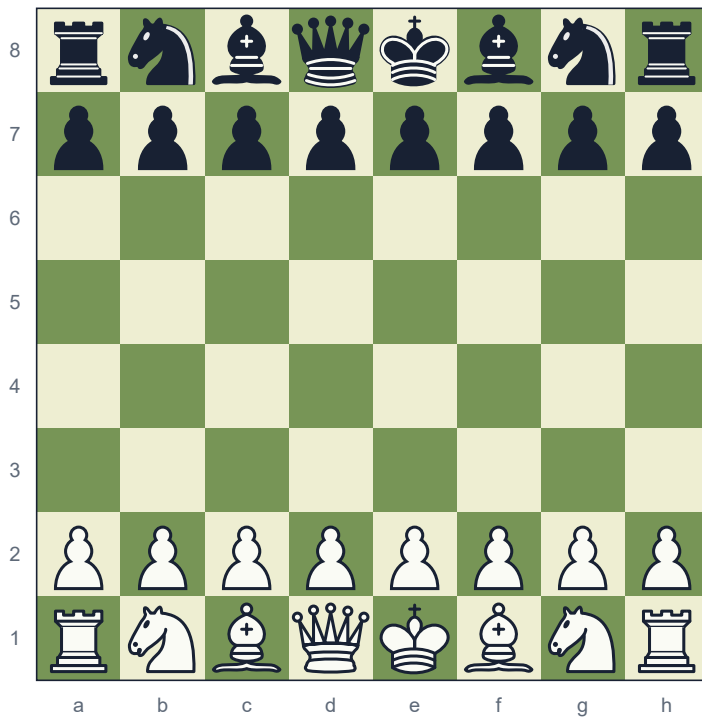
THEN USE THE TOOLS

Compare the game with the matching line ID. Use an engine to test forcing variations and examine a stronger defensive reply. An engine number is evidence from a finite search, not a verbal explanation. Write one sentence that tells you what to do differently next time.

BUILD A SMALL ERROR NOTEBOOK

Keep the position, your move, a better candidate, the opponent's key reply and one lesson. Revisit it after one day, three days, a week and a month. Add the position to your repertoire only when you can explain it without the answer visible.

Read the diagram before the moves



White to move

A RELIABLE FIRST SCAN

Find both kings, name the side to move and locate all pawns in the center. Then inspect checks, captures and direct threats.

ORIENTATION

Your course side is at the bottom. On a Black-oriented board, files read h to a along the bottom; pawns still move according to their color and rank numbers.

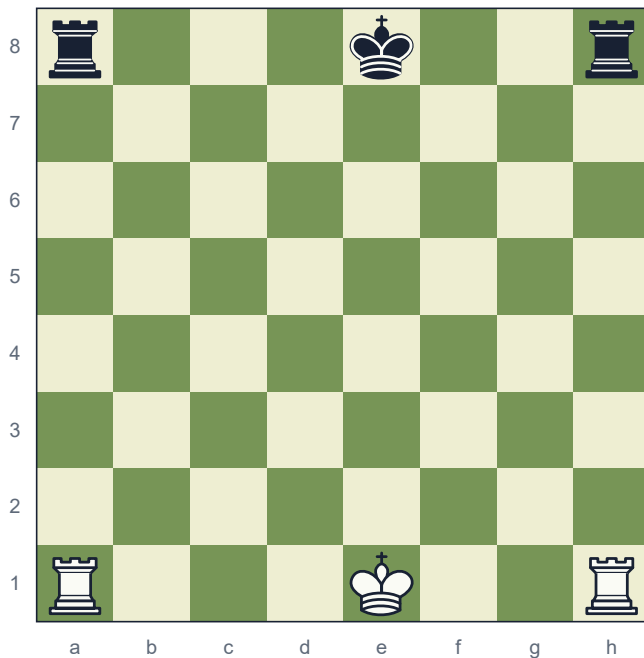
PRACTICE WITHOUT MOVING

Find e4, d5, f7 and b2. Name the piece that begins on each of b1, c1, f8 and g8. From the initial position, count White's legal pawn moves and knight moves: 16 pawn moves and 4 knight moves.

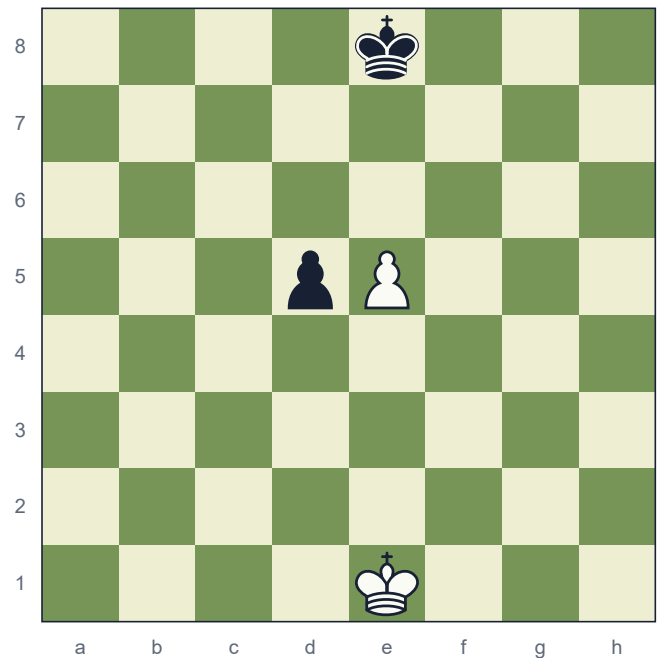
ANSWER THE REAL POSITION

A board caption always states whose move it is and whether the king is in check. You may not ignore check to finish development. In the initial position, bishops and rooks are blocked by friendly pieces.

Castling and en passant on a board



White to move - castling geometry



White to move - en passant available

LEFT: CASTLING GEOMETRY

With the rights recorded in this teaching position, White may castle O-O or O-O-O. The king crosses f1 or d1 and lands on g1 or c1; the rook lands on f1 or d1. Empty squares alone are not enough in a real game: check previous king/rook moves and attacked king squares.

RIGHT: IMMEDIATE EN PASSANT

Black has just played ...d7-d5. White can play exd6 en passant: the white pawn lands on d6 and the black pawn is removed from d5. If White plays another move, the special capture is no longer available.

TRAINING QUESTION

Why can a knight jump over a piece but a bishop cannot? Why can a rook be attacked during legal castling while the king cannot cross an attacked square? Explain the movement rule before using it in an opening.

Your first moves, explained

1. E4

Changes central space and pawn contacts. Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension before choosing the next piece plan.

2. F4

Creates a wing or central pawn contact and changes king shelter. Calculate captures and the opponent's central counterplay before extending the advance.

3. NF3

Develops the king knight toward e5 and d4. In the King's Gambit it also controls h4, making an immediate queen check there unattractive.

BEFORE YOU MEMORIZE

The reference route is one example. Reconstruct it, then change one opposing move and explain why the next automatic setup move might need to change.

Repertoire map / 1

ACCEPTED: THE G-PAWN DEFENSES

Start with KG-01. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

KG-01 The main choice: meet ...g5 with h4

Attack the pawn chain, then move the attacked knight.

KG-02 Kieseritzky: the developing ...Nf6

Count both sides' captures, not just the pawn you recovered.

KG-03 Kieseritzky: an immediate ...d6

An attacked piece may escape by capturing a target.

KG-04 Black reinforces with ...h6

Calculate the h-file before choosing the recapture.

KG-05 Black develops the bishop early

Track a pawn's new file after every capture.

KG-06 Quiet alternative: the Vienna-style approach

A development move can concede a forcing pawn tempo.

KG-07 Fischer Defense: build the center

...d6 changes the knight's retreat square.

KG-08 Fischer Defense: Black develops first

If the pawn is returned, play the resulting position.

Repertoire map / 2

ACCEPTED: CENTRAL AND DEVELOPING DEFENSES

Start with KG-09. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

KG-09 Modern Defense: ...d5 at once

Central counterplay can matter more than retaining the extra pawn.

KG-10 Modern Defense: the queen recaptures

Gain a tempo and spend it on development.

KG-11 Abbazia: an early pawn exchange

A check can help the defender develop.

KG-12 Schalopp Defense

An offside knight may still perform a concrete defensive job.

KG-13 Cunningham: meet the bishop check

Surviving the check changes the whole king-safety plan.

KG-14 Cunningham: Black chooses ...Nf6

Count attackers and defenders on f2 as well as f7.

KG-15 The ...Nc6 developing defense

Development with tempo must still be tactically safe.

KG-16 The ...h6 waiting move

Match the position, not just the opening name.

Repertoire map / 3

DECLINED AND COUNTERGAMBITS

Start with KG-17. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

KG-17 Classical Declined: ...Bc5

Respect the diagonal before taking e5.

KG-18 Declined: ...Bc5 with ...Nc6

A declined gambit can become a normal development contest.

KG-19 Falkbeer: the ...e4 wedge

Challenge the wedge before it binds your pieces.

KG-20 Falkbeer transposes to the Modern

Transpose by position, including whose turn it is.

KG-21 Falkbeer: ...c6 counter gambit

You do not have to accept a second gambit.

KG-22 Declined with ...d6

Gain space, then finish development.

KG-23 Declined with ...Nc6

The opening can change family a move later.

KG-24 The ...f5 counter gambit

Against counter gambits, check forcing moves first.

Repertoire map / 4

ALTERNATIVES AND REPERTOIRE BOUNDARIES

Start with KG-25. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

KG-25 Bishop's Gambit: optional route

Bc4 first permits the check Nf3 would prevent.

KG-26 Muzio: understand the sacrifice

Distinguish a deliberate piece sacrifice from normal development.

KG-27 Simple warning: the exposed king

Check the queen's diagonal before chasing a pawn.

KG-28 If Black plays the French

No ...e5 means no King's Gambit.

KG-29 If Black plays the Caro-Kann

Choose a real response to Black's first move.

KG-30 If Black plays the Sicilian

A bridge line has a defined move-order boundary.

KG-31 If Black plays the Scandinavian

Meet a central challenge with development and calculation.

KG-32 If Black plays a modern setup

Take space, then make it sustainable.

Accepted: the g-pawn defenses

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

KG-01 - Nf3 prevents an immediate queen check on h4. Black uses ...g5 to keep f4, so h4 attacks the supporting chain. After ...g4 the knight must move; Ne5 takes an active central post.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Develop Bc4 or d4 according to Black's reply, then solve king safety. The h-file may open for either side; do not assume the rook alone creates an attack.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

Black can play ...Nf6 against e4 and ...d6 against Ne5. Count the defenders of e4 before chasing f7.

RECOGNITION TEST

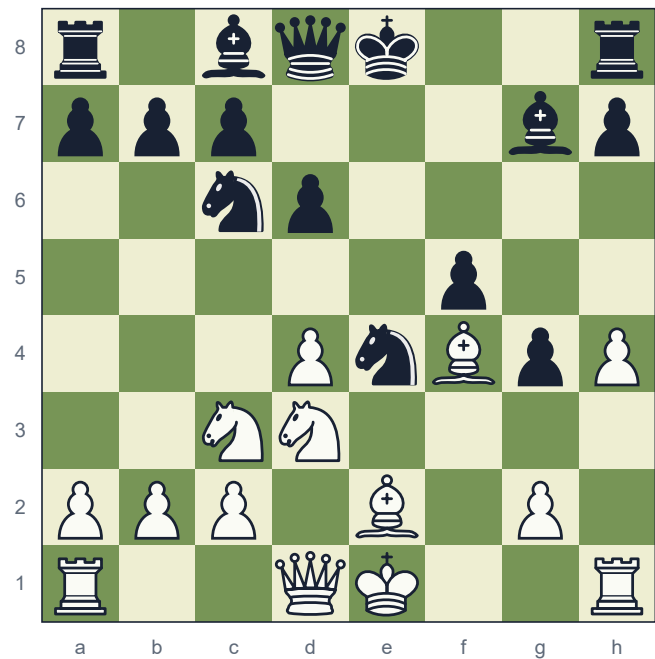
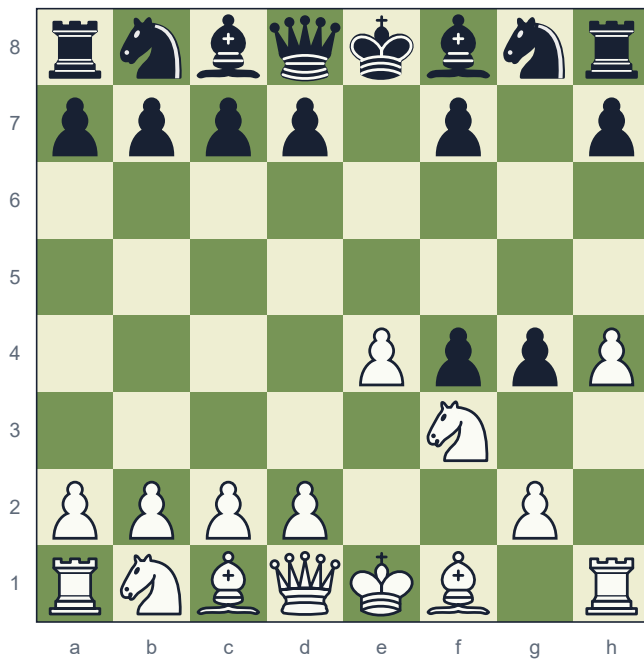
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

KG-01 / The main choice: meet ...g5 with h4

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 g5 4. h4 g4 5. Ne5 Nf6 6. d4 d6 7. Nd3 Nxe4 8. Bxf4 Nc6 9. Nc3 f5 10. Be2 Bg7

Authored anchor ends after 5. Ne5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

Nf3 prevents an immediate queen check on h4. Black uses ...g5 to keep f4, so h4 attacks the supporting chain. After ...g4 the knight must move; Ne5 takes an active central post.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop Bc4 or d4 according to Black's reply, then solve king safety. The h-file may open for either side; do not assume the rook alone creates an attack.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can play ...Nf6 against e4 and ...d6 against Ne5. Count the defenders of e4 before chasing f7.

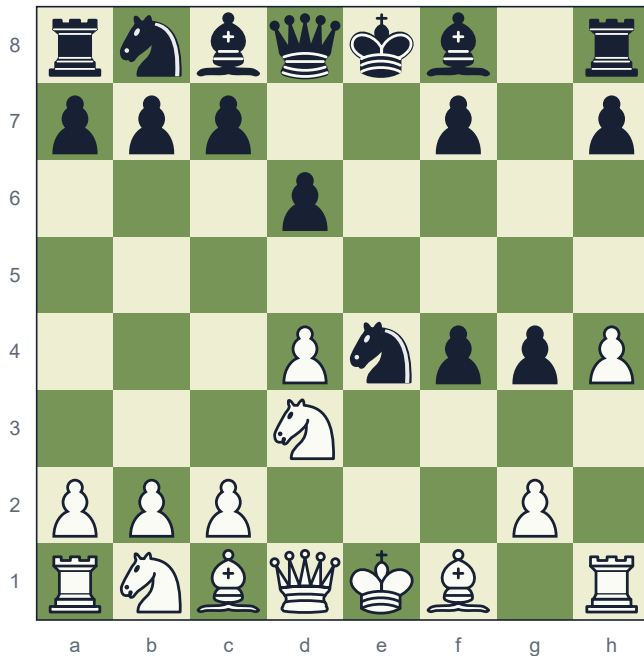
REMEMBER Attack the pawn chain, then move the attacked knight.

KG-02 / Kieseritzky: the developing ...Nf6

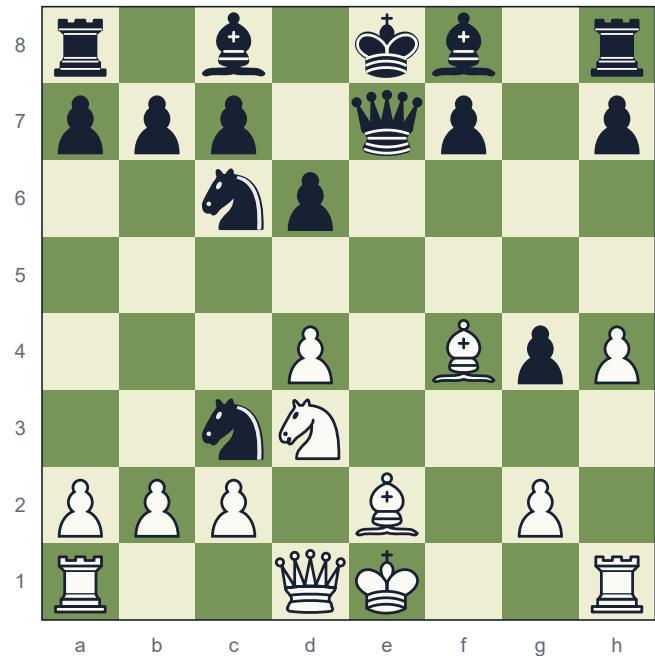
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 g5 4. h4 g4 5. Ne5 Nf6 6. d4 d6 7. Nd3 Nxe4 8. Bxf4 Qe7 9. Be2 Nc6 10. Nc3 Nxc3

Authored anchor ends after 8. Bxf4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The retreat Nd3 keeps the knight protected and allows the bishop to recover f4. Black takes e4, so material recovery alone has not won the opening.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Finish development and compare the open central files. Look for useful queen or knight pressure against the advanced e4 knight without overlooking a check.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black's knight is active and your king remains central. A speculative attack on f7 can lose time against ...Bg7 and ...O-O.

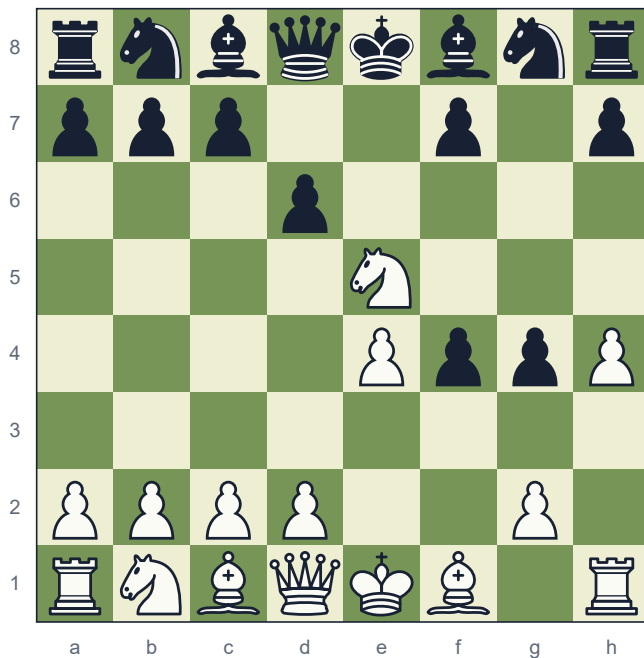
REMEMBER Count both sides' captures, not just the pawn you recovered.

KG-03 / Kieseritzky: an immediate ...d6

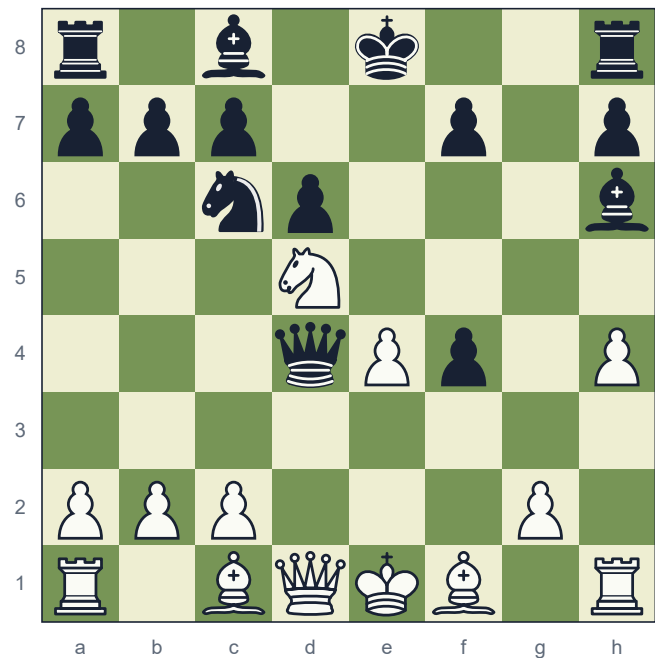
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 g5 4. h4 g4 5. Ne5 d6 6. Nxg4 Nc6 7. Nc3 Nf6 8. Nxf6+ Qxf6 9. d4 Bh6 10. Nd5 Qxd4

Authored anchor ends after 6. Nxg4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black attacks Ne5 with the d-pawn, but the knight can capture the advanced g4 pawn while escaping. This concrete resource is stronger than mechanically retreating to d3 in this exact position.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the bishops and build the center while checking whether the knight will be attacked again. Compare Black's bishop development with attempts to preserve f4.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A similar position with an extra black developing move can change the tactics. Do not treat Nxg4 as universal whenever ...d6 attacks Ne5.

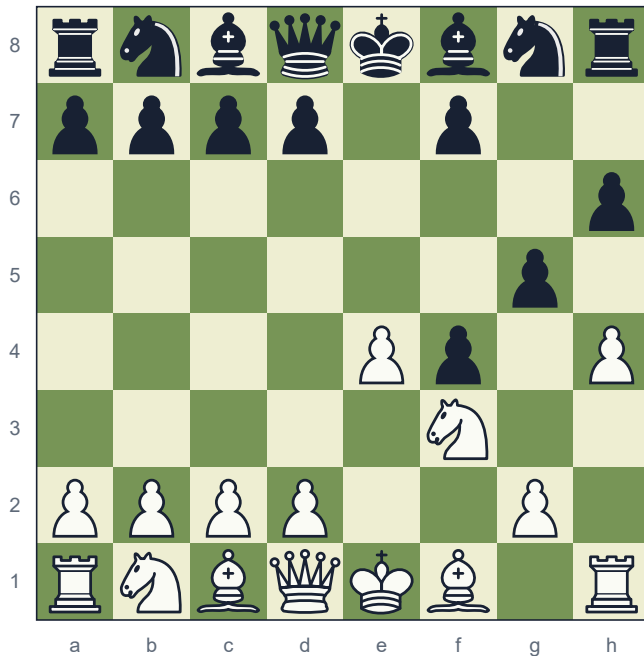
REMEMBER An attacked piece may escape by capturing a target.

KG-04 / Black reinforces with ...h6

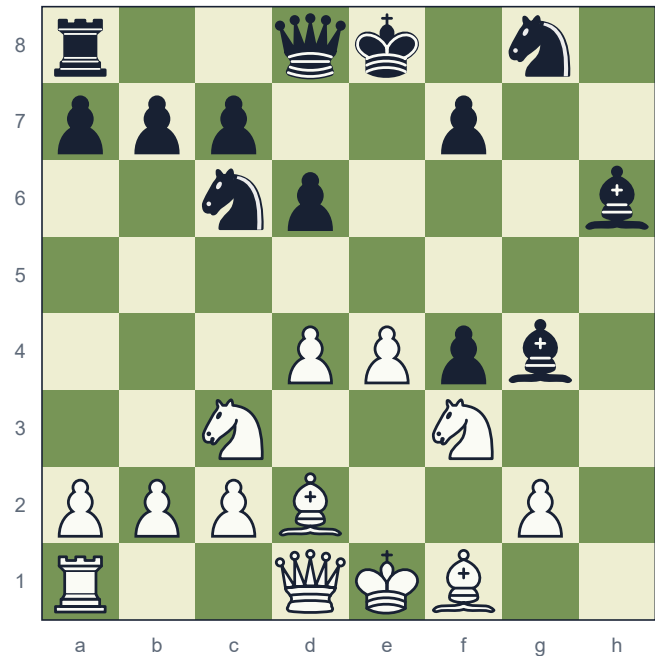
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 g5 4. h4 h6 5. hxg5 Bg7 6. gxh6 Rxh6 7. Rxh6 Bxh6 8. d4 d6 9. Bd2 Bg4 10. Nc3 Nc6

Authored anchor ends after 5. hxg5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White captures on g5 immediately, testing the supporting pawn chain before building d4. The exact recapture matters because the h-file and rook on h8 can become tactically relevant.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Follow the printed continuation and finish development. Recount material after the whole exchange rather than assuming every pawn contact has an automatic recapture.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black may develop with ...Bg7 or use the center. A careless capture can open a rook line against an undeveloped position.

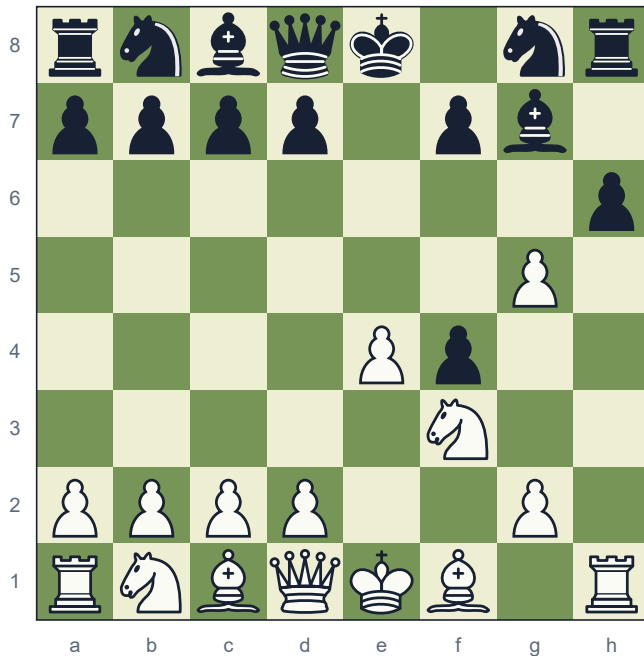
REMEMBER Calculate the h-file before choosing the recapture.

KG-05 / Black develops the bishop early

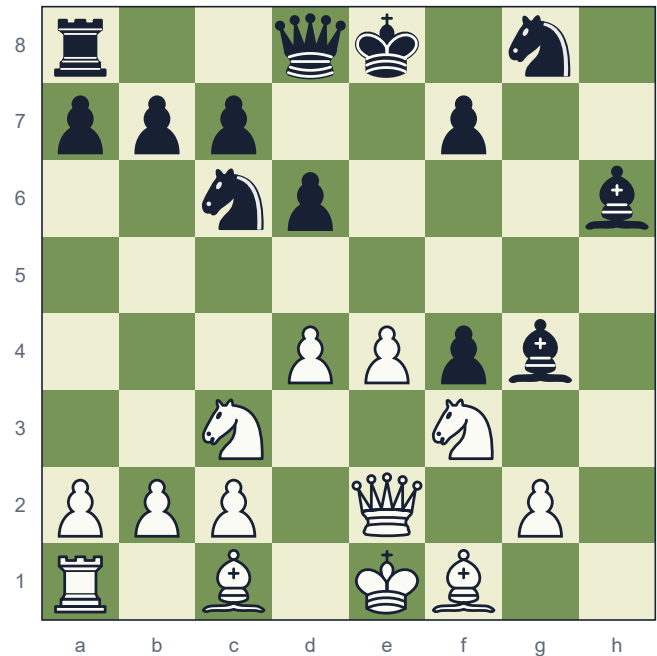
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 g5 4. h4 Bg7 5. hxg5 h6 6. gxh6 Rxh6 7. Rxh6 Bxh6 8. Nc3 d6 9. Qe2 Nc6 10. d4 Bg4

Authored anchor ends after 6. gxh6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White's h-pawn captures on g5 and then on h6, removing two supporting pawns. The resulting position requires exact material accounting and a development plan.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the center and bishops, then choose king safety. Compare the pressure on the advanced h6 pawn with the usefulness of opening the h-file.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black's g7 bishop and f4 pawn remain active factors. A pawn on h6 is not itself a mating attack.

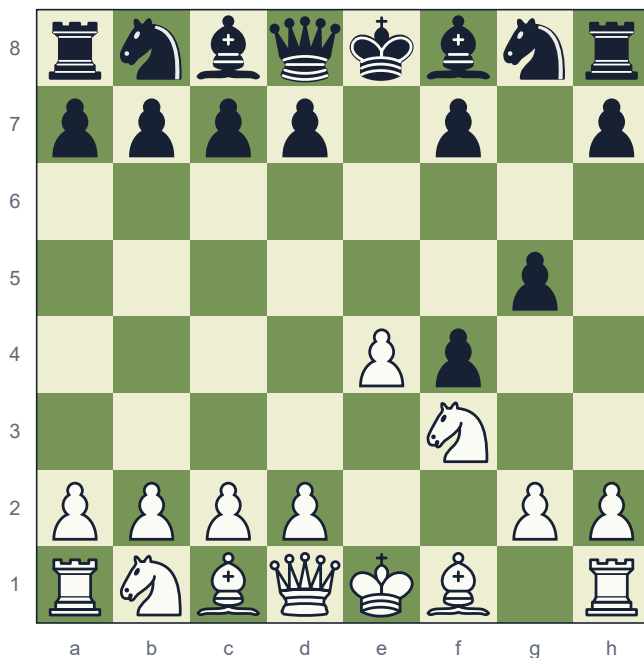
REMEMBER Track a pawn's new file after every capture.

KG-06 / Quiet alternative: the Vienna-style approach

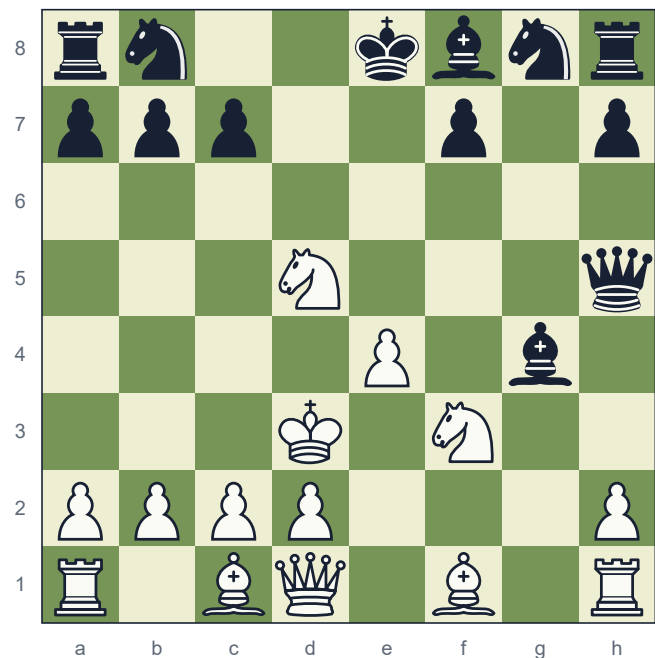
OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 g5 4. Nc3 g4 5. Ne5 d5 6. Nxd5 Qh4+ 7. Ke2 f3+ 8. gxf3 gxf3+ 9. Kd3 Qh5 10. Nxf3 Bg4

Authored anchor ends after 4. Nc3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Nc3 develops instead of immediately challenging g5. It protects e4 but permits Black to expand; this is an optional comparison, not the main h4 repertoire.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Meet threats to Nf3 concretely and use d4 when supported. Compare the resulting position with the h4 lines before choosing this alternative for real games.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A quick ...g4 gains a tempo against the knight. Quiet development does not make the advanced pawn chain disappear.

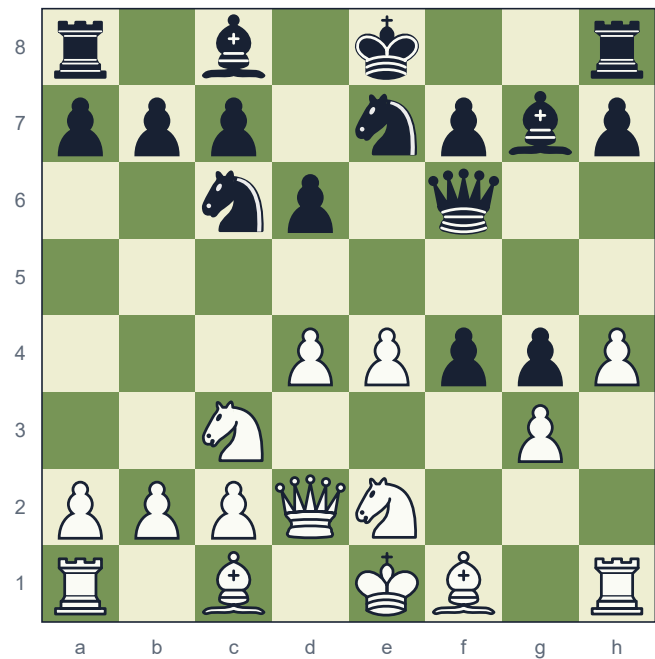
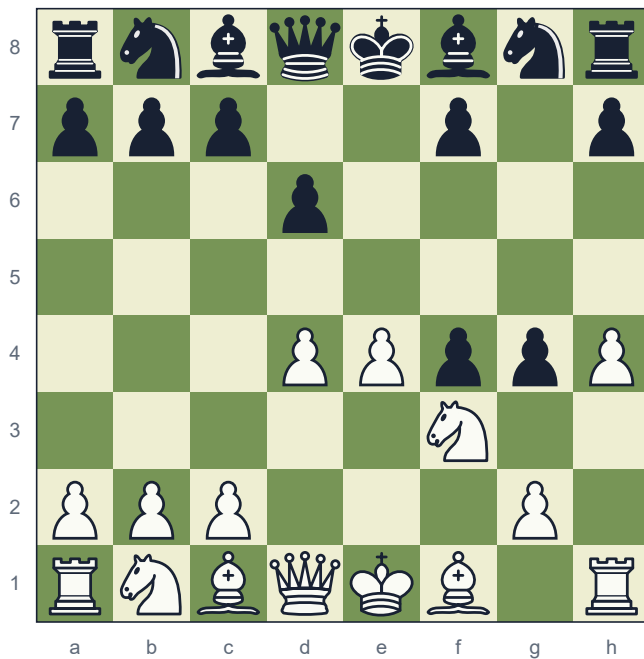
REMEMBER A development move can concede a forcing pawn tempo.

KG-07 / Fischer Defense: build the center

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 d6 4. d4 g5 5. h4 g4 6. Ng1 Qf6 7. Nc3 Ne7 8. Nge2 Bh6 9. Qd2 Nbc6 10. g3 Bg7

Authored anchor ends after 6. Ng1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

Black's ...d6 controls e5, so the Kieseritzky knight jump is unavailable. Ng1 is a deliberate retreat preserving the knight after the g-pawn advance.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Use the broad center and develop the bishops. The knight must return to play, often through e2 or h3 according to the concrete line.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Playing Ne5 as if ...d6 were absent simply leaves the knight vulnerable. Black also threatens to complete development while you spend another knight tempo.

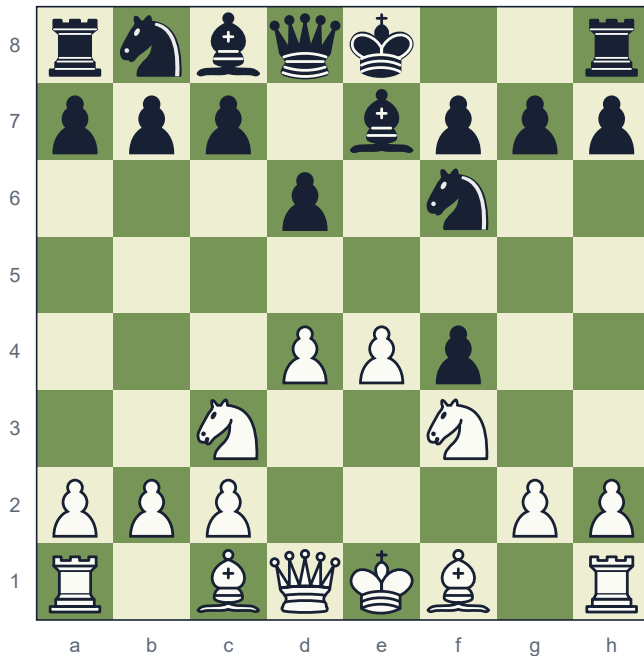
REMEMBER ...d6 changes the knight's retreat square.

KG-08 / Fischer Defense: Black develops first

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 d6 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nc3 Be7 6. Bxf4 O-O 7. Bd3 Nc6 8. a3 Bg4 9. Be3 Bh5 10. O-O Ng4

Authored anchor ends after 6... O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black returns the extra pawn to develop smoothly. White obtains a center and normal pieces, but should not expect a forced attack.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Choose Bd3 or Be2, castle and reinforce e4. A central break may be more useful than an early kingside pawn storm.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can challenge the center with ...d5 or ...c5. An undefended e4 pawn can become the target of ...Nxe4 tactics.

REMEMBER If the pawn is returned, play the resulting position.

Work through KG-01

7. ND3

Places the knight on d3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

8. BXF4

The bishop captures a pawn on f4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

9. NC3

Places the knight on c3, attacking knight on e4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

10. BE2

Places the bishop on e2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Nf3 prevents an immediate queen check on h4. Black uses ...g5 to keep f4, so h4 attacks the supporting chain. After ...g4 the knight must move; Ne5 takes an active central post. Develop Bc4 or d4 according to Black's reply, then solve king safety. The h-file may open for either side; do not assume the rook alone creates an attack.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Accepted: central and developing defenses

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

KG-09 - Black exchanges central pawns and develops toward the returned material. Bc4 creates pressure while White builds a useful d4 center.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Castle, develop Nc3 and decide whether the f4 pawn is worth a separate tempo. A lead in development is valuable only if the pieces have targets.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

Black can exchange pieces and neutralize the initiative. Do not sacrifice more material merely because the opening began as a gambit.

RECOGNITION TEST

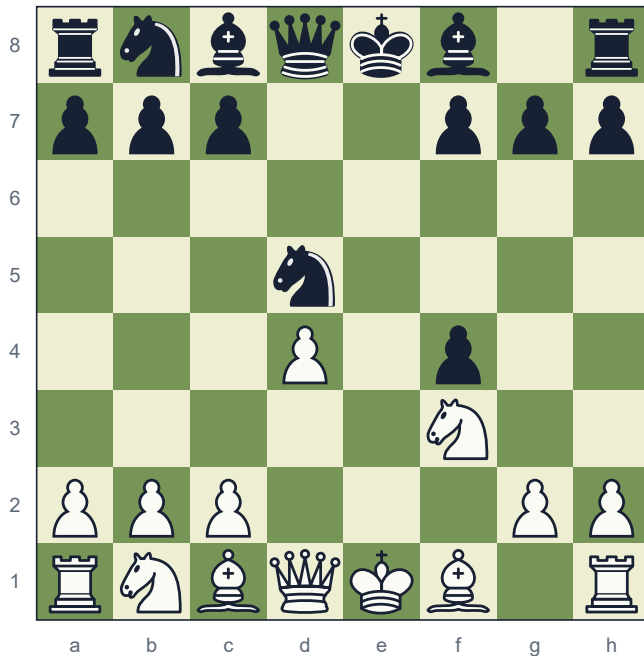
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

KG-09 / Modern Defense: ...d5 at once

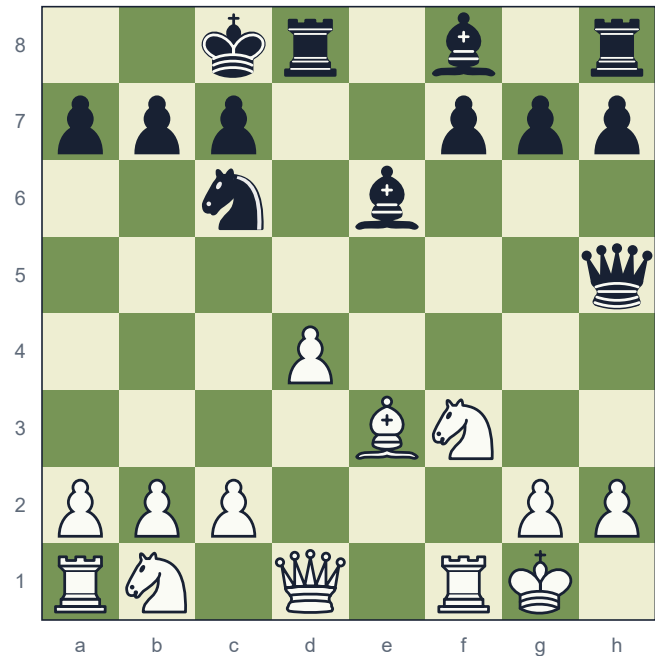
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 d5 4. exd5 Nf6 5. d4 Nxd5 6. Bc4 Be6 7. Bxd5 Qxd5 8. O-O Nc6 9. Bxf4 O-O-O 10. Be3 Qh5

Authored anchor ends after 6. Bc4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black exchanges central pawns and develops toward the returned material. Bc4 creates pressure while White builds a useful d4 center.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Castle, develop Nc3 and decide whether the f4 pawn is worth a separate tempo. A lead in development is valuable only if the pieces have targets.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can exchange pieces and neutralize the initiative. Do not sacrifice more material merely because the opening began as a gambit.

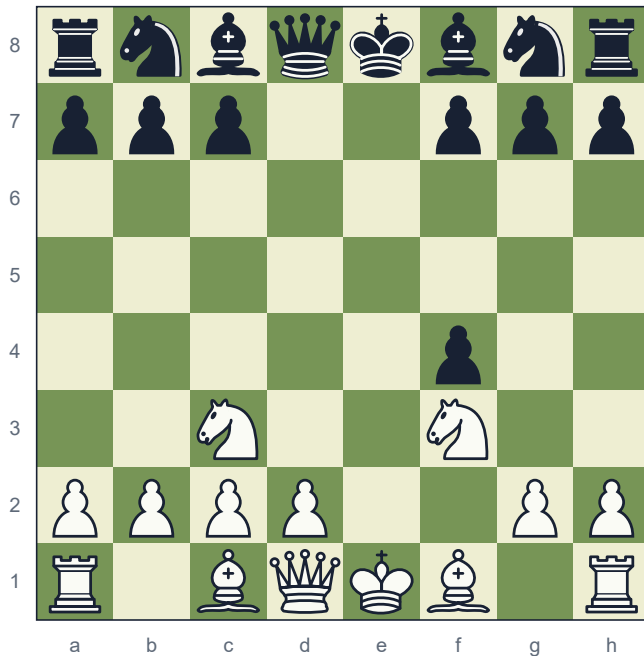
REMEMBER Central counterplay can matter more than retaining the extra pawn.

KG-10 / Modern Defense: the queen recaptures

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 d5 4. exd5 Qxd5 5. Nc3 Qd8 6. d4 Bd6 7. Bc4 Bf5 8. O-O Nc6 9. Nb5 Nge7 10. Nh4 Be6

Authored anchor ends after 6. d4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Nc3 develops while attacking the queen. After her retreat White has gained time, but still needs to complete development and address f4.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Bring out the bishops, castle and keep the central pawns supported. The extra developing tempo should become piece activity rather than premature queen moves.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A queen chased once is not trapped. Black can catch up if White spends several moves trying to hunt it.

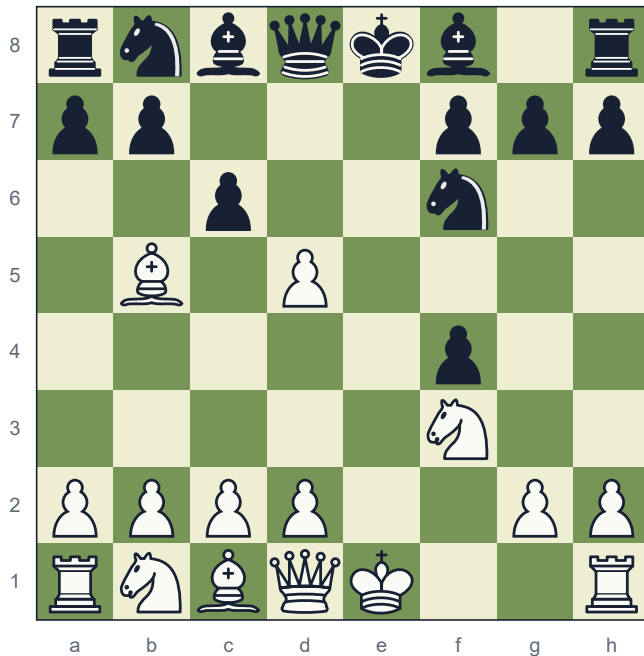
REMEMBER Gain a tempo and spend it on development.

KG-11 / Abbazia: an early pawn exchange

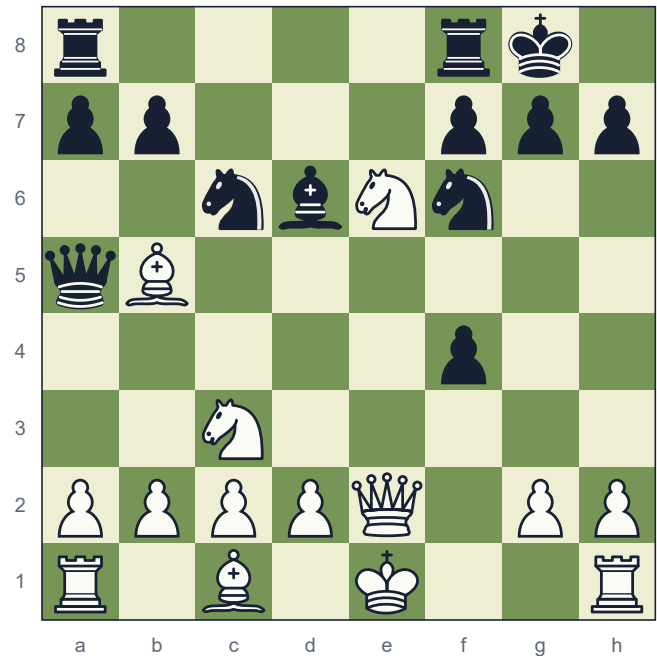
OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 d5 4. exd5 Nf6 5. Bb5+ c6 6. dxc6 Nxc6 7. Nc3 Bd6 8. Qe2+ Be6 9. Ng5 O-O 10. Nxe6 Qa5

Authored anchor ends after 6... Nxc6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The checking bishop invites ...c6, after which exchanges accelerate Black's development too. This optional branch teaches why a check is not necessarily a gain of time.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Withdraw the bishop safely when attacked and establish d4 if the position permits. Compare activity and king safety before claiming a material gain.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black's knights have natural central squares and open lines. Taking more pawns can leave White behind in development.

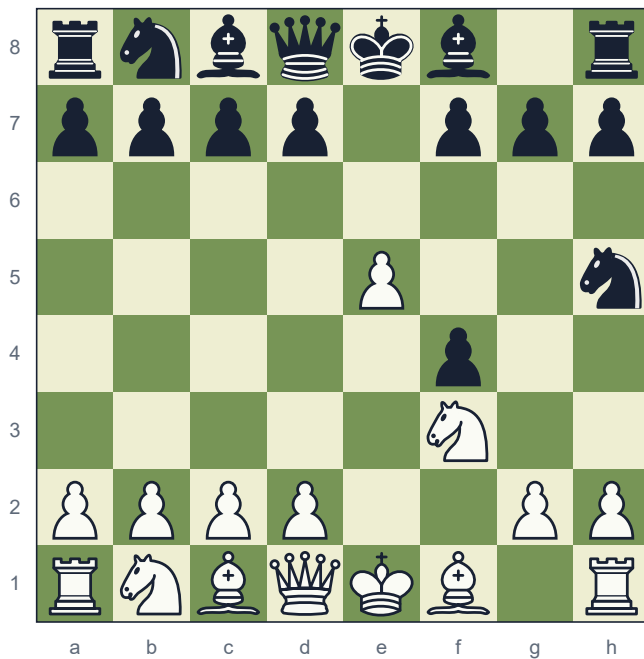
REMEMBER A check can help the defender develop.

KG-12 / Schallop Defense

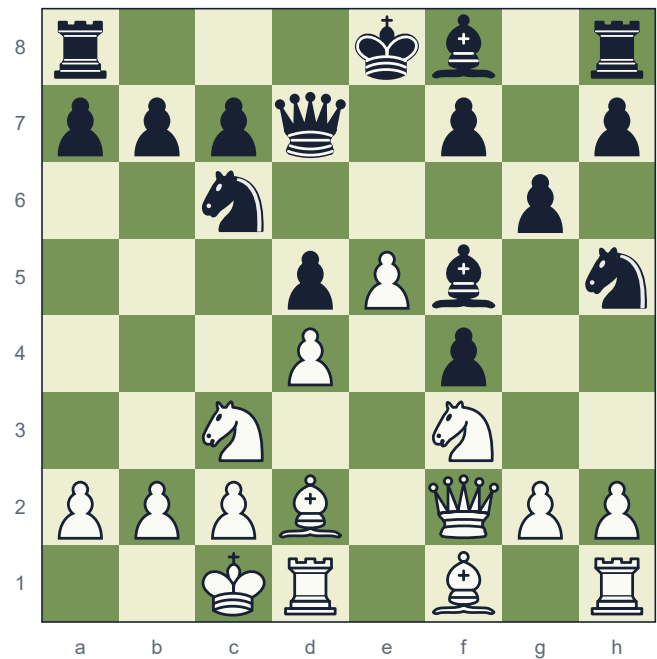
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e5 Nh5 5. d4 d6 6. Qe2 d5 7. Nc3 Nc6 8. Bd2 Bf5 9. O-O-O Qd7 10. Qf2 g6

Authored anchor ends after 5... d6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

e5 attacks the knight, which heads to h5 to help preserve f4. Black challenges the advanced e-pawn with ...d6.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop Bc4 or Bd3 as appropriate and examine exd6 only after considering the recapture. White must maintain central support while the knight is offside.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

The h5 knight still influences f4 and g3. Do not push g4 without calculating ...fxg3 en passant when legal and the effect on king safety.

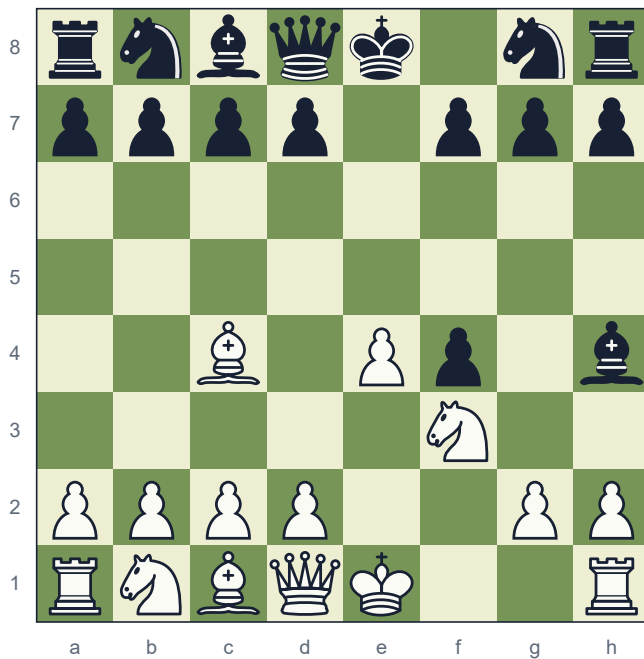
REMEMBER An offside knight may still perform a concrete defensive job.

KG-13 / Cunningham: meet the bishop check

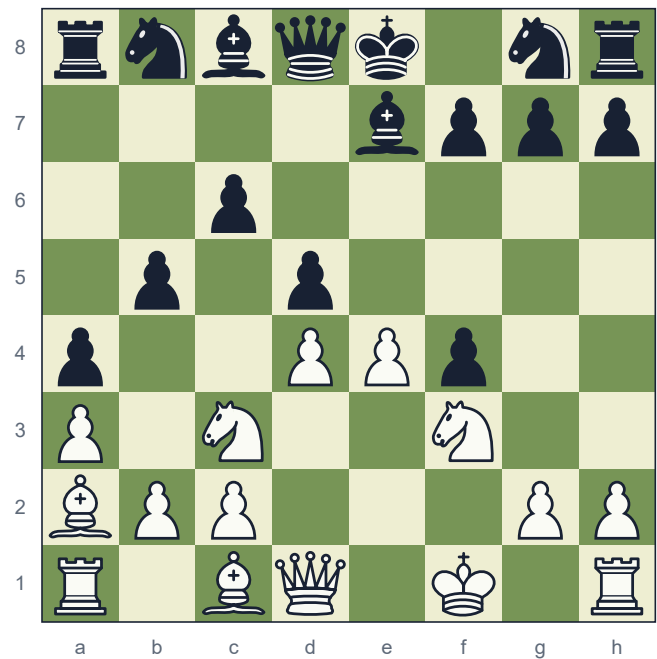
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 Be7 4. Bc4 Bh4+ 5. Kf1 c6 6. Nc3 b5 7. Bb3 a5 8. a3 Be7 9. d4 a4 10. Ba2 d5

Authored anchor ends after 5. Kf1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move - in check



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The bishop reaches h4 with check along the diagonal to e1. Kf1 answers it without pushing more kingside pawns, but permanently gives up castling.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop d4, Nc3 and the queen bishop while finding a safe place for the king. Treat rook coordination as a task; castling is no longer available.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can open the center with ...d5. Do not continue a routine castling plan after the king has moved.

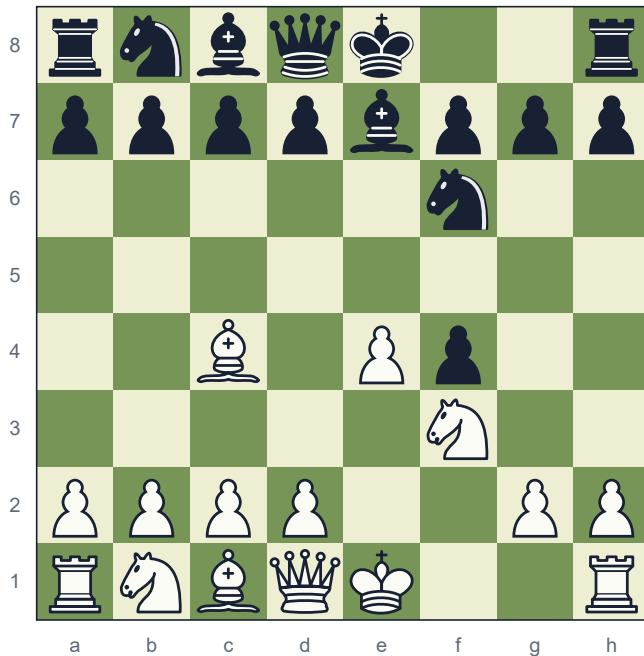
REMEMBER Surviving the check changes the whole king-safety plan.

KG-14 / Cunningham: Black chooses ...Nf6

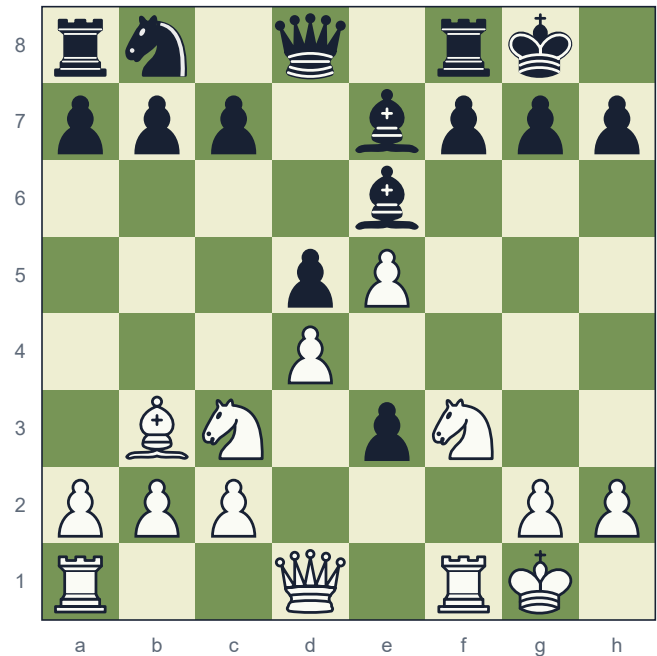
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 Be7 4. Bc4 Nf6 5. e5 Ng4 6. O-O O-O 7. d4 d5 8. Bb3 Ne3 9. Bxe3 fxe3 10. Nc3 Be6

Authored anchor ends after 5... Ng4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White gains space with e5 and Black places the knight actively. The g4 knight can create threats against e5 or f2; its location is more important than a general developing rule.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Use d4 and careful development. Before castling, check the tactical relation between the knight, the f-pawn deficit and the bishop on c4.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Bxf7+ is not automatically sound. Black's king may survive while your pieces lack support.

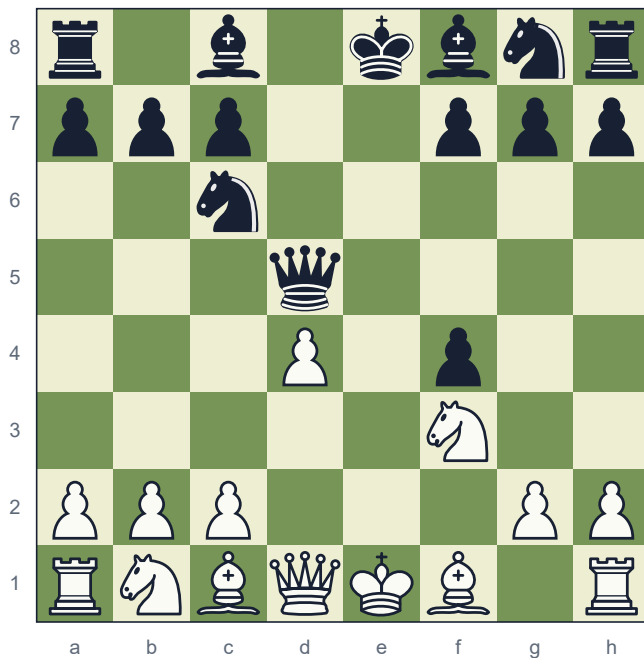
REMEMBER Count attackers and defenders on f2 as well as f7.

KG-15 / The ...Nc6 developing defense

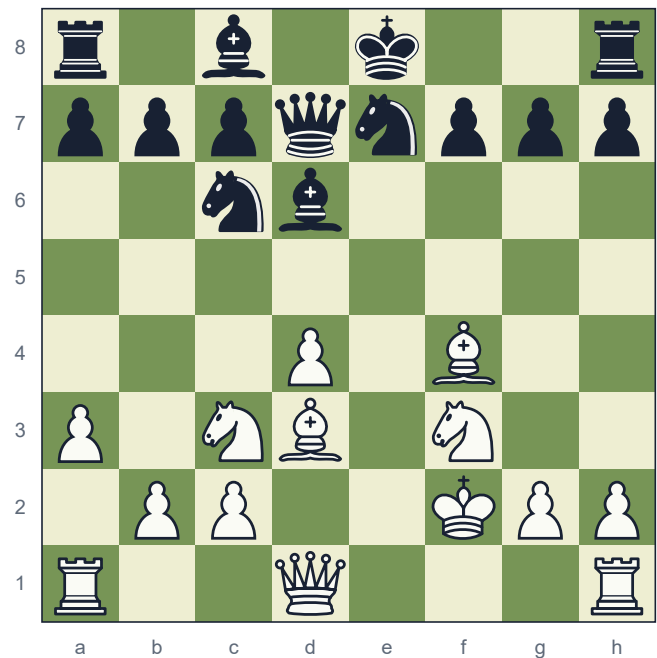
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 Nc6 4. d4 d5 5. exd5 Qxd5 6. Nc3 Bb4 7. Bd3 Qe6+ 8. Kf2 Nge7 9. Bxf4 Qd7 10. a3 Bd6

Authored anchor ends after 6. Nc3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black develops and then hits the center. Nc3 gains a queen tempo, but the exchanges also release Black's pieces.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Complete development and compare queen retreats before choosing a bishop square. A broad center is useful only while it remains defended.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can answer a threat with a check or a capture. Verify the queen's active squares before assuming a free attack.

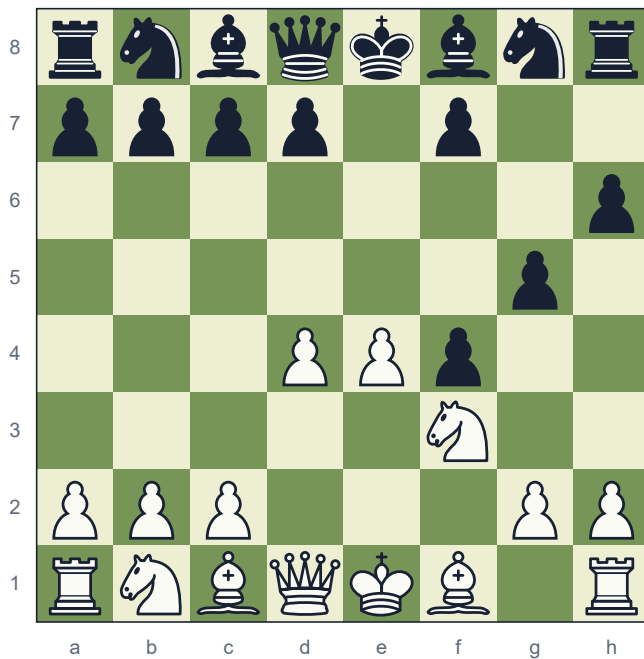
REMEMBER Development with tempo must still be tactically safe.

KG-16 / The ...h6 waiting move

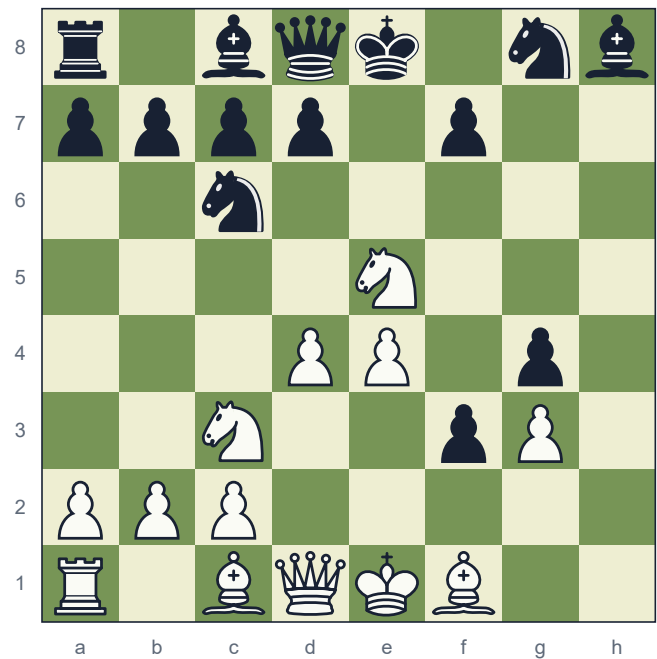
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 h6 4. d4 g5 5. h4 Bg7 6. hxg5 hxg5 7. Rxh8 Bxh8 8. g3 Nc6 9. Nc3 g4 10. Ne5 f3

Authored anchor ends after 5. h4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black prepares to hold f4 with ...g5. White places d4 before challenging the supporting pawns. This reaches familiar themes by a different order.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Follow the h-file exchanges carefully and use the center to keep pieces active. Identify whether e5 remains available to your knight before responding to ...g4.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

...d6 changes that availability; ...Nf6 changes the pressure on e4. Do not memorize the knight jump independently of those moves.

REMEMBER Match the position, not just the opening name.

Work through KG-09

7. BXD5

The bishop captures a knight on d5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

8. O-O

Moves the king toward shelter and brings a rook toward the center. Check the resulting open lines before assuming the king is safe.

9. BXF4

The bishop captures a pawn on f4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

10. BE3

Places the bishop on e3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Black exchanges central pawns and develops toward the returned material. Bc4 creates pressure while White builds a useful d4 center. Castle, develop Nc3 and decide whether the f4 pawn is worth a separate tempo. A lead in development is valuable only if the pieces have targets.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Declined and countergambits

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

KG-17 - White uses c3 to support d4 while the bishop keeps pressure on the king side. Exchanging in the center gives White space but opens lines.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Develop the bishops, castle and keep the d4-e4 center defended. Chase the bishop only when it improves the position, not just because it is visible.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

The c5-b6 bishop watches the sensitive f2 square. Capturing e5 at the wrong time may permit ...Qh4+ and a king attack.

RECOGNITION TEST

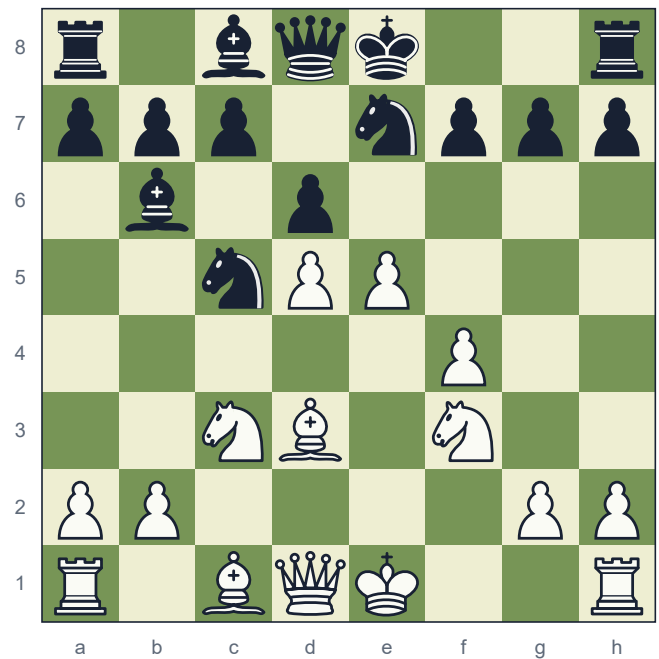
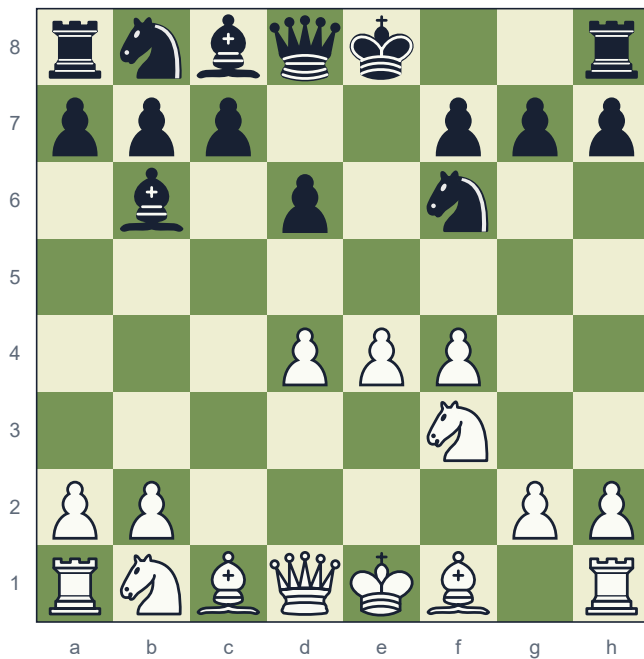
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

KG-17 / Classical Declined: ...Bc5

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 Bc5 3. Nf3 d6 4. c3 Nf6 5. d4 exd4 6. cxd4 Bb6 7. Nc3 Nc6 8. e5 Nd7 9. d5 Ne7 10. Bd3 Nc5

Authored anchor ends after 7. Nc3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

White uses c3 to support d4 while the bishop keeps pressure on the king side. Exchanging in the center gives White space but opens lines.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the bishops, castle and keep the d4-e4 center defended. Chase the bishop only when it improves the position, not just because it is visible.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

The c5-b6 bishop watches the sensitive f2 square. Capturing e5 at the wrong time may permit ...Qh4+ and a king attack.

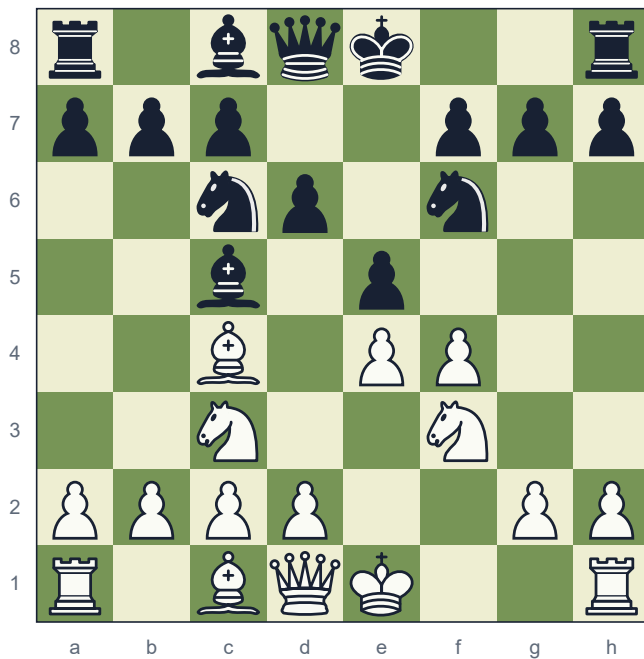
REMEMBER Respect the diagonal before taking e5.

KG-18 / Declined: ...Bc5 with ...Nc6

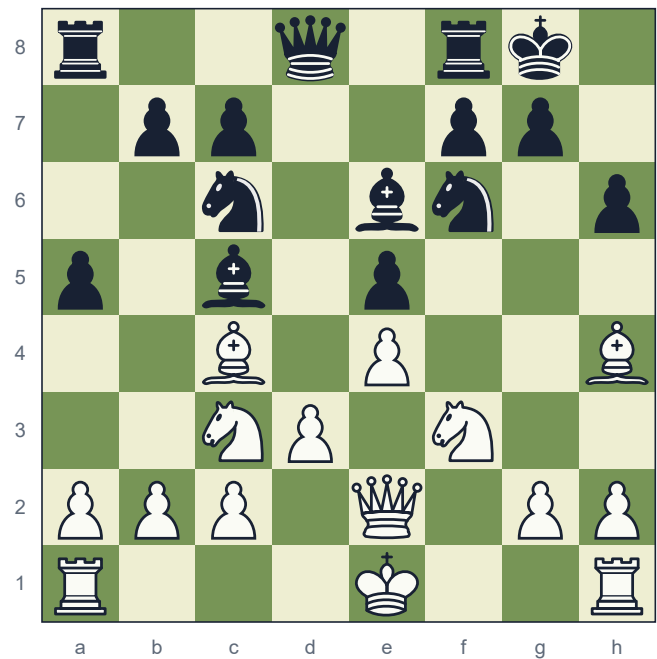
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 Bc5 3. Nf3 Nc6 4. Nc3 d6 5. Bc4 Nf6 6. d3 a5 7. fxe5 dxe5 8. Bg5 h6 9. Bh4 Be6 10. Qe2 O-O

Authored anchor ends after 6. d3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Both sides develop naturally. White keeps the option of a later f-pawn exchange without forcing an immediate central confrontation.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Castle, identify whether d4 is achievable and improve the least active piece. A quiet maneuvering game is a normal outcome of a gambit being declined.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can use ...Bg4 to pin Nf3 or open the center. Do not weaken the king with repeated pawn moves while pieces remain at home.

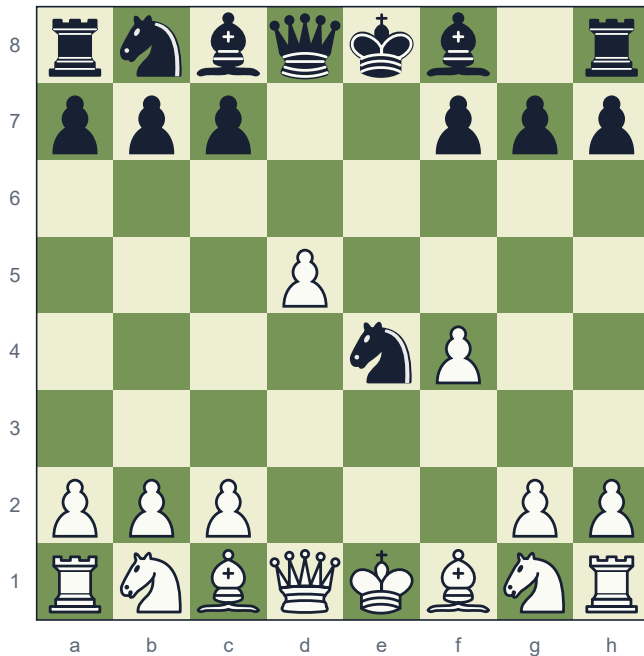
REMEMBER A declined gambit can become a normal development contest.

KG-19 / Falkbeer: the ...e4 wedge

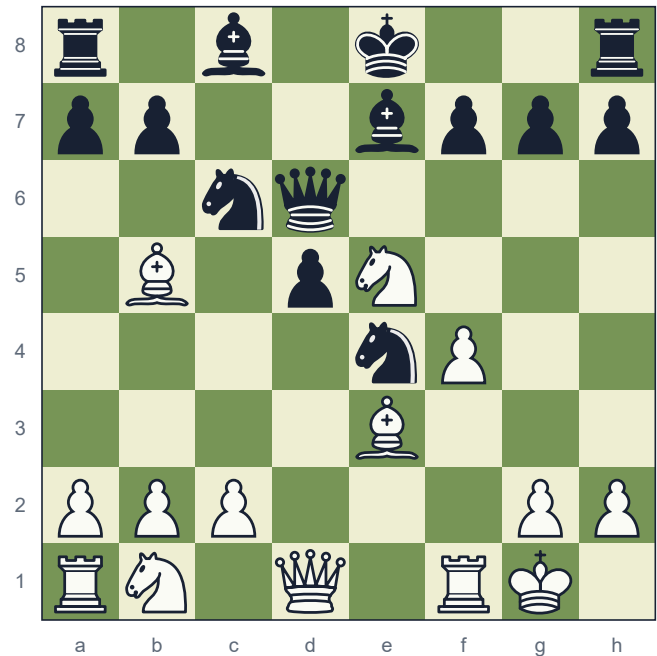
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 d5 3. exd5 e4 4. d3 Nf6 5. dxe4 Nxe4 6. Nf3 c6 7. Be3 cxd5 8. Bb5+ Nc6 9. O-O Be7 10. Ne5 Qd6

Authored anchor ends after 6. Nf3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black ignores the offered f-pawn and builds an advanced e4 wedge. d3 challenges it directly; exchanges change the position into a development battle.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the bishops and castle. Attack the central knight with useful moves only after checking tactics along the e-file.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black's development can be rapid and the king remains on e1. A greedy attempt to keep every extra pawn can allow a central attack.

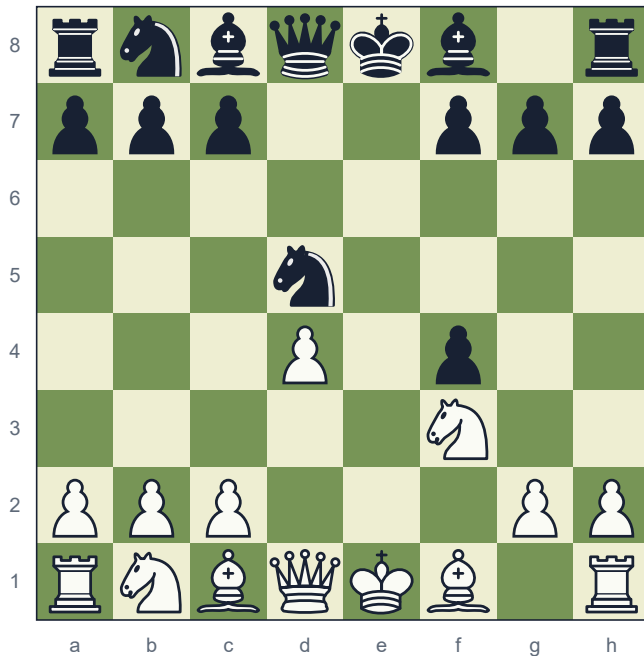
REMEMBER Challenge the wedge before it binds your pieces.

KG-20 / Falkbeer transposes to the Modern

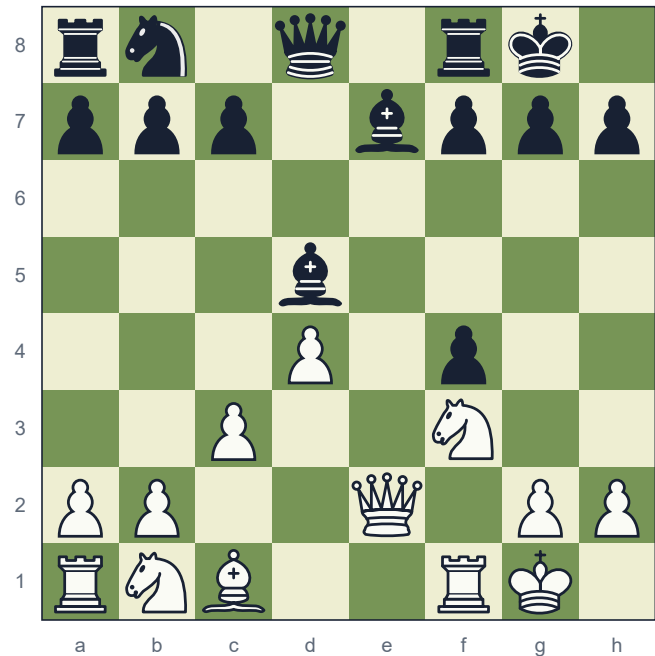
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 d5 3. exd5 exf4 4. Nf3 Nf6 5. d4 Nxd5 6. Bc4 Be6 7. Qe2 Bb4+ 8. c3 Be7 9. O-O O-O 10. Bxd5 Bxd5

Authored anchor ends after 6. Bc4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Capturing f4 after ...d5 produces the same type of position as the Modern Defense. The move order differs, but the central exchanges and piece tasks converge.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Use the Modern Defense plan: development, king safety and pressure on active targets. Link the two routes on your repertoire map to reduce memorization.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

An extra tempo or a different knight square can break a transposition. Compare the actual board before importing a memorized continuation.

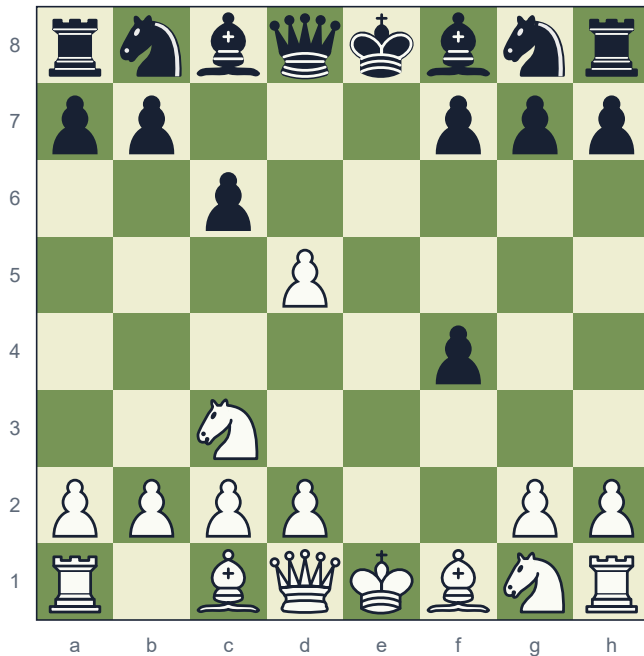
REMEMBER Transpose by position, including whose turn it is.

KG-21 / Falkbeer: ...c6 countergambit

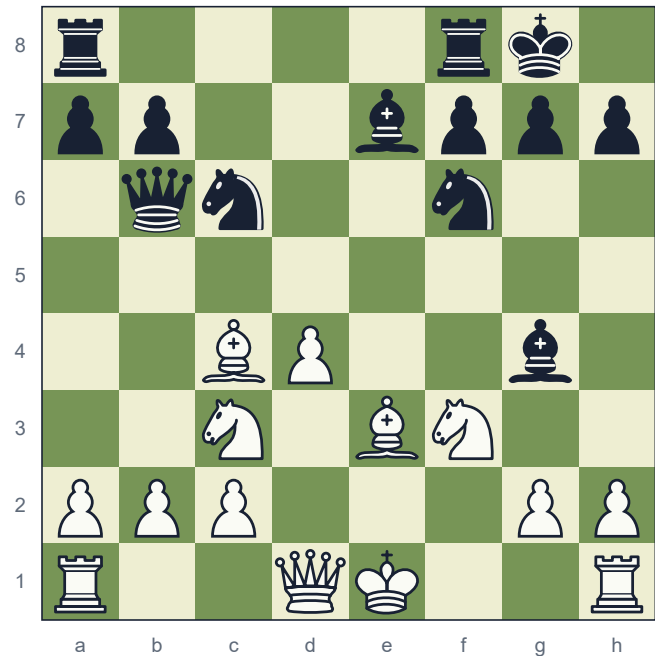
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 d5 3. exd5 c6 4. Nc3 exf4 5. Nf3 Be7 6. Bc4 Nf6 7. dxc6 Nxc6 8. d4 O-O 9. Bxf4 Bg4 10. Be3 Qb6

Authored anchor ends after 5. Nf3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White declines to spend another tempo taking a wing pawn and develops. Black sacrifices or returns material to obtain central and diagonal activity.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Stabilize the d-pawn if it is useful, otherwise let material return for development. Check the c-file and queen routes after any dxc6 capture.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Capturing c6 blindly can give Black easy development with ...Nxc6. The point is the resulting activity, not the label countergambit.

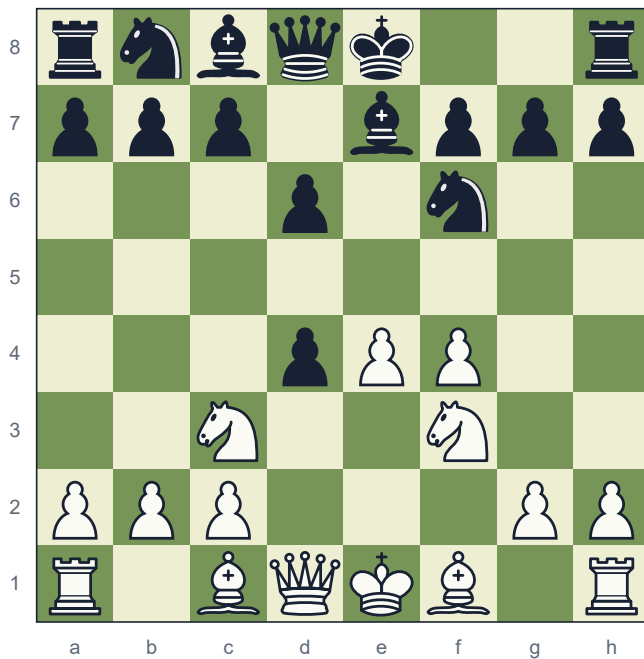
REMEMBER You do not have to accept a second gambit.

KG-22 / Declined with ...d6

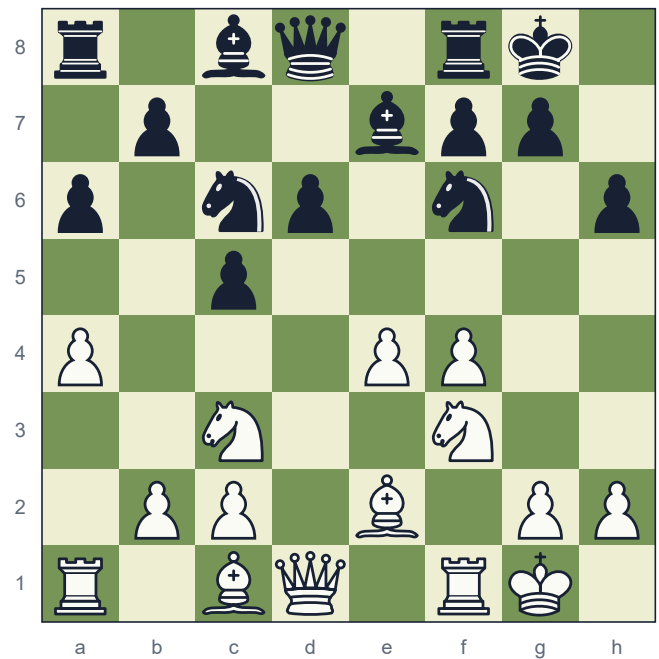
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 d6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Be7 5. d4 exd4 6. Nxd4 O-O 7. Be2 c5 8. Nf3 Nc6 9. O-O a6 10. a4 h6

Authored anchor ends after 6. Nxd4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black supports e5 and later exchanges it. White recaptures actively with the knight and gains space without an immediate sacrifice.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop a bishop, castle and decide whether f4-f5 or ordinary central pressure is justified. Keep the d4 knight safe from pawn attacks.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black's restrained setup can still strike with ...d5. Do not assume that a passive-looking opening removes tactical obligations.

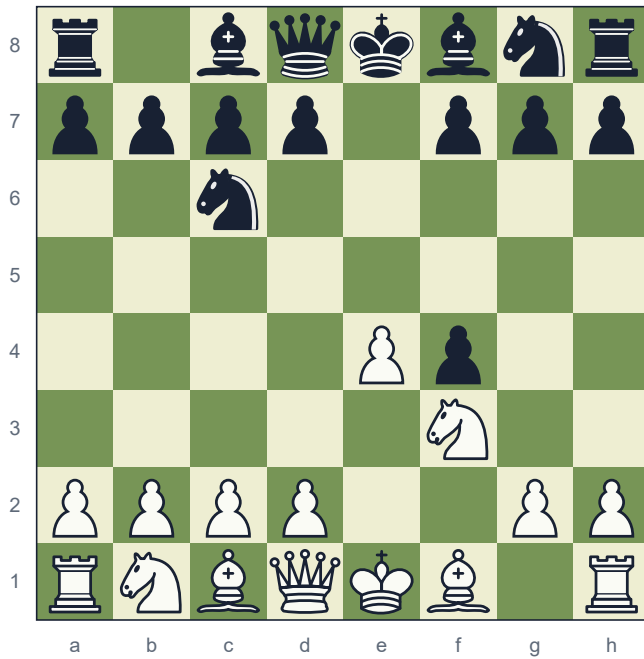
REMEMBER Gain space, then finish development.

KG-23 / Declined with ...Nc6

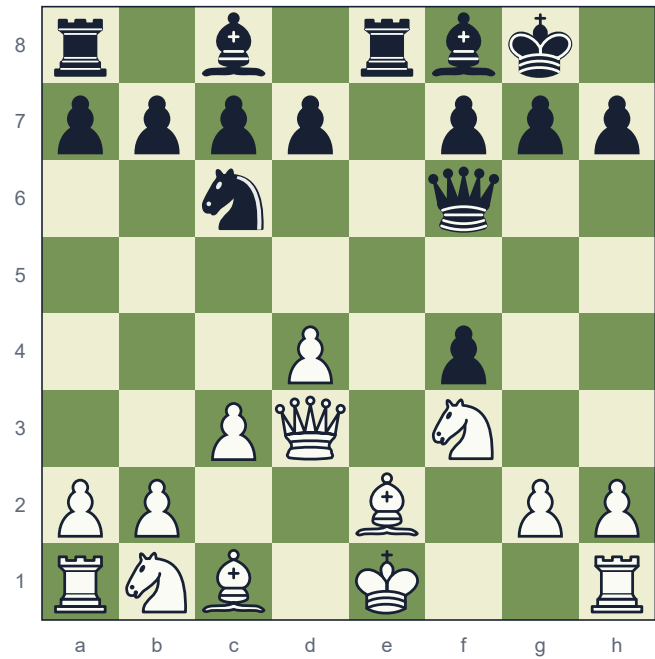
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 Nc6 3. Nf3 exf4 4. d4 Nf6 5. Qe2 Bd6 6. e5 O-O 7. Qd3 Re8 8. Be2 Bb4+ 9. c3 Bf8 10. exf6 Qxf6

Authored anchor ends after 4. d4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black may decline for one move and accept later. The position enters accepted-gambit territory with the queen knight already developed.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Track the pressure on d4 and e4, develop and answer ...g5 according to the actual center. A delayed capture changes available counterplay.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Memorizing only move two misses the transposition. Black may choose ...d5 before trying to defend f4.

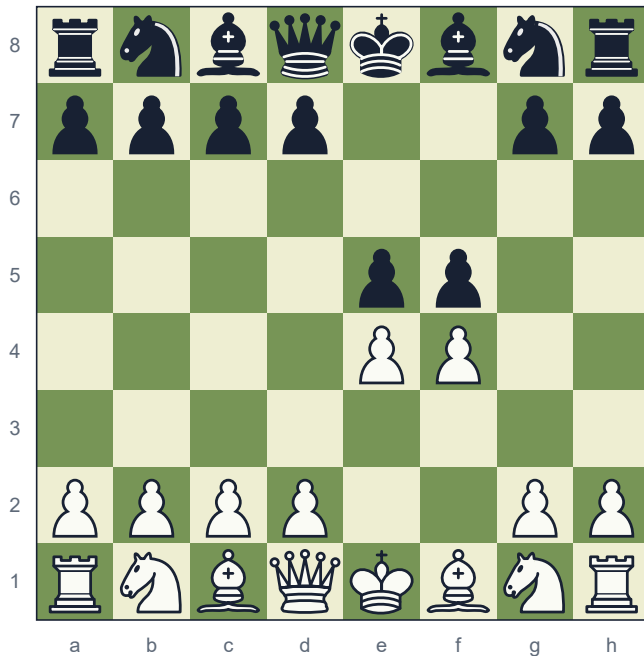
REMEMBER The opening can change family a move later.

KG-24 / The ...f5 countergambit

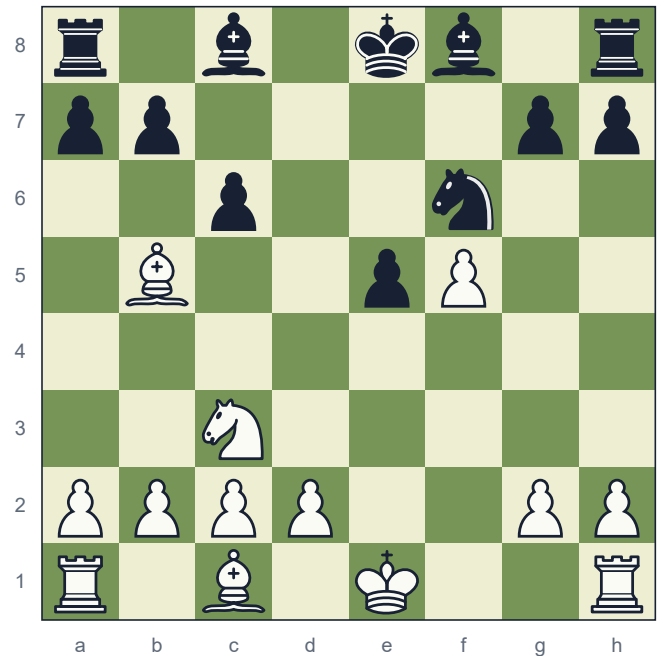
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 f5 3. exf5 Qe7 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Nc3 Nf6 6. fxe5 Nxe5 7. Nxe5 Qxe5+ 8. Qe2 d6 9. Qxe5+ dxe5 10. Bb5+ c6

Authored anchor ends after 3. exf5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Capturing e5 is not the only way to respond to Black's central pawn action. exf5 exchanges the advanced f-pawn and leaves a concrete position to calculate.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop Nf3 and choose d4 when safe. Study Black's checks and central captures before treating the extra pawn as secure.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

The exposed kings and open diagonals make routine moves unreliable. A queen check can be more urgent than recovering another pawn.

REMEMBER Against countergambits, check forcing moves first.

Work through KG-17

7. NC3

Develops toward d5 and e4. Compare its central influence with the fact that it blocks the c-pawn.

8. E5

Places the pawn on e5, attacking knight on f6. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

9. D5

Places the pawn on d5, attacking knight on c6. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

10. BD3

Places the bishop on d3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

White uses c3 to support d4 while the bishop keeps pressure on the king side. Exchanging in the center gives White space but opens lines. Develop the bishops, castle and keep the d4-e4 center defended. Chase the bishop only when it improves the position, not just because it is visible.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Alternatives and repertoire boundaries

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

KG-25 - Bc4 develops before Nf3 and therefore permits the queen check. Kf1 preserves the center but gives up castling. This is an alternative to learn after the main repertoire.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Develop Nf3 with a tempo against the queen if the position allows, then build d4 and coordinate the rook manually.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

An exposed king can be attacked through the center even if the queen retreats. Do not equate a queen tempo with complete compensation.

RECOGNITION TEST

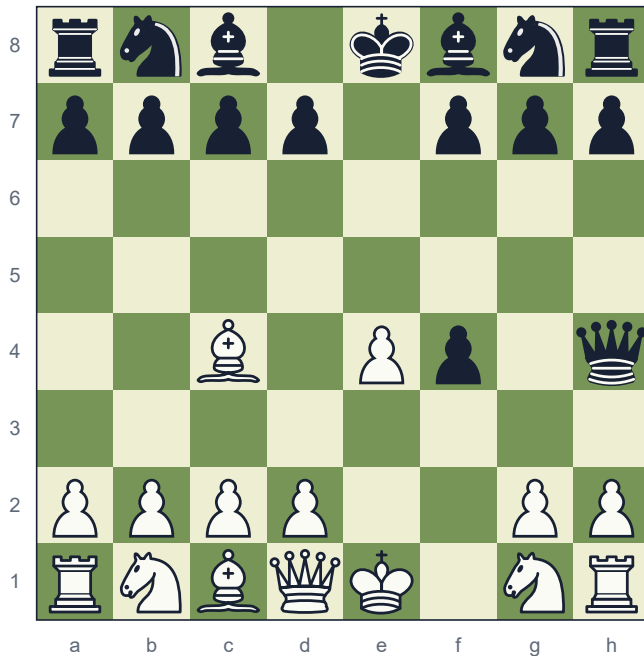
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

KG-25 / Bishop's Gambit: optional route

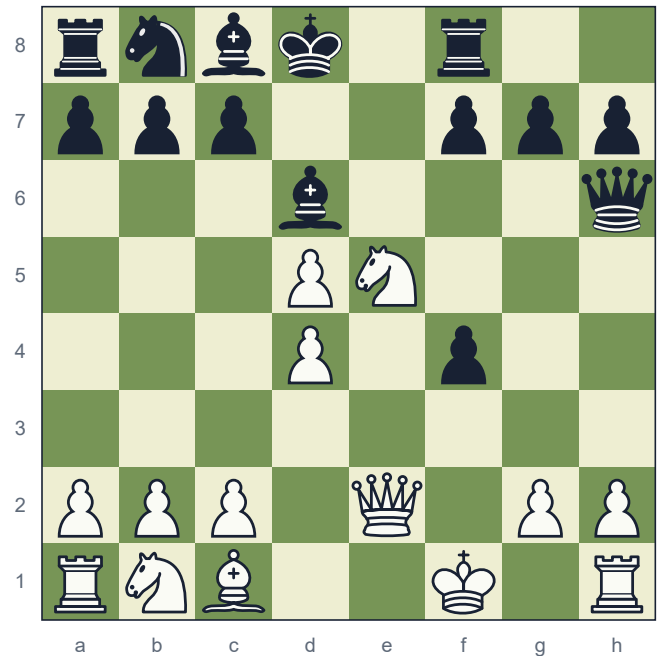
OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Bc4 Qh4+ 4. Kf1 d5 5. Bxd5 Nf6 6. Nf3 Qh6 7. d4 Nxd5 8. exd5 Bd6 9. Qe2+ Kd8 10. Ne5 Rf8

Authored anchor ends after 4. Kf1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move - in check



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Bc4 develops before Nf3 and therefore permits the queen check. Kf1 preserves the center but gives up castling. This is an alternative to learn after the main repertoire.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop Nf3 with a tempo against the queen if the position allows, then build d4 and coordinate the rook manually.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

An exposed king can be attacked through the center even if the queen retreats. Do not equate a queen tempo with complete compensation.

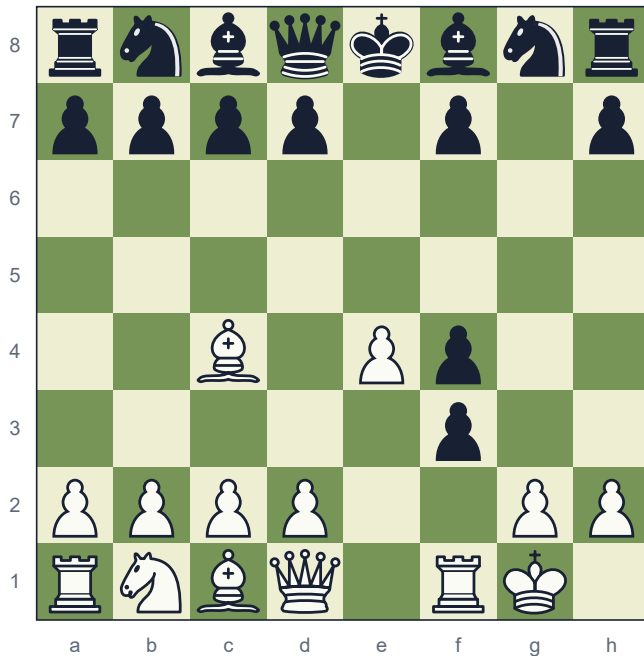
REMEMBER Bc4 first permits the check Nf3 would prevent.

KG-26 / Muzio: understand the sacrifice

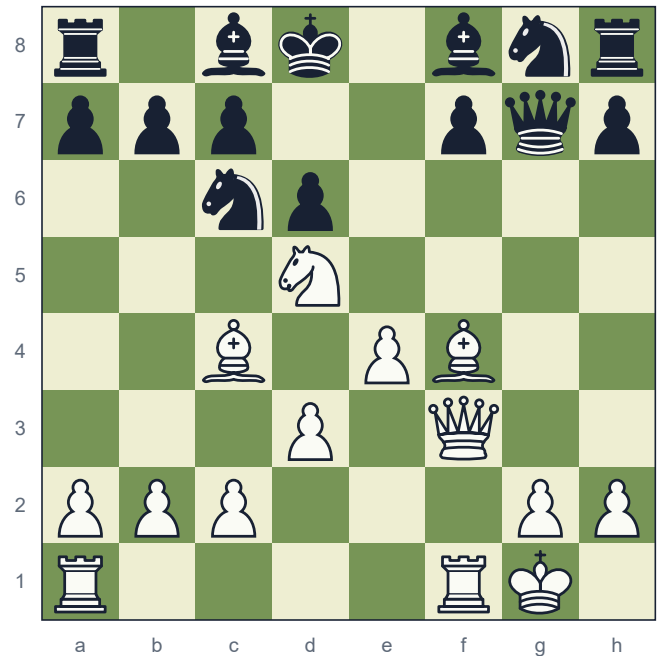
OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 g5 4. Bc4 g4 5. O-O gxf3 6. Qxf3 Qf6 7. d3 Nc6 8. Bxf4 d6 9. Nc3 Qg7 10. Nd5 Kd8

Authored anchor ends after 6. Qxf3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White deliberately gives a knight for rapid attacking development. This is a high-risk optional laboratory, not the recommended main repertoire for this course.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Calculate forcing play against f7 and e8 before making another sacrifice. Compare attack speed with Black's defensive resources and possible queen exchanges.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black need not cooperate with a famous mating pattern. If the attack stops, White is a piece down rather than merely a pawn down.

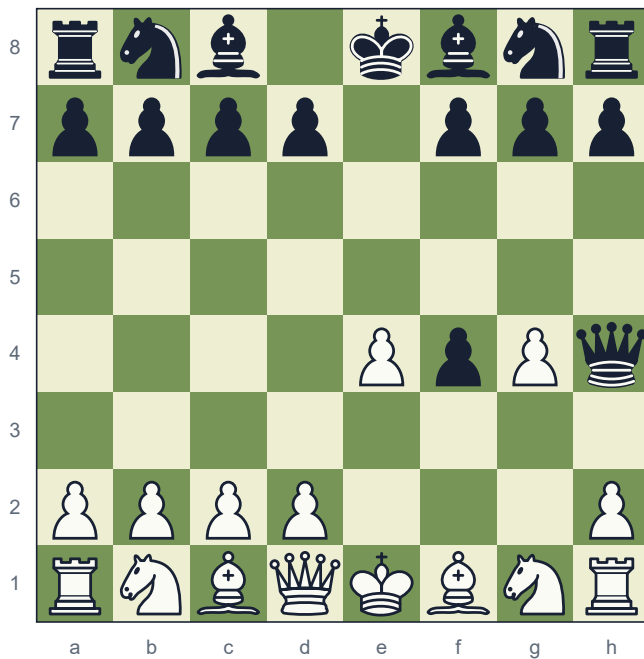
REMEMBER Distinguish a deliberate piece sacrifice from normal development.

KG-27 / Simple warning: the exposed king

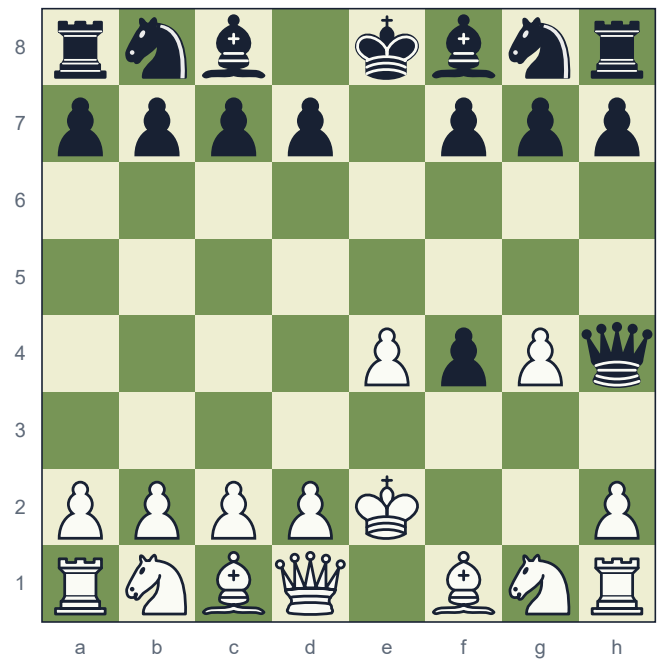
WARNING LINE - study the mistake

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. g4 Qh4+ 4. Ke2

The anchor is the complete printed sequence.



Before your decision - White to move - in check



End of study line - Black to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The queen check on h4 forces a serious king-safety concession. Ke2 is a legal escape, so this is not checkmate, but White has lost castling and exposed the king before developing.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Use this warning to learn why the main repertoire plays Nf3. Prove that Ke2 is legal, then explain why allowing the check was still a poor practical decision.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

The desire to chase f4 ignores the h4-e1 diagonal. A legal escape does not make the opening choice good.

REMEMBER Check the queen's diagonal before chasing a pawn.

KG-28 / If Black plays the French

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. exd5 exd5 4. Nf3 Nf6 5. Bd3 Bd6 6. O-O O-O 7. Bg5 Bg4 8. Nbd2 c5 9. c4 Nc6 10. dxc5 Bxc5

Authored anchor ends after 6... O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The King's Gambit requires ...e5. Against ...e6 this course offers a simple Exchange French bridge so you can reach a playable game without pretending to force the gambit.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the queen knight and bishop, then use the open e-file carefully. Study a separate French repertoire if this defense appears often in your games.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A symmetrical center does not mean a forced draw. Pins, attacks on h2 and h7, and central breaks still matter.

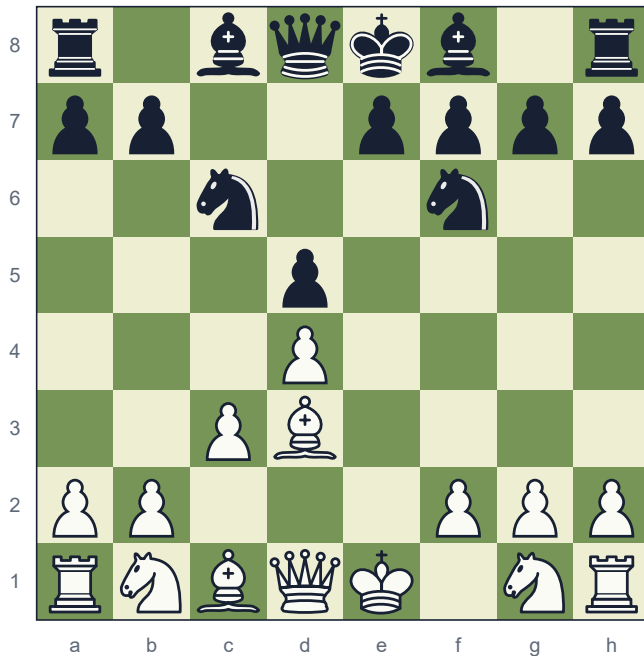
REMEMBER No ...e5 means no King's Gambit.

KG-29 / If Black plays the Caro-Kann

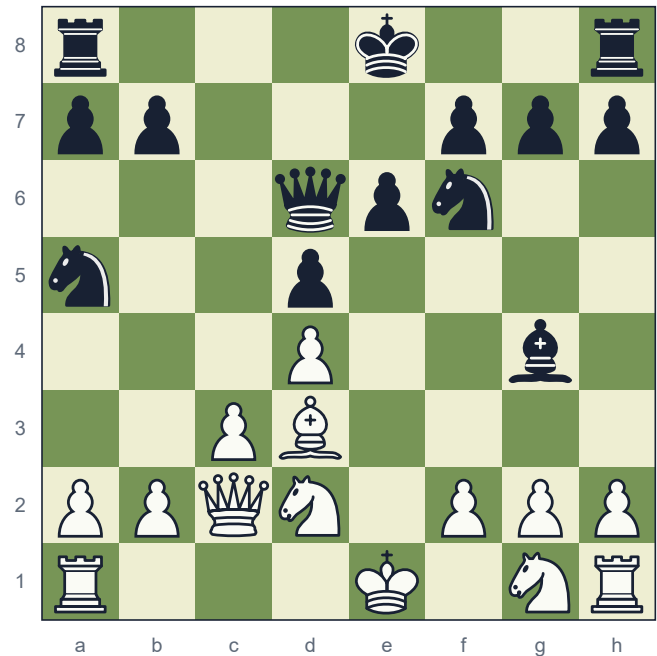
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. exd5 cxd5 4. Bd3 Nc6 5. c3 Nf6 6. Bf4 Bg4 7. Qb3 Na5 8. Qc2 e6 9. Nd2 Bd6 10. Bxd6 Qxd6

Authored anchor ends after 6. Bf4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The Exchange Caro-Kann bridge creates a clear pawn structure. Bf4 develops the queen bishop before e3 would block it.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Finish development and castle. Watch the c-file and choose a useful knight square without obstructing your own pieces.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can exchange the light-squared bishop or challenge the center. This is a companion starting line, not a complete Caro-Kann repertoire.

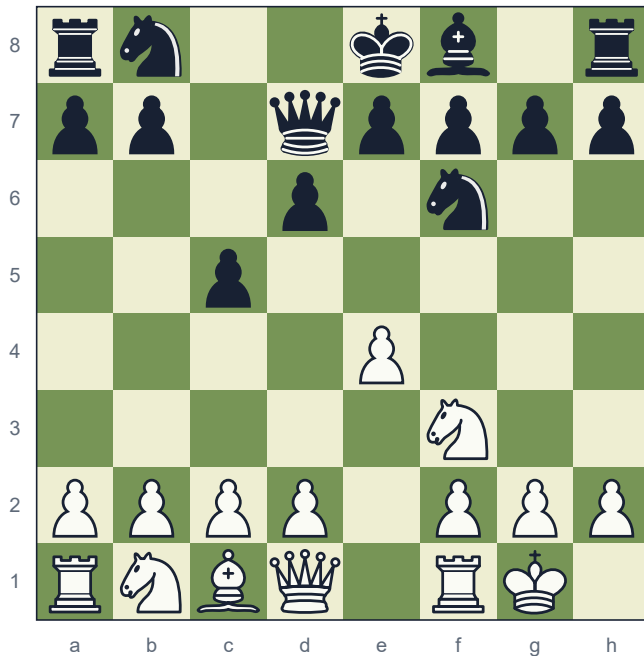
REMEMBER Choose a real response to Black's first move.

KG-30 / If Black plays the Sicilian

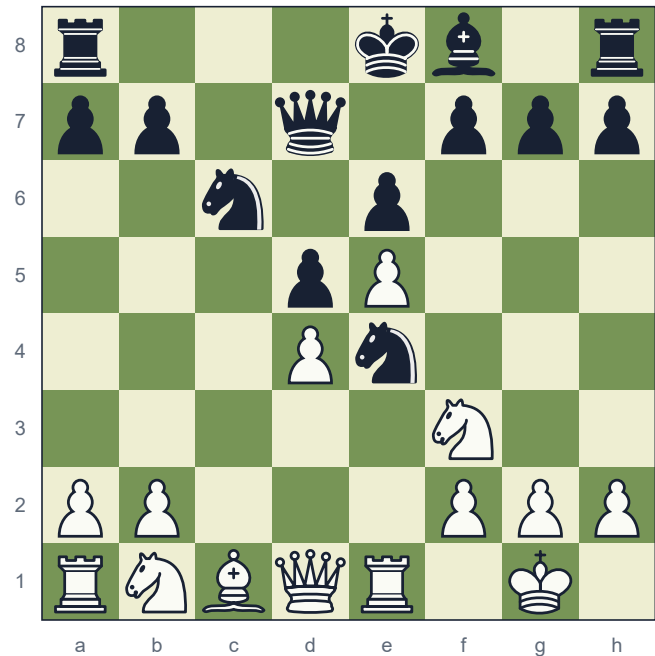
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. Bb5+ Bd7 4. Bxd7+ Qxd7 5. O-O Nf6 6. Re1 Nc6 7. c3 e6 8. d4 cxd4 9. cxd4 d5 10. e5 Ne4

Authored anchor ends after 6. Re1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Against ...d6 the check on b5 is a practical bridge. The bishop exchange simplifies development but gives up the bishop pair.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Build c3 and d4 if safe or choose d3 for a slower game. Against ...Nc6 or ...e6 use the separate bridge lessons in the study guide rather than forcing this exact check sequence.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black's queen recapture affects d4 and the d-file. This line cannot stand in for all Sicilian variations.

REMEMBER A bridge line has a defined move-order boundary.

KG-31 / If Black plays the Scandinavian

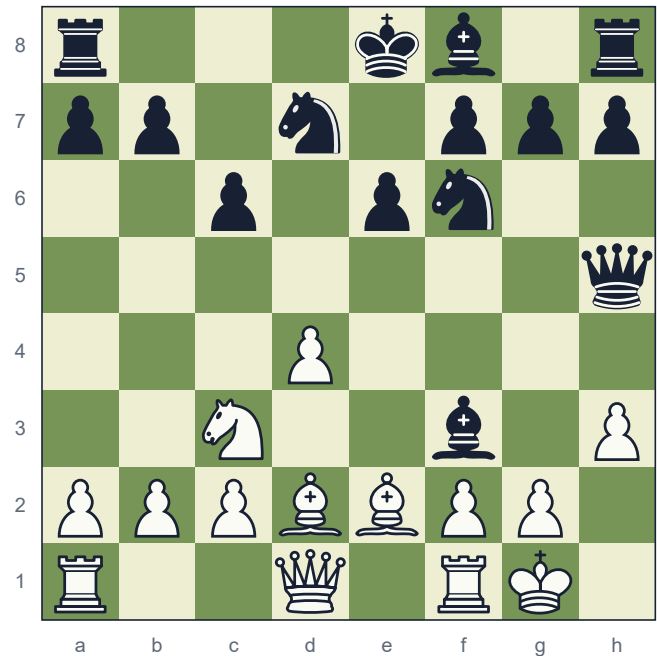
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bc4 Bg4 7. h3 Qh5 8. Be2 e6 9. Bd2 Nbd7 10. O-O Bxf3

Authored anchor ends after 6. Bc4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White gains a developing tempo against the queen and occupies the center. This normal response complements the gambit repertoire when Black immediately attacks e4.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Castle and develop the queen bishop, checking the a5-e1 diagonal before central tactics. Use your space rather than hunting the queen without purpose.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black often plays ...Bf5 and ...e6. A pin on the c3 knight can affect whether d4 is actually defended.

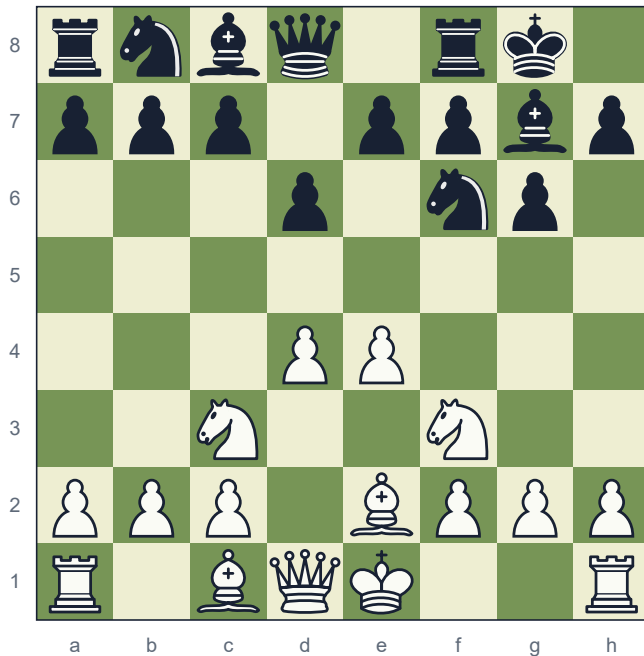
REMEMBER Meet a central challenge with development and calculation.

KG-32 / If Black plays a modern setup

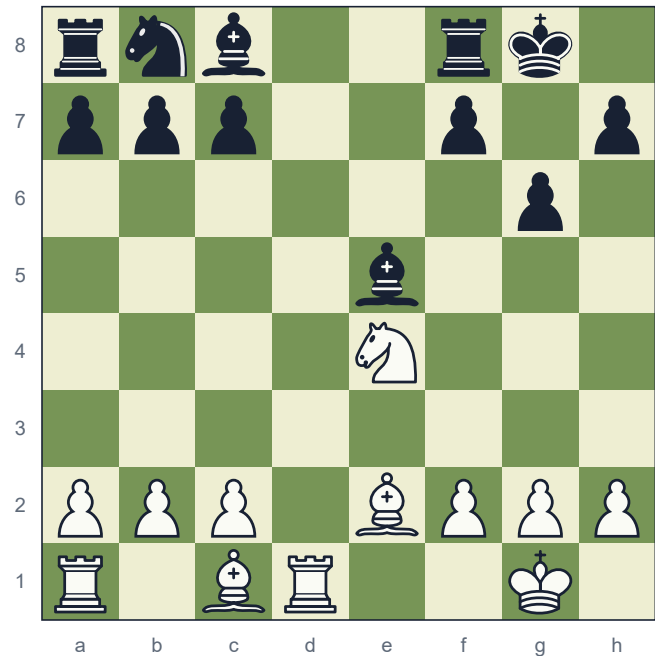
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 Nf6 5. Be2 O-O 6. O-O e5 7. dxe5 dxe5 8. Nxe5 Nxe4 9. Nxe4 Qxd1 10. Rxd1 Bxe5

Authored anchor ends after 6. O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White takes the center and develops normally against a fianchetto. This bridge does not require sacrificing the f-pawn or launching an immediate attack.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Complete development and support e4 before choosing d5 or a kingside expansion. Black's ...c5 and ...e5 are the breaks to monitor.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A large center can become a target. The g7 bishop becomes active when central pawns exchange.

REMEMBER Take space, then make it sustainable.

Work through KG-25

7. D4

Changes central space and pawn contacts. Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension before choosing the next piece plan.

8. EXD5

The pawn captures a knight on d5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

9. QE2+

Gives check with the queen on e2. The opponent must answer the check; inspect legal king moves, captures and blocks.

10. NE5

Places the knight on e5. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

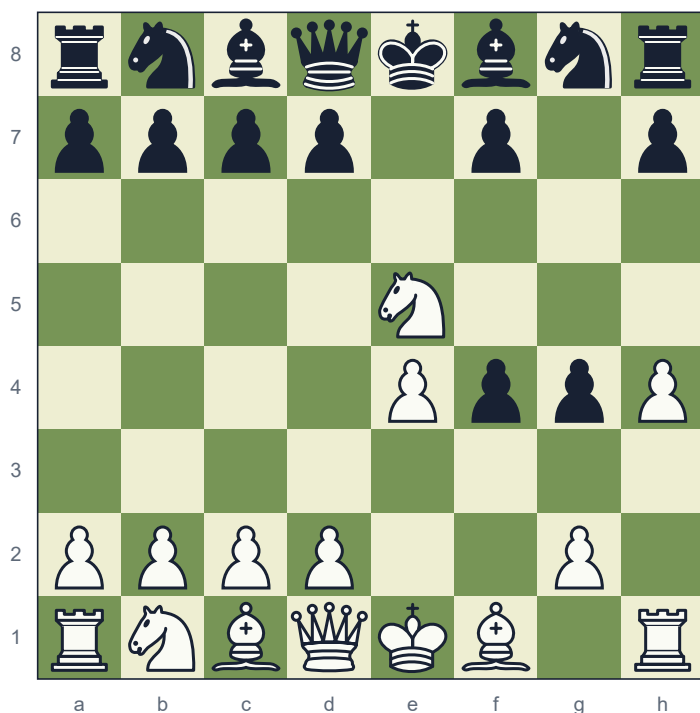
EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Bc4 develops before Nf3 and therefore permits the queen check. Kf1 preserves the center but gives up castling. This is an alternative to learn after the main repertoire. Develop Nf3 with a tempo against the queen if the position allows, then build d4 and coordinate the rook manually.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Compensation is a balance sheet



KG-01 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

The f-pawn buys a chance at central control and development, while weakening the king. Compensation must exist in the current position; the word gambit does not preserve it indefinitely.

HOW TO DECIDE

Count material, useful developed pieces, safe king squares and concrete threats. Ask what happens if Black returns the pawn or exchanges queens. If your compensation disappears, change the plan instead of sacrificing again.

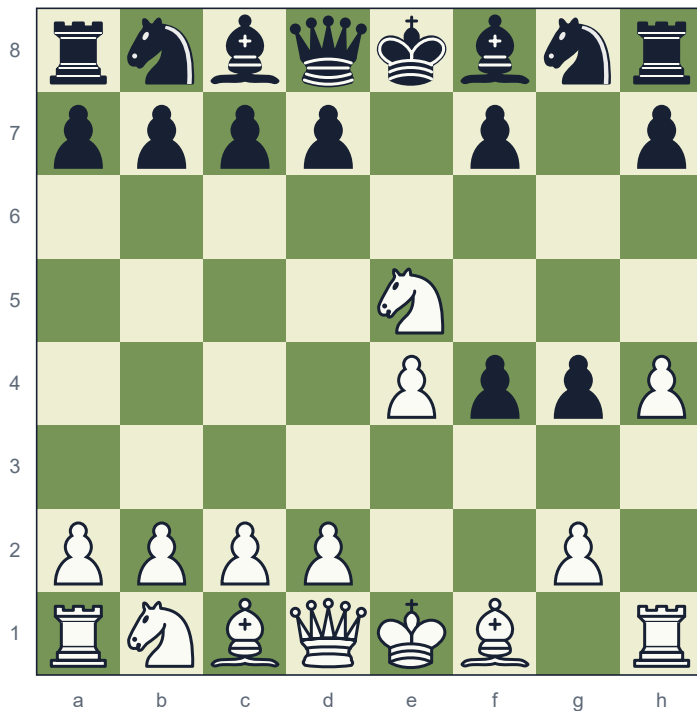
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can neutralize activity with ...d5 and timely exchanges rather than trying to hold f4 forever.

BOARD DRILL

Play the endpoint twice: first pursue development, then try to recover f4 immediately. Compare the time cost and resulting king safety.

The h4 lever and the g-pawn chain



KG-01 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

A supported pawn on f4 is hard to win directly. h4 challenges the g5 support and can force Black to choose between advancing, exchanging and reinforcing.

HOW TO DECIDE

After ...g4, name the attacked knight and its legal safe squares. Before hxg5, calculate the recapture and which rook gains the h-file. Keep track of the h-pawn's new file after captures.

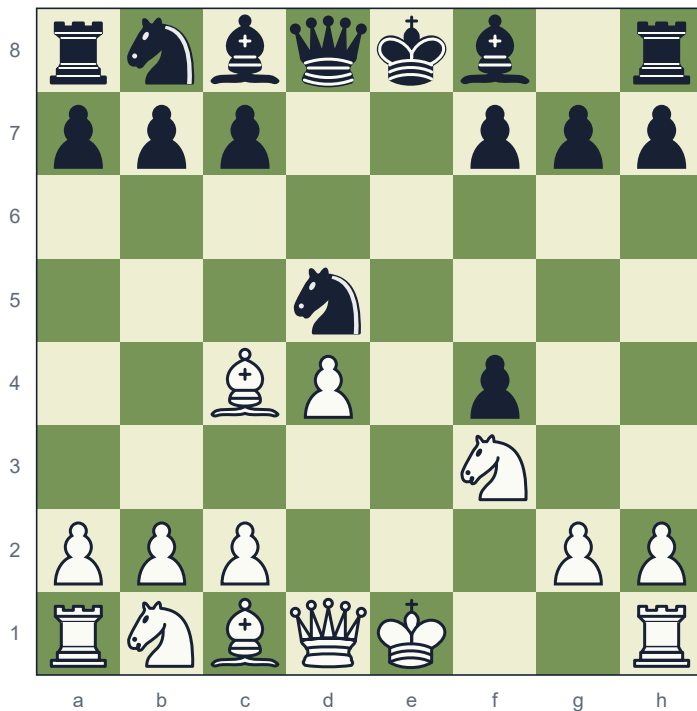
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

...d6 denies e5, while ...h6 changes the capture sequence. The same h4 move can lead to very different knight routes.

BOARD DRILL

Set up the position before h4 and compare ...g4, ...h6 and ...Bg7 on a board. Explain one concrete difference for each reply.

The f-file is not open until it is open



KG-09 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

After f2-f4 and ...exf4, the f-file still contains Black's pawn on f4. A rook on f1 cannot attack through it. Recovery or displacement of that pawn changes the file.

HOW TO DECIDE

Trace every square from the rook to f7. Identify blockers and defenders. Choose development that prepares a real file opening instead of calling a blocked file an attack.

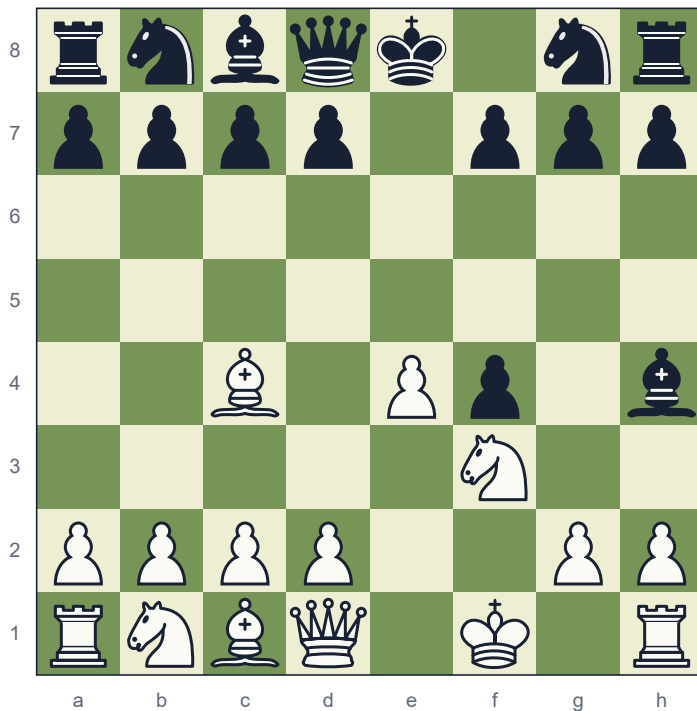
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black may return f4 to close another line or exchange attacking pieces. An open file with no entry square is not enough.

BOARD DRILL

Point to the first occupied square on the f-file in three different accepted-gambit diagrams, then explain how it might be removed.

When the king cannot castle



KG-13 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

Kf1 is a legal defensive response in some lines, but it permanently changes rook coordination. A central king can survive behind a stable center and become vulnerable when files open.

HOW TO DECIDE

Find the next central pawn break for both sides. Develop with that deadline in mind and look for a safe king route only after answering concrete checks. Do not spend several king moves without a reason.

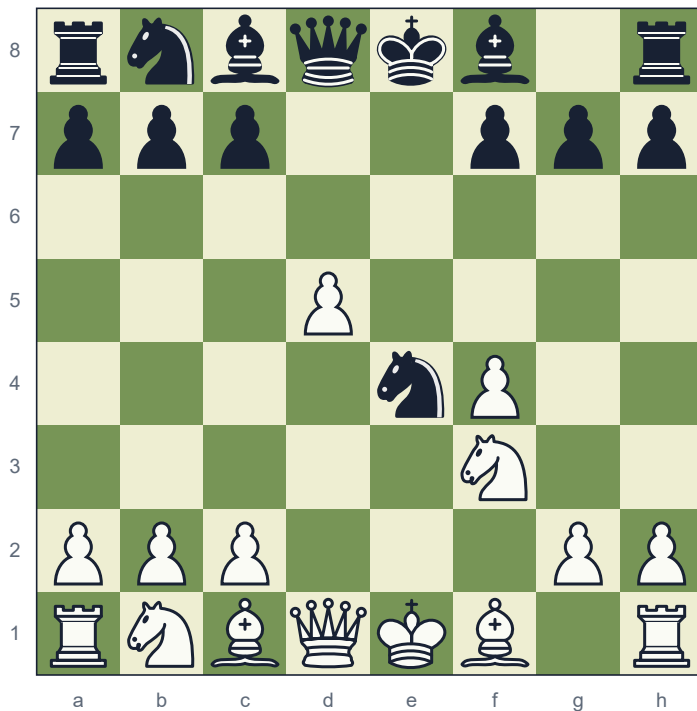
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can use ...d5 to open the game while the h1 rook is disconnected. A queen trade may help White more than a speculative attack.

BOARD DRILL

Play a Kf1 endpoint with the aim of connecting the rooks safely. Record how many tempi that task takes.

Central countergambits



KG-19 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

The Falkbeer attacks the center rather than defending e5. The advanced e4 pawn can restrict White and gain time against developing pieces.

HOW TO DECIDE

Challenge the wedge with d3 when appropriate. Calculate exchanges all the way to the recapture, then assess the resulting knight activity and king safety.

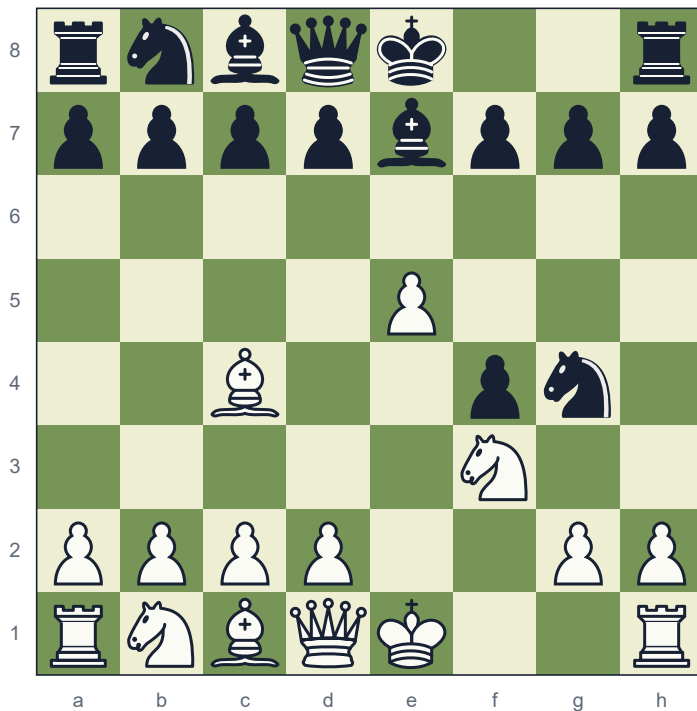
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can return material to develop rapidly. Holding an extra pawn while leaving the king on an open file can reverse the evaluation.

BOARD DRILL

Compare the ...e4 and ...exf4 versions after ...d5. State which one transposes to the Modern Defense and which creates a distinct center.

Attacking f7 without wishful thinking



KG-14 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

f7 is initially defended only by the king, but that fact alone does not justify a sacrifice. The king may capture a bishop and escape if White has insufficient follow-up.

HOW TO DECIDE

Calculate $Bxf7+$ through the best king reply and the next forcing move. Count supporting attackers and safe flight squares. Compare a quiet developing move before sacrificing.

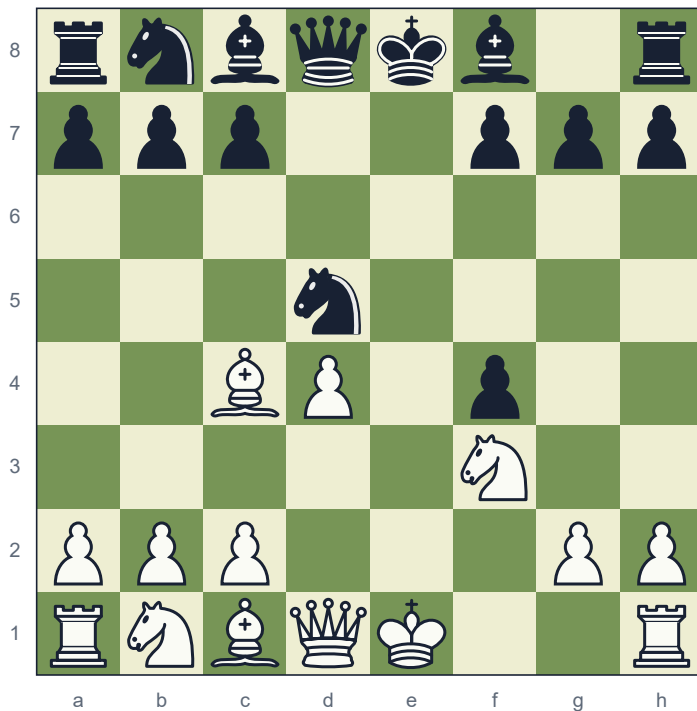
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black may answer an attack with $\dots d5$, interposing a pawn and opening the center. Defenders can arrive with tempo.

BOARD DRILL

In one laboratory, list all legal checks but choose the best move only after calculating the opponent's reply.

Trading queens when a pawn down



KG-09 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

A pawn-down endgame can be playable if your pieces are active and the opponent has weaknesses. It can also remove the compensation you relied on.

HOW TO DECIDE

Before a queen trade, compare pawn count, king activity and whether a target can be attacked. Do not refuse every trade merely because you started a gambit.

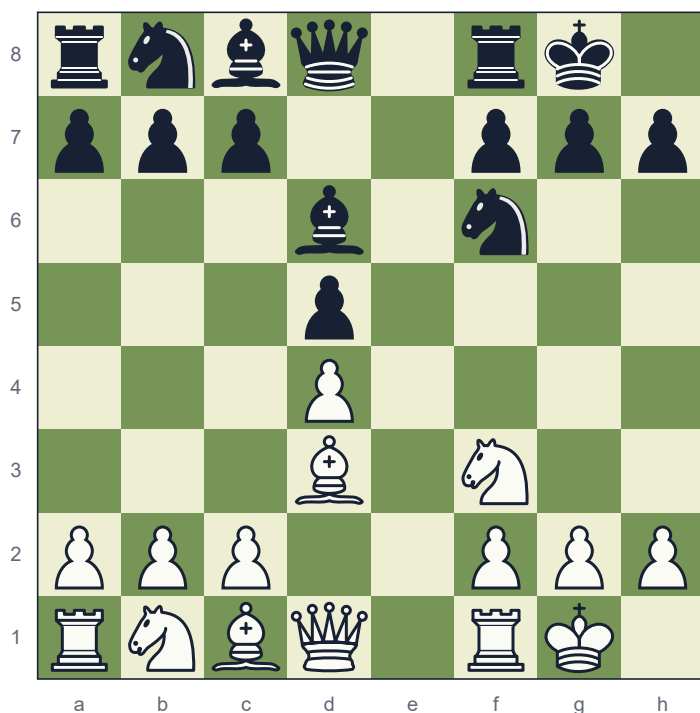
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black may force simplification when your attack has stalled. Maintaining queens at the cost of another pawn can make the defense harder.

BOARD DRILL

At an endpoint, remove neither queen by hand. Find a legal queen-trade route and compare the resulting pawn weaknesses.

The boundary of a King's Gambit repertoire



KG-28 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

The opening requires 1.e4 e5. French, Caro-Kann, Sicilian and Scandinavian replies need real companion choices; 2.f4 against them is a different opening.

HOW TO DECIDE

Use the bridge lines to reach familiar development, then deepen the defenses you meet most often. Against Sicilian 2...Nc6 or 2...e6, a simple 3.d3 followed by g3 and Bg2 is a bridge, not the 3.Bb5+ line shown against ...d6.

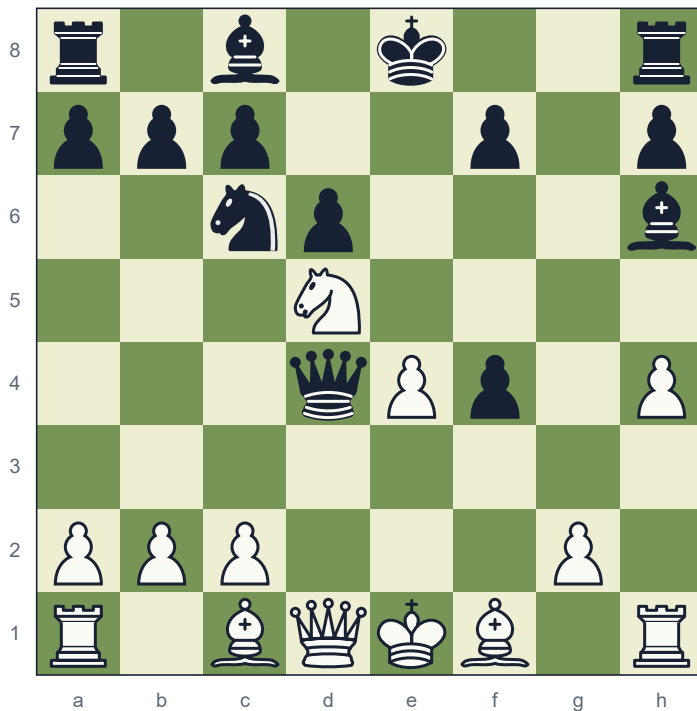
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can prevent your favorite opening on move one. Trying to force its name usually creates an unrelated and poorly prepared position.

BOARD DRILL

Sort ten imagined first replies into: King's Gambit available, bridge covered, or separate study needed. Include ...Nf6, ...b6 and ...Nc6 as separate-study examples.

Loose pieces and forks



KG-03 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

Before calculating an attack, list undefended pieces. A knight fork attacks two targets that cannot both move away. A queen check may combine king pressure with a second target. If you remove a defender, inspect every piece it protected.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Find two pieces that would be vulnerable if their defender moved. Calculate one legal forcing move that tests the relation. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

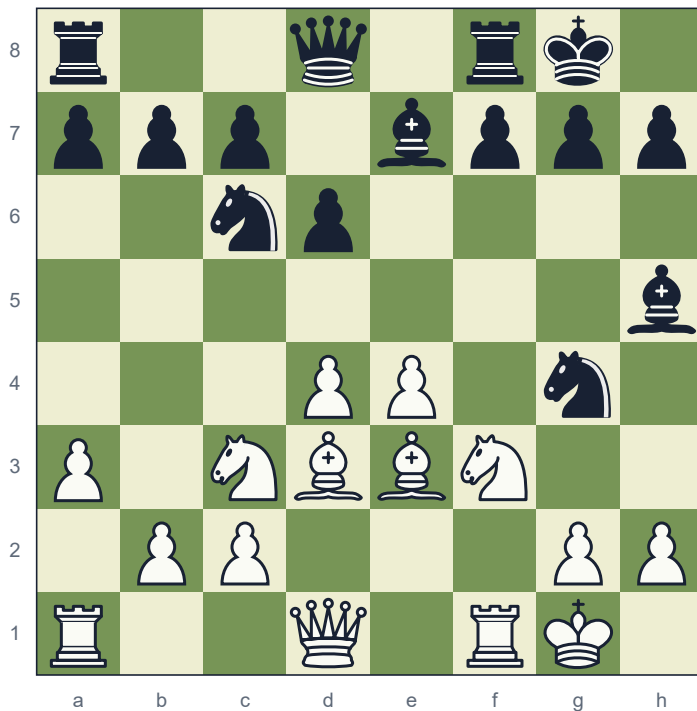
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

A similar position with an extra black developing move can change the tactics. Do not treat Nxg4 as universal whenever ...d6 attacks Ne5.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Pins and discovered attacks



KG-08 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

An absolute pin prevents a piece from moving if doing so exposes its king. A relative pin involves a valuable piece behind it, usually the queen. A discovered attack appears when a blocking piece moves away. Always trace the entire line, including the piece behind the blocker.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Identify a line piece, its blocker and the target behind it. If no pin exists, explain which required element is missing. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Black can challenge the center with ...d5 or ...c5. An undefended e4 pawn can become the target of ...Nxe4 tactics.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Intermediate moves and defensive resources



KG-13 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

A recapture is not compulsory unless it is the only legal response to check. Before recapturing, inspect checks, stronger captures and direct threats. When attacking, give the defender the same opportunity; do not assume automatic recaptures.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

At a capture in your line, pause before the reply. List all legal checks, then compare them with the expected recapture. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

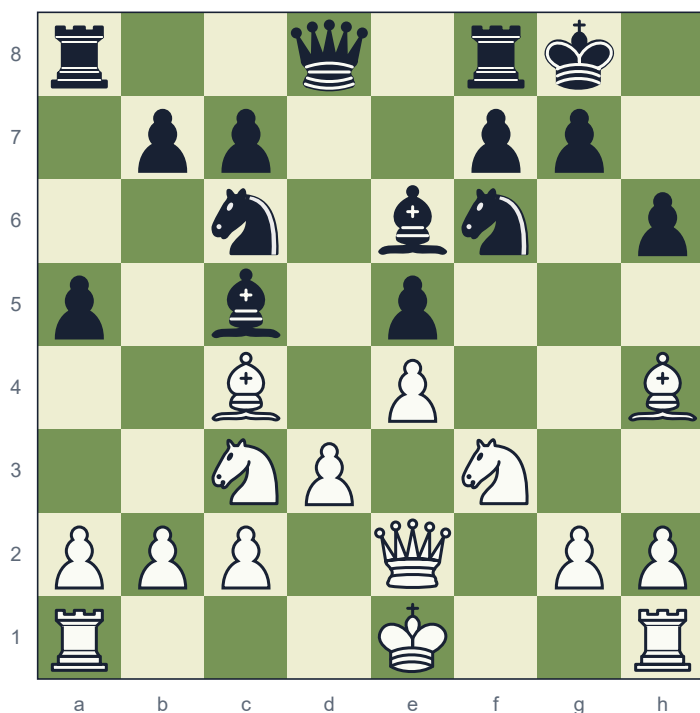
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Black can open the center with ...d5. Do not continue a routine castling plan after the king has moved.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

A sacrifice needs a stopping point



KG-18 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

Calculate a sacrifice until the defender has a stable reply you can evaluate. Count material after the whole sequence, not after the first capture. If the line ends only with a vague promise of attack, compare a non-sacrificial candidate.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Choose a tempting sacrifice from a laboratory or your own game. Write the best defensive reply and the position where you stop calculating. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

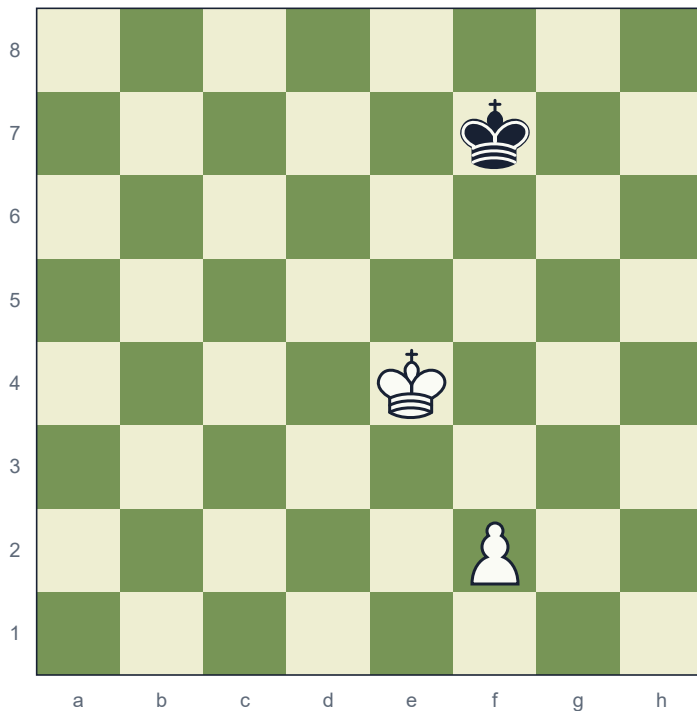
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Black can use ...Bg4 to pin Nf3 or open the center. Do not weaken the king with repeated pawn moves while pieces remain at home.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Activate the king when queens are gone



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

White to move: Kf5 is a legal active king move. Kf4 is also legal but less direct; compare plans rather than inventing a forcing win. The general lesson is to bring the king toward the pawn and useful squares while keeping the opposing king out.

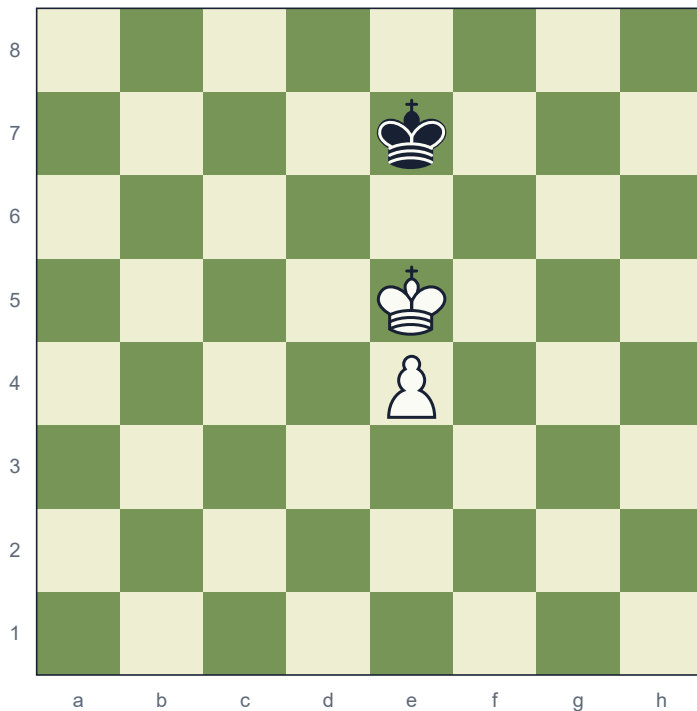
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In an opening-to-endgame transition, first inspect checks and pawn threats, then activate the king. Do not continue making shelter moves whose main purpose was defense against a queen. A rook ending may still require care about checks from behind.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Opposition and the importance of the move



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The kings face each other on e5 and e7 with one square between. White to move must give way or move the pawn; the geometry changes if Black is to move. Opposition is a tool for gaining entry squares, not a rule that always wins.

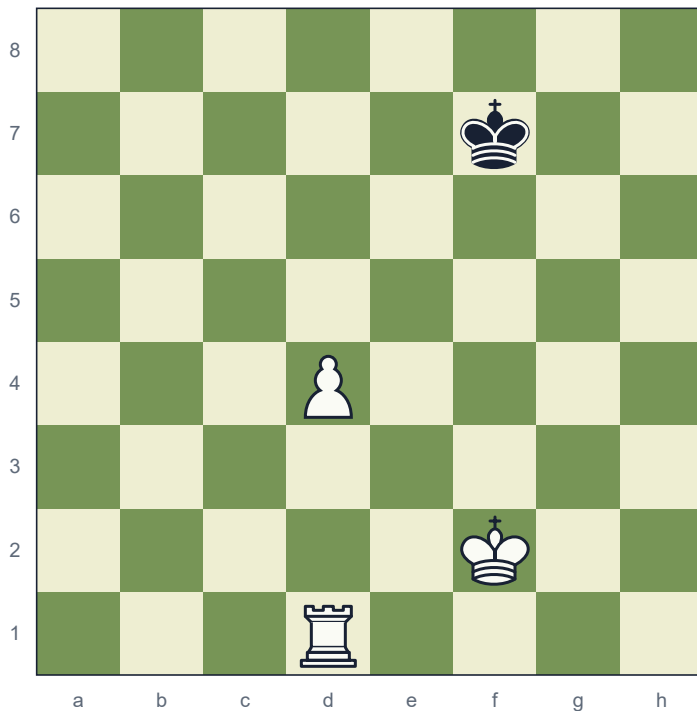
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Replay both side-to-move versions. Track the pawn's key squares and whether the attacking king can reach them. If you exchange into a pawn ending, calculate the actual king route and tempo rather than relying on the extra pawn alone.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Rooks belong where they work



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The rook on d1 stands behind its own passed d-pawn. As the pawn advances, the rook can continue supporting it from behind. This is a teaching position, not a claim of a difficult theoretical win against a rook.

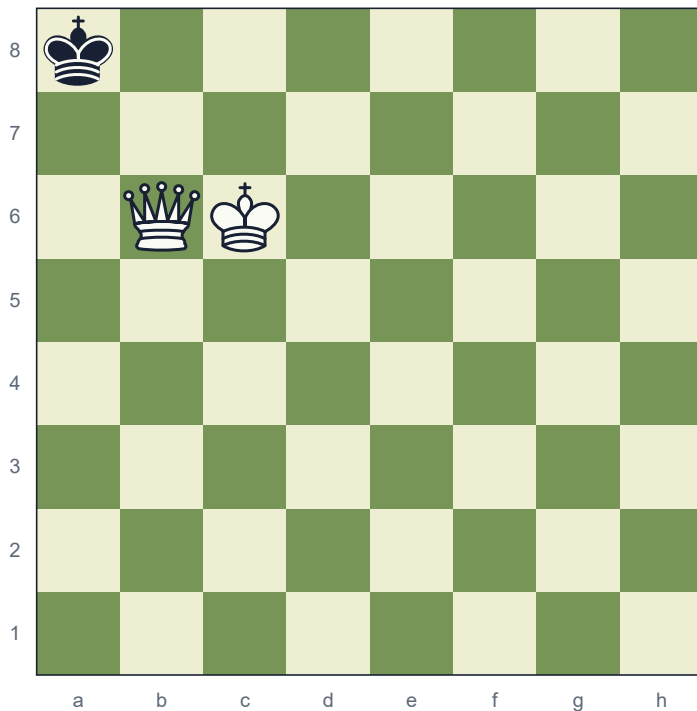
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In real rook endings compare activity, checking distance, king shelter and pawn races. Putting a rook behind a passed pawn is a useful default, but a tactical threat or a decisive lateral check can override it. Do not trade an active rook into a lost pawn ending.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Recognize stalemate before promoting



Teaching position - Black to move

READ THE BOARD

Black to move is not in check and has no legal move: a7 and b8 are controlled by Qb6, while b7 is controlled by the queen and Kc6. This is stalemate, so the position is a draw despite White's extra queen.

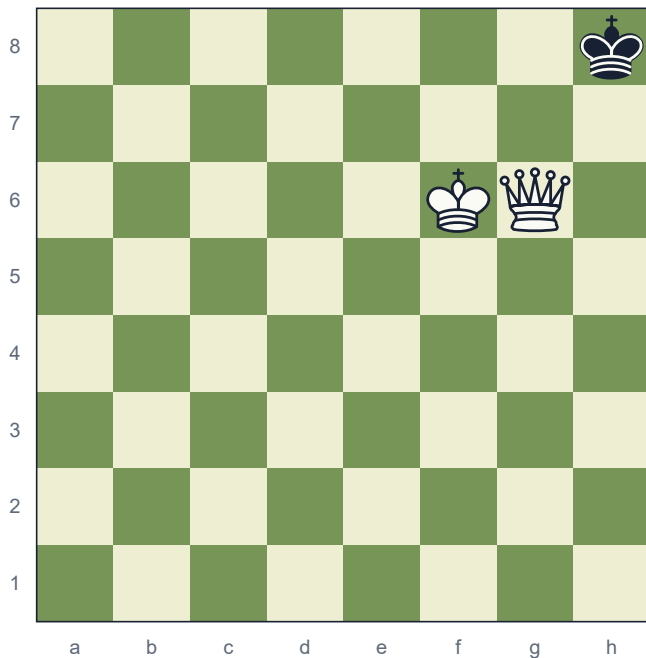
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Before delivering the final move of a won game, check whether the opponent has a legal reply if not in check. In queen-versus-king technique, restrict the king with the queen, approach with your king and preserve a legal waiting square until you can give mate.

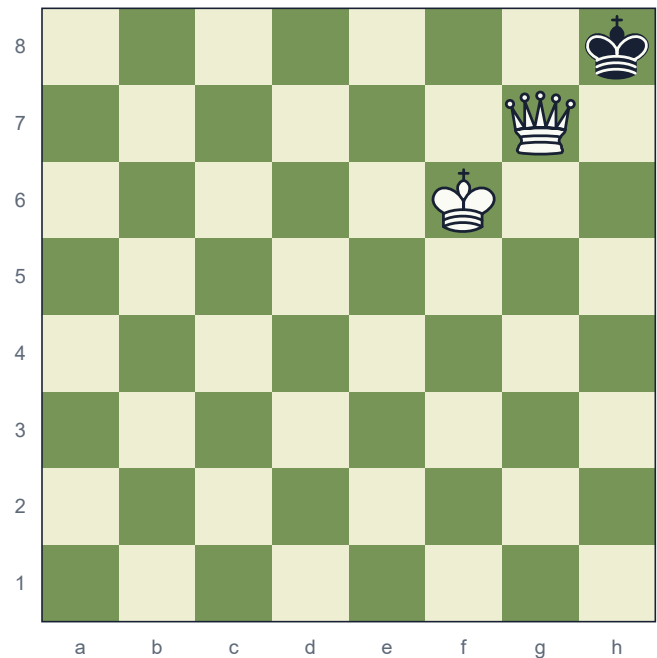
PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Finish a won queen ending



White to move - find mate in one



After Qg7# - Black is checkmated

WHY THIS IS MATE

Qg7 gives check along the g7-h8 diagonal. The white king on f6 protects the queen, so ...Kxg7 is illegal. The queen controls g8 and h7, removing the remaining escape squares. This proof checks attacks and legal replies, not just the appearance of the diagram.

TECHNIQUE BEFORE THE FINAL MOVE

Use the queen to reduce the enemy king's space, bring your king close enough to support the mate, and keep a legal waiting square until you can give checkmate. A queen alone can accidentally stalemate; review the previous lesson before repeating this drill.

Choosing the right exchanges

DO NOT TRADE BY HABIT

When offered a trade, compare the activity of the pieces leaving the board, the resulting pawn weaknesses and the king positions. A player with less space may welcome exchanges, but trading the only active piece can make the position worse.

PAWN ENDING TEST

Before exchanging the last pieces, calculate king activity, passed-pawn races and the side to move. Opposition is one tool; it is not a substitute for counting legal tempi. A pawn ending is often less forgiving than a rook ending.

OPENING-SPECIFIC QUESTION

The opening requires 1.e4 e5. French, Caro-Kann, Sicilian and Scandinavian replies need real companion choices; 2.f4 against them is a different opening.

PRACTICAL CONVERSION

When ahead, neutralize counterplay and improve the least active piece before collecting another pawn. When defending, seek active checks, pawn breaks and useful exchanges rather than passive waiting.

A STUDY HABIT

After every practice game, keep one transition position. Record which exchange you chose, which alternative you considered and how the pawn structure changed.

How the six laboratories work

ORIGINAL ILLUSTRATIVE PLAY

These are original engine-assisted study continuations from this course's positions. They are not historical master games and no invented players or tournament results are assigned. The continuations reach roughly move twenty and stop for further practice.

THINK BEFORE REVEALING

At each checkpoint, name the opponent's threat, compare two candidates and calculate a forcing reply. Use a board to replay the sequence. The engine comparison supplies concrete evidence, while the opening explanation supplies a plan.

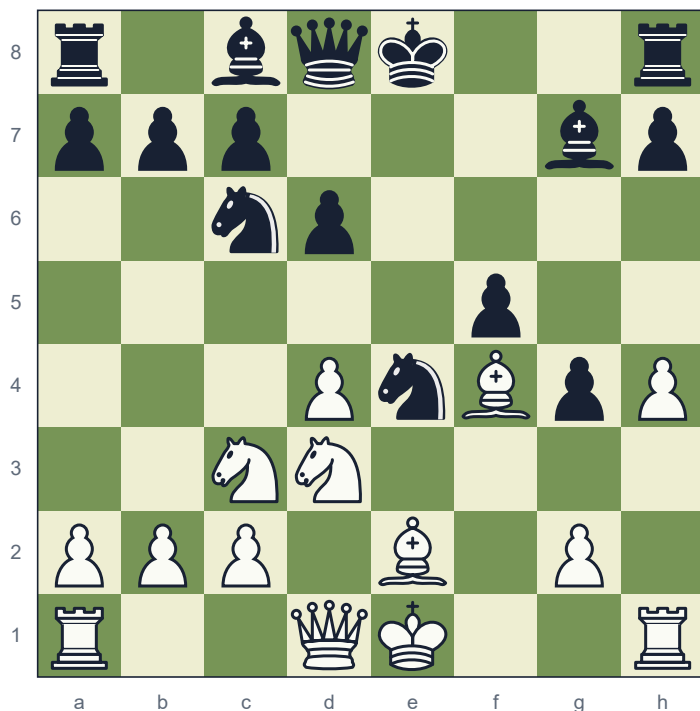
MORE THAN ONE GOOD MOVE

Close engine scores do not establish a unique answer. The finite search can prefer a different move when run longer. Accept another candidate if you can support it with a sound variation and a coherent explanation.

PRACTICE FROM BOTH SIDES

Play each starting position twice, switching colors. Record the first decision you could not explain and compare it with the branch lesson after the game.

KG-LAB-01 / The main choice: meet ...g5 with h4



Laboratory start - White to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

Nf3 prevents an immediate queen check on h4. Black uses ...g5 to keep f4, so h4 attacks the supporting chain. After ...g4 the knight must move; Ne5 takes an active central post.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns f5, d6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

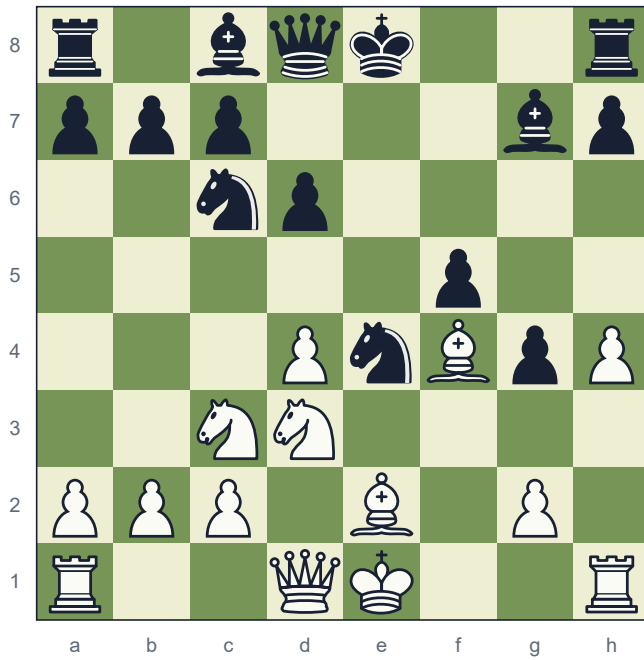
Black can play ...Nf6 against e4 and ...d6 against Ne5. Count the defenders of e4 before chasing f7. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

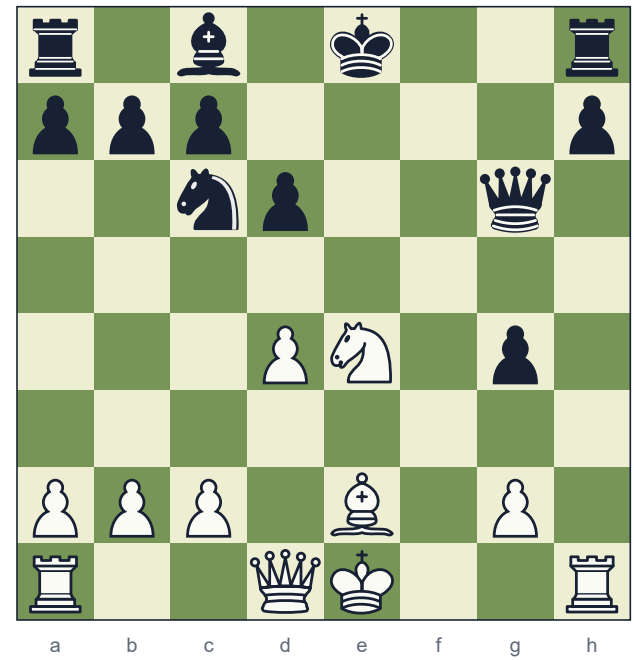
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

KG-LAB-01 / play and explain 1

11. Nxe4 fxe4 12. Bg5 Bf6 13. Nf2 Bxg5 14. hxg5 Qxg5 15. Nxe4 Qg6



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

11. Nxe4

The knight captures a knight on e4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

13. Nf2

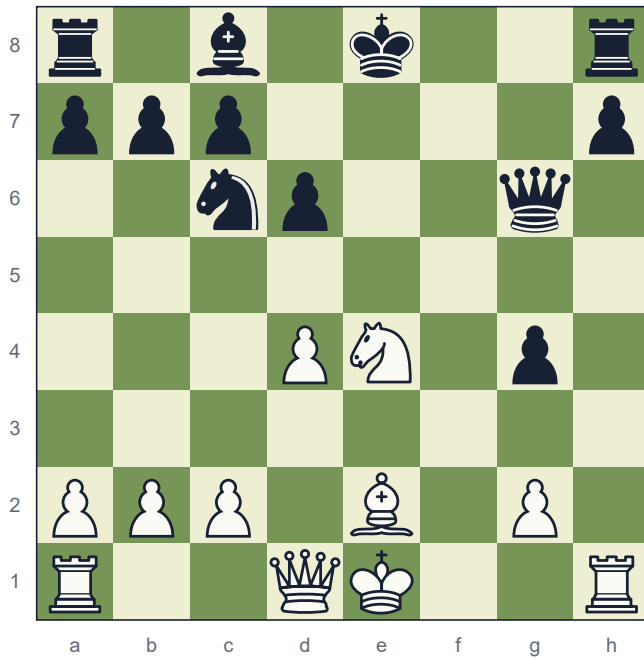
Places the knight on f2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

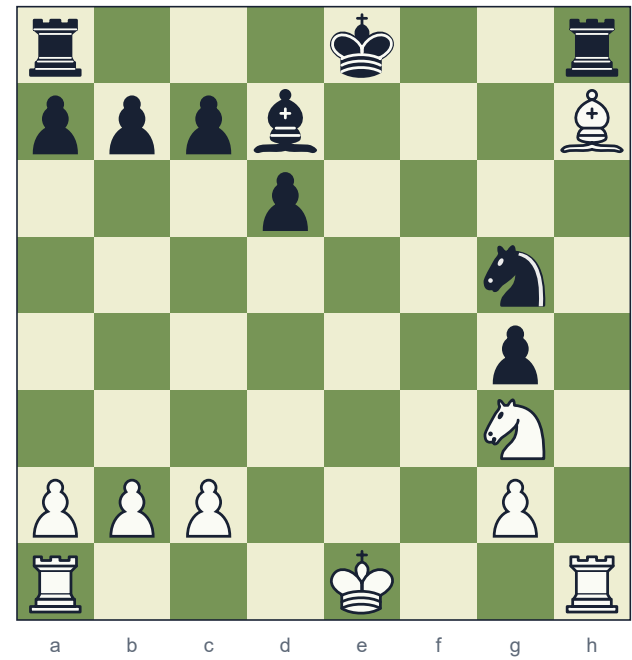
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

KG-LAB-01 / play and explain 2

16. Ng3 Bd7 17. Bd3 Qe6+ 18. Qe2 Nxd4 19. Qxe6+ Nxe6 20. Bxh7 Ng5



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

16. NG3

Places the knight on g3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

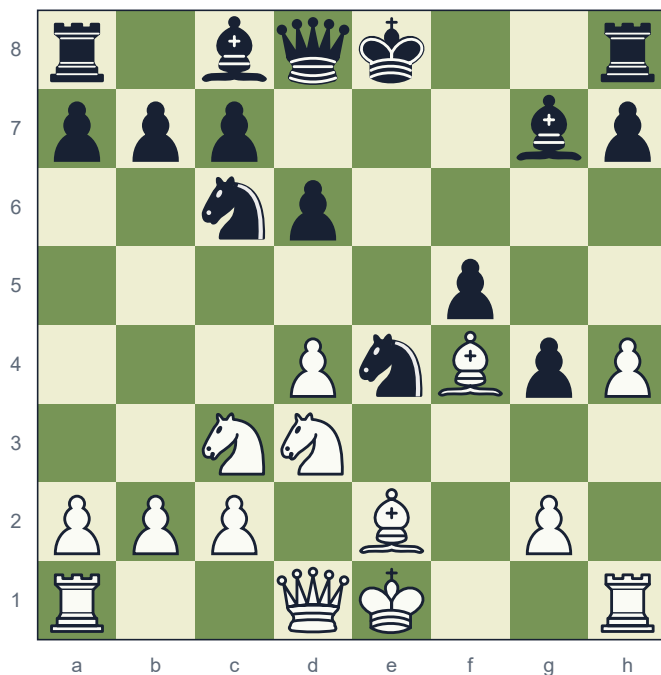
18. QE2

Places the queen on e2, attacking queen on e6. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

KG-LAB-01 / decision 1



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nxe4 and Bxg4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns f5, d6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NXE4

11. Nxe4 fxe4 Search estimate: -0.94 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE BXG4

11. Bxg4 O-O 12. Bf3 Nxd4 13. Ne2 Re8 14. c3 Nxe2 Search estimate: -1.89 from White's perspective.

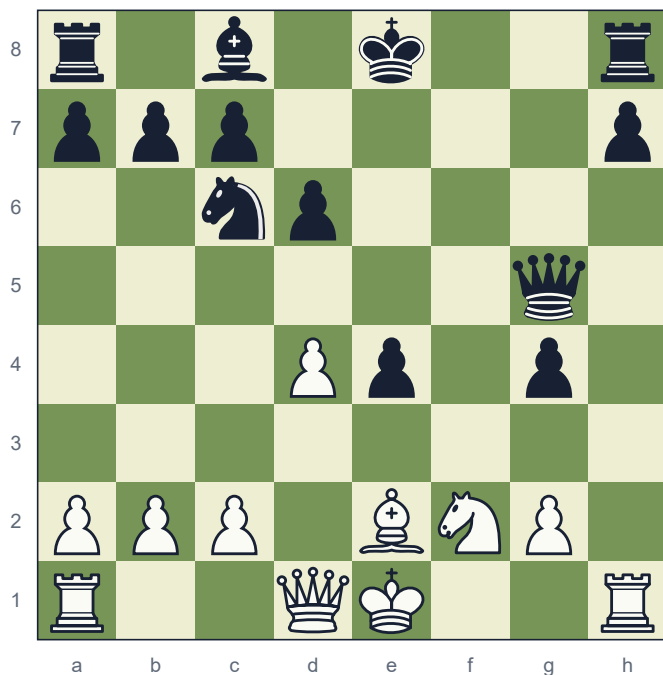
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The knight captures a knight on e4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-01 / decision 2



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nxe4 and d5. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns e4, d6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NXE4

15. Nxe4 Qg6 16. Ng3 Bd7 17. Qd3 O-O-O 18. Qxg6 hxg6 Search estimate: -0.82 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE D5

15. d5 Ne5 16. Nxe4 Qg6 17. Ng3 h5 18. Qd4 h4 Search estimate: -1.55 from White's perspective.

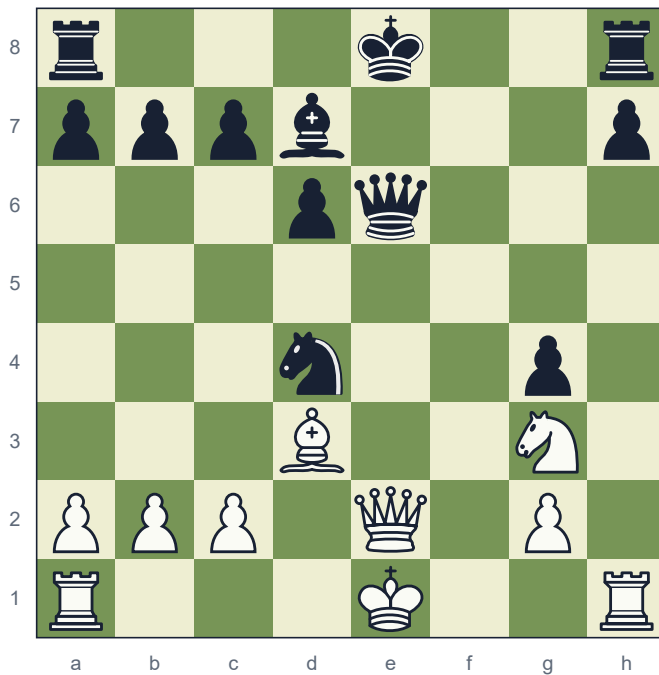
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The knight captures a pawn on e4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-01 / decision 3



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Qxe6+ and Qe4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns c2. Black king e8; central-file pawns d6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE QXE6+

19. Qxe6+ Nxe6 20. Bxh7 Nf4 21. Kd2 Nxg2 22. Raf1 Bc6 Search estimate: -0.92 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE QE4

19. Qe4 Bc6 Search estimate: -1.64 from White's perspective.

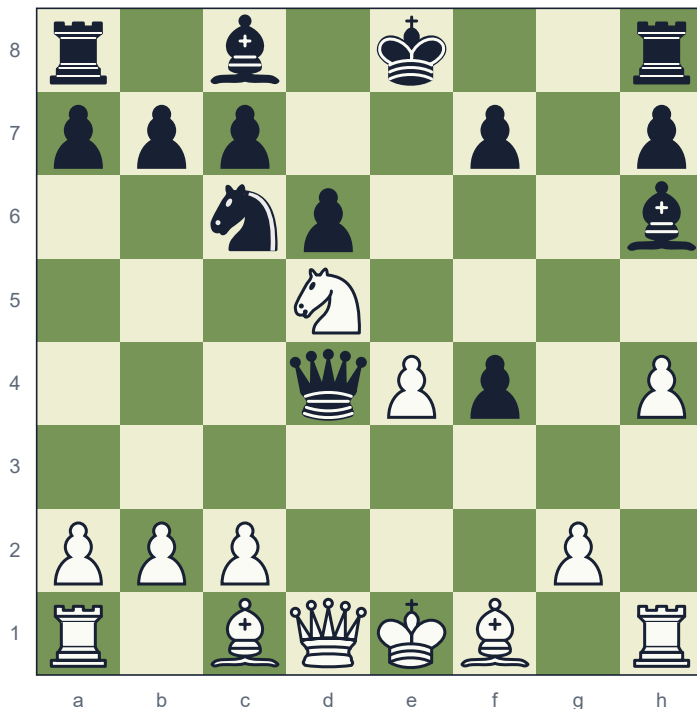
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The queen captures a queen on e6. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-02 / Kieseritzky: an immediate ...d6



Laboratory start - White to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

Black attacks Ne5 with the d-pawn, but the knight can capture the advanced g4 pawn while escaping. This concrete resource is stronger than mechanically retreating to d3 in this exact position.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns c2, e4. Black king e8; central-file pawns f4, d6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

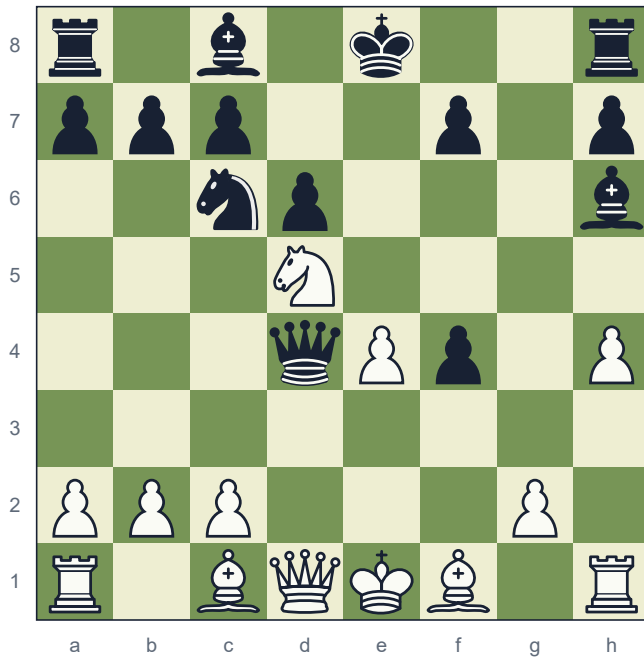
A similar position with an extra black developing move can change the tactics. Do not treat Nxg4 as universal whenever ...d6 attacks Ne5. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

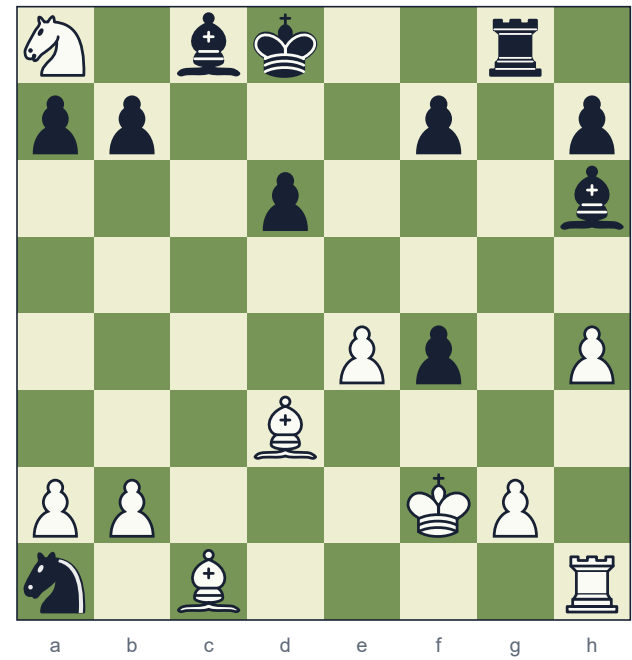
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

KG-LAB-02 / play and explain 1

11. Nxc7+ Kd8 12. Qxd4 Nxd4 13. Nxa8 Nxc2+ 14. Kf2 Nxa1 15. Bd3 Rg8



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

11. NXC7+

The knight captures a pawn on c7. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

13. NXA8

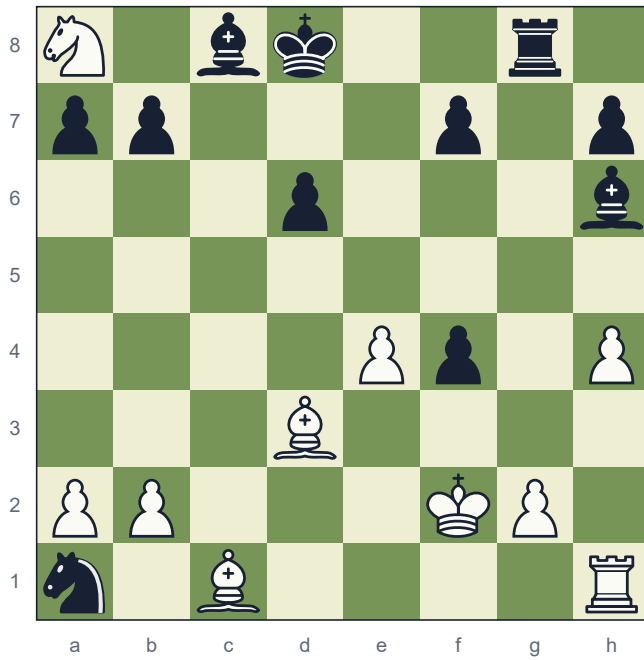
The knight captures a rook on a8. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

REASSESS

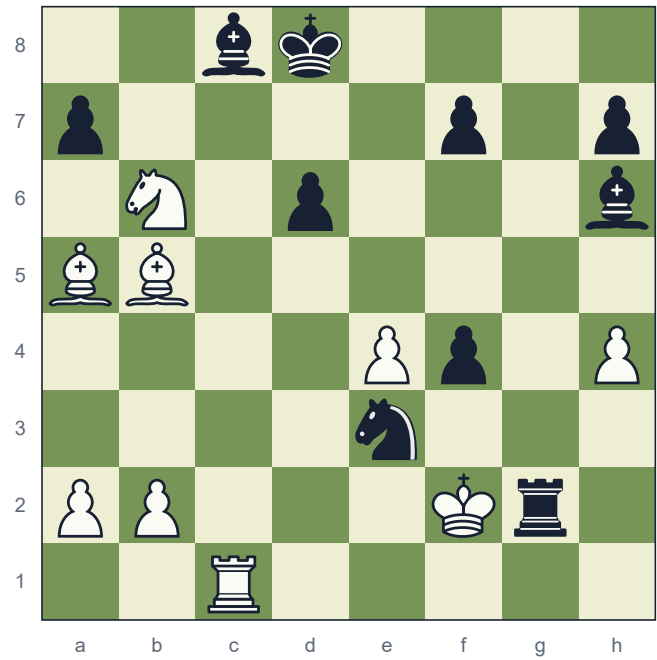
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

KG-LAB-02 / play and explain 2

16. Bd2 Rg3 17. Bb5 Nc2 18. Rc1 Ne3 19. Ba5+ b6 20. Nxb6 Rxd2+



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move - in check

16. BD2

Places the bishop on d2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

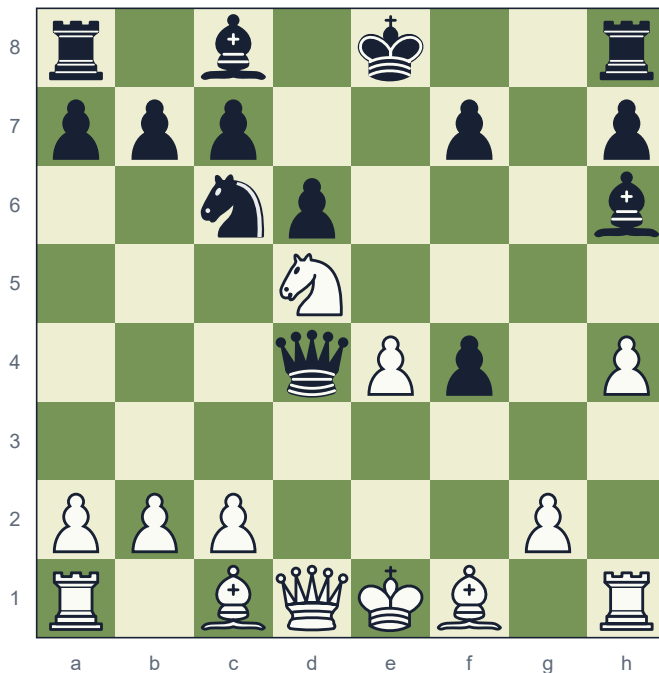
18. RC1

Places the rook on c1, attacking knight on c2. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

KG-LAB-02 / decision 1



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nxc7+ and Qxd4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns c2, e4. Black king e8; central-file pawns f4, d6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NXC7+

11. Nxc7+ Kd8 Search estimate: +0.31 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE QXD4

11. Qxd4 Nxd4 12. Nxc7+ Kd8 13. Nxa8 Nxc2+ 14. Kf2 Nxa1 Search estimate: +0.32 from White's perspective.

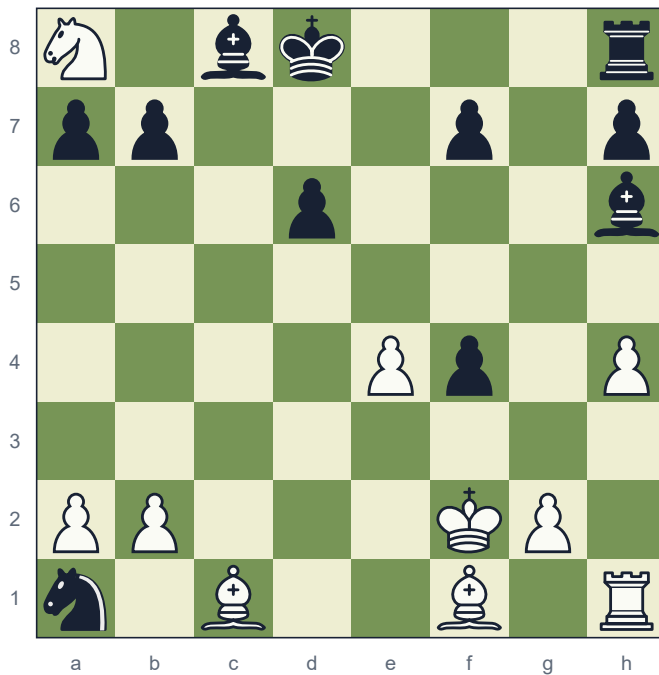
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The knight captures a pawn on c7. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-02 / decision 2



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Bd3 and b3. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king f2; central-file pawns e4. Black king d8; central-file pawns f4, d6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE BD3

15. Bd3 Rg8 16. Bd2 Rg3 17. Bb5 Nc2 18. Rc1 Ne3 Search estimate: +0.04 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE B3

15. b3 Nc2 16. Bb2 Rg8 17. Bf6+ Kd7 18. Bb5+ Ke6 Search estimate: -0.81 from White's perspective.

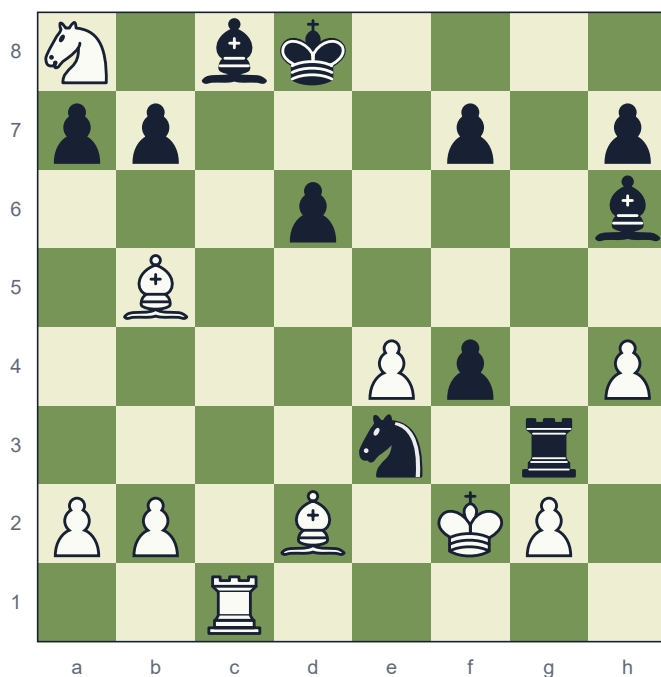
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the bishop on d3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-02 / decision 3



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Ba5+ and Bxe3. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king f2; central-file pawns e4. Black king d8; central-file pawns f4, d6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE BA5+

19. Ba5+ b6 20. Nxb6 Rxb6 21. Ke1 axb6 22. Bxb6+ Ke7 Search estimate: +0.02 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE BXE3

19. Bxe3 Rxe3 Search estimate: -0.55 from White's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Gives check with the bishop on a5. The opponent must answer the check; inspect legal king moves, captures and blocks.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-03 / Modern Defense: ...d5 at once



Laboratory start - White to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

Black exchanges central pawns and develops toward the returned material. Bc4 creates pressure while White builds a useful d4 center.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king c8; central-file pawns c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

Black can exchange pieces and neutralize the initiative. Do not sacrifice more material merely because the opening began as a gambit. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

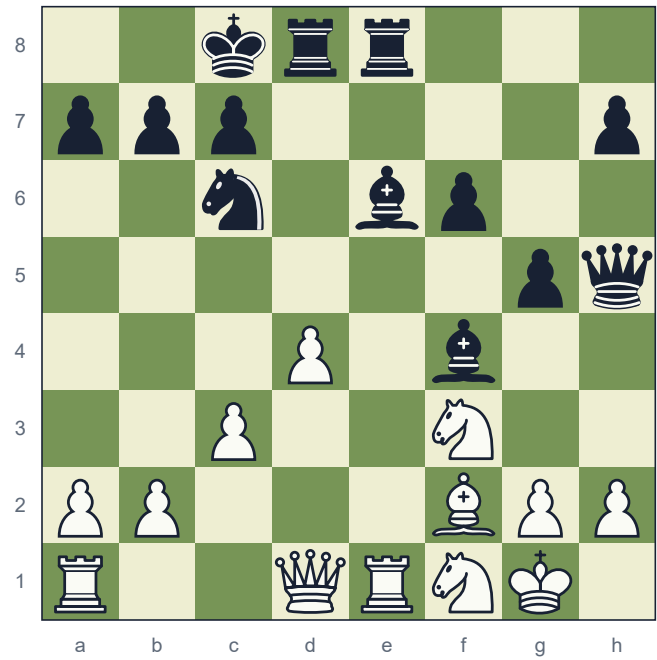
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

KG-LAB-03 / play and explain 1

11. Nbd2 Bd6 12. c3 Rhe8 13. Re1 f6 14. Bf2 Bf4 15. Nf1 g5



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

11. NBD2

Develops the queen knight while leaving the c-pawn free. The knight supports e4 and may seek c4 or a route through f1.

13. RE1

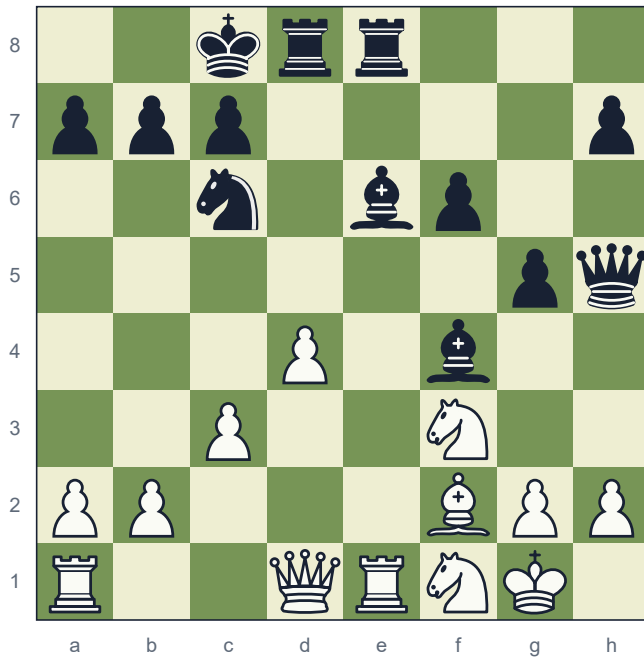
Places the rook on the e-file, commonly supporting e4 or preparing pressure against an opposing king or central pawn.

REASSESS

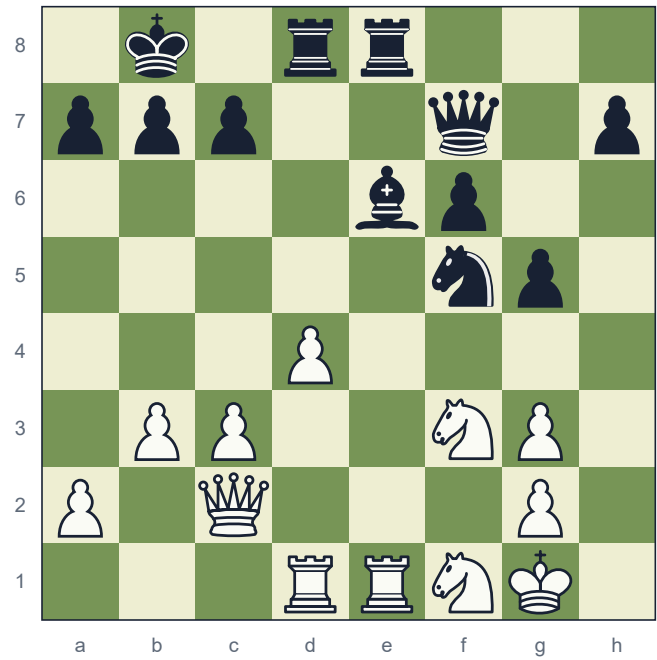
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

KG-LAB-03 / play and explain 2

16. Qc2 Kb8 17. Bg3 Bxg3 18. hxg3 Qf7 19. b3 Ne7 20. Rad1 Nf5



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

16. QC2

Places the queen on c2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

18. HXG3

The pawn captures a bishop on g3. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

KG-LAB-03 / decision 1



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nbd2 and c3. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king c8; central-file pawns c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NBD2

11. Nbd2 Bd6 12. Ne4 Be7 13. c3 Rhe8 14. Ng3 Qg6 Search estimate: -0.64 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE C3

11. c3 f6 12. Re1 Bd6 13. Nbd2 Rhe8 14. Bf2 g5 Search estimate: -0.68 from White's perspective.

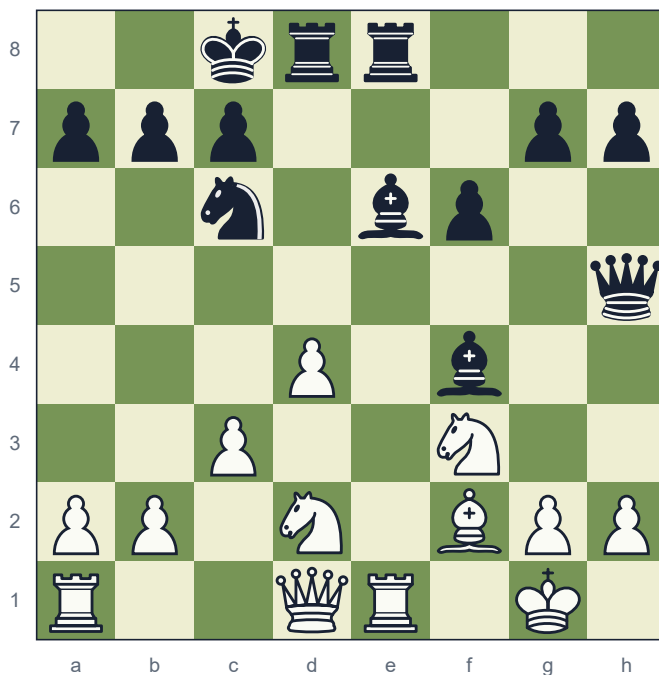
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Develops the queen knight while leaving the c-pawn free. The knight supports e4 and may seek c4 or a route through f1.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-03 / decision 2



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nf1 and Bg3. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c3, d4. Black king c8; central-file pawns f6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NF1

15. Nf1 Bd5 16. Rxe8 Rxe8 17. Ng3 Bxg3 18. hxg3 Nd8 Search estimate: -0.63 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE BG3

15. Bg3 Bh6 Search estimate: -0.72 from White's perspective.

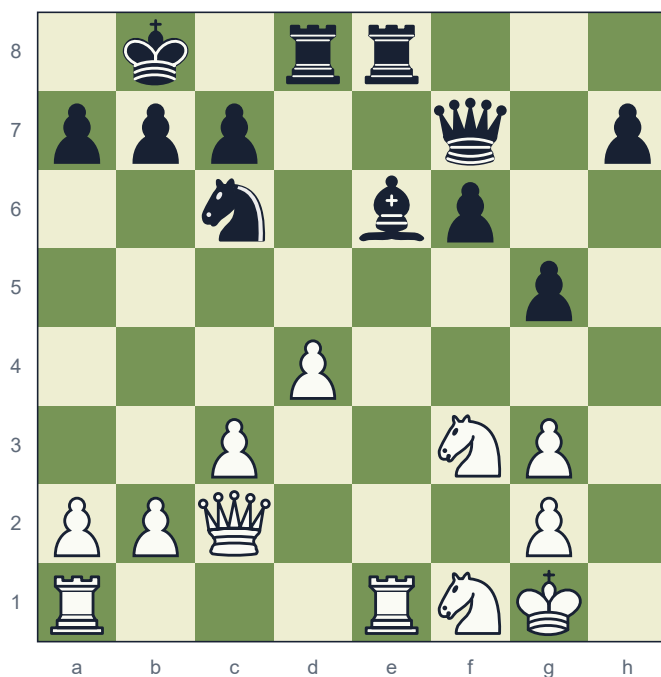
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the knight on f1. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-03 / decision 3



COMPARE CANDIDATES

b3 and Ne3. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c3, d4. Black king b8; central-file pawns f6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE B3

19. b3 Ne7 20. Rad1 h5 21. c4 Bg4 22. Qf2 Nf5 Search estimate: -0.47 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE NE3

19. Ne3 h5 Search estimate: -0.74 from White's perspective.

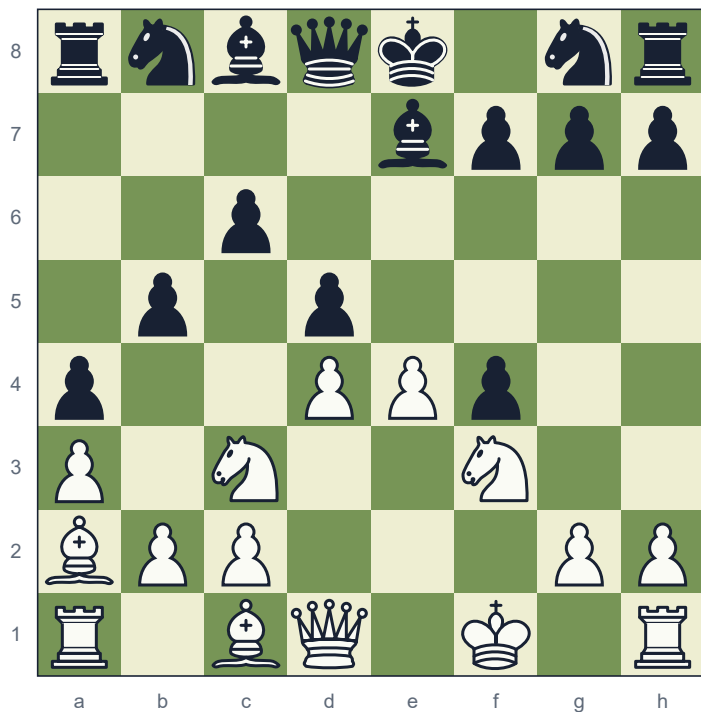
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Prepares a fianchetto and changes the long diagonal. Check the bishop and corner rook before assuming the next developing move is safe.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-04 / Cunningham: meet the bishop check



Laboratory start - White to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

The bishop reaches h4 with check along the diagonal to e1. Kf1 answers it without pushing more kingside pawns, but permanently gives up castling.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king f1; central-file pawns c2, d4, e4. Black king e8; central-file pawns f4, d5, c6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

Black can open the center with ...d5. Do not continue a routine castling plan after the king has moved. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

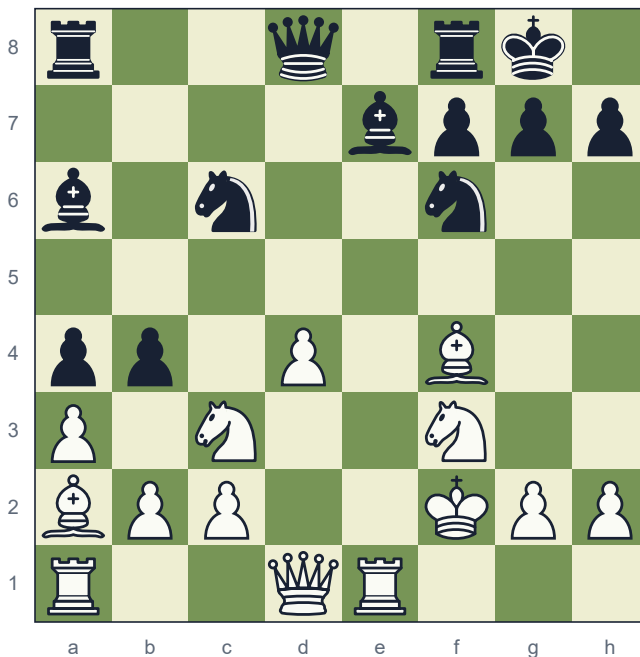
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

KG-LAB-04 / play and explain 1

11. exd5 Nf6 12. dxc6 Ba6 13. Kf2 Nxc6 14. Re1 O-O 15. Bxf4 b4



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

11. EXD5

The pawn captures a pawn on d5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

13. KF2

Places the king on f2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

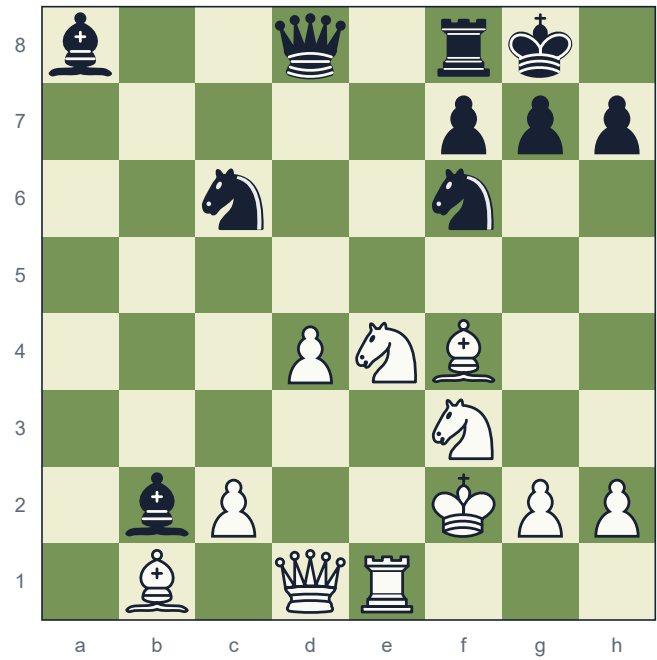
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

KG-LAB-04 / play and explain 2

16. Ne4 bxa3 17. bxa3 Bxa3 18. Bb1 Bb2 19. Rxa4 Bb7 20. Rxa8 Bxa8



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

16. NE4

Places the knight on e4, attacking knight on f6. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

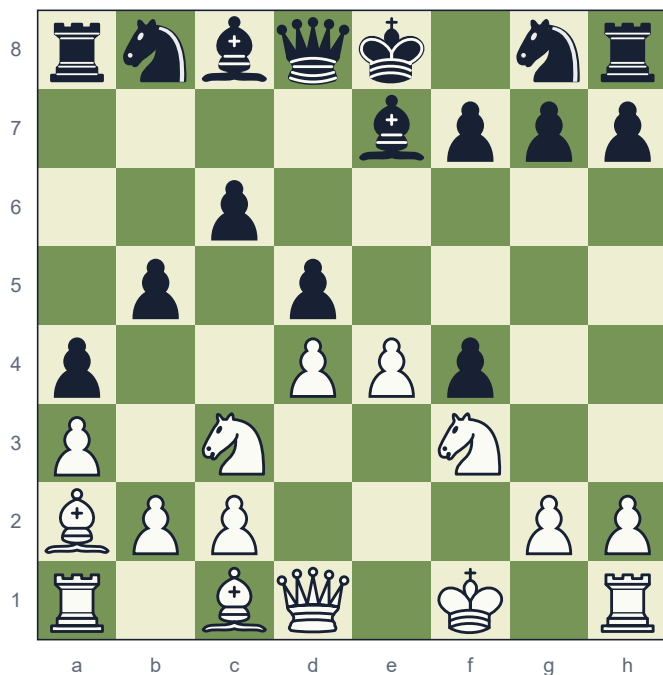
18. BB1

Places the bishop on b1. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

KG-LAB-04 / decision 1



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

exd5 and Bxf4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king f1; central-file pawns c2, d4, e4. Black king e8; central-file pawns f4, d5, c6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE EXD5

11. exd5 Search estimate: +0.17 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE BXF4

11. Bxf4 Nf6 12. exd5 O-O 13. dxc6 Nxc6 14. Nxb5 Na7 Search estimate: +0.02 from White's perspective.

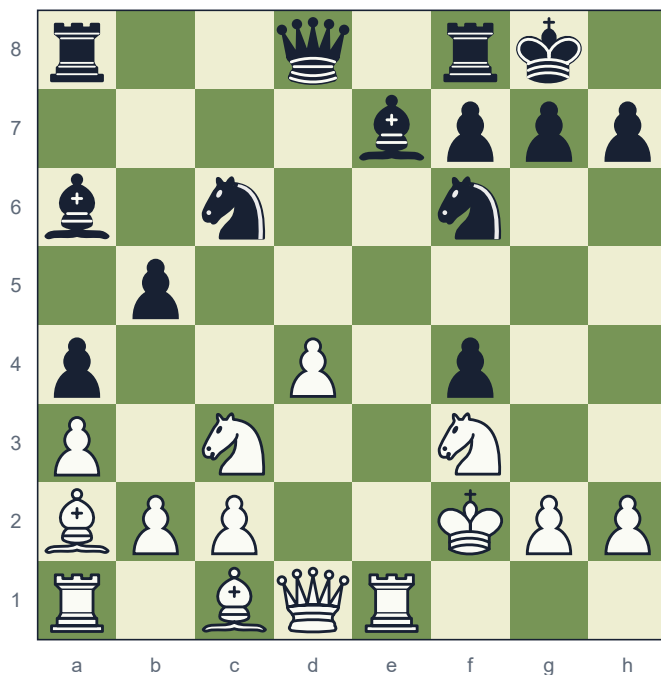
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The pawn captures a pawn on d5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-04 / decision 2



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Bxf4 and Kg1. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king f2; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns f4, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE Bxf4

15. Bxf4 b4 16. Ne4 bxa3 17. bxa3 Bxa3 18. Bb1 Bb2 Search estimate: +0.53 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE Kg1

15. Kg1 Bd6 16. Ne5 Qb6 17. Bxf4 Qxd4+ 18. Qxd4 Nxd4 Search estimate: +0.00 from White's perspective.

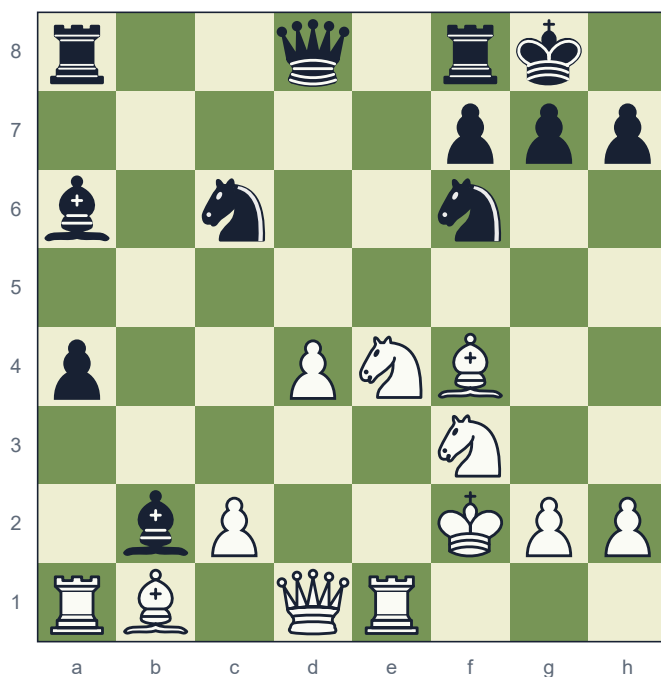
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The bishop captures a pawn on f4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-04 / decision 3



COMPARE CANDIDATES

Rxa4 and Nxf6+. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king f2; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE Rxa4

19. Rxa4 Bb7 Search estimate: +0.08 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE Nxf6+

19. Nxf6+ Qxf6 20. Bg5 Bxd4+ 21. Qxd4 Qxf3+ 22. gxf3 Nxd4 Search estimate: -0.06 from White's perspective.

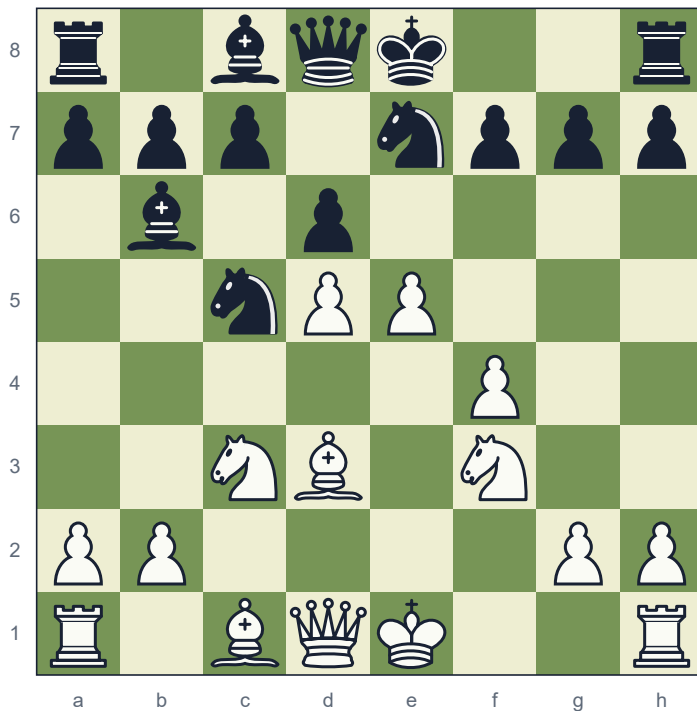
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The rook captures a pawn on a4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-05 / Classical Declined: ...Bc5



Laboratory start - White to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

White uses c3 to support d4 while the bishop keeps pressure on the king side. Exchanging in the center gives White space but opens lines.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns f4, d5, e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns d6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

The c5-b6 bishop watches the sensitive f2 square. Capturing e5 at the wrong time may permit ...Qh4+ and a king attack. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

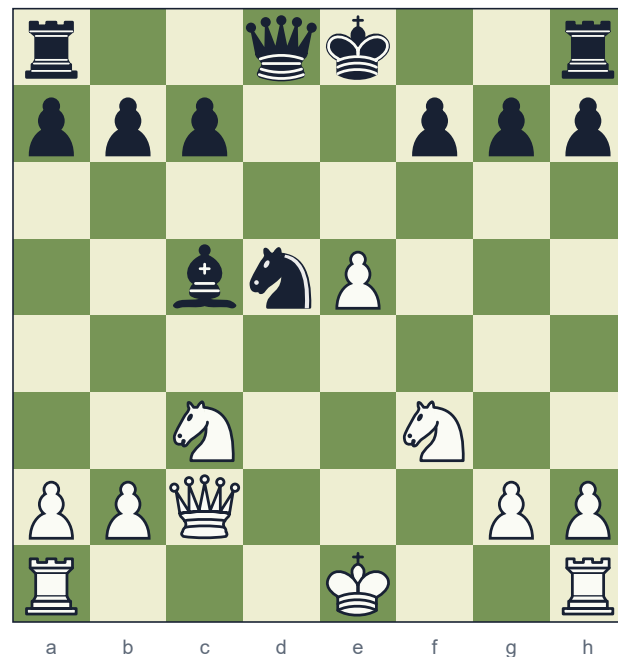
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

KG-LAB-05 / play and explain 1

11. Bc2 Bf5 12. Be3 dxe5 13. fxe5 Bxc2 14. Qxc2 Nxd5 15. Bxc5 Bxc5



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

11. BC2

Places the bishop on c2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

13. FXE5

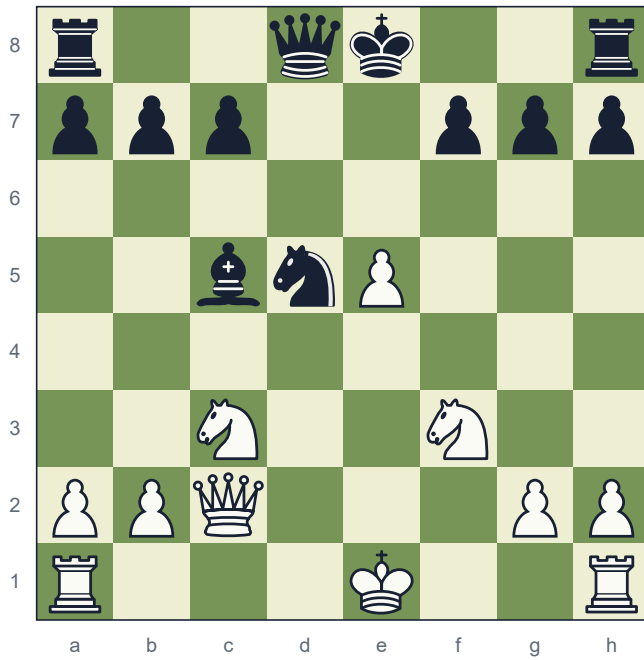
The pawn captures a pawn on e5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

REASSESS

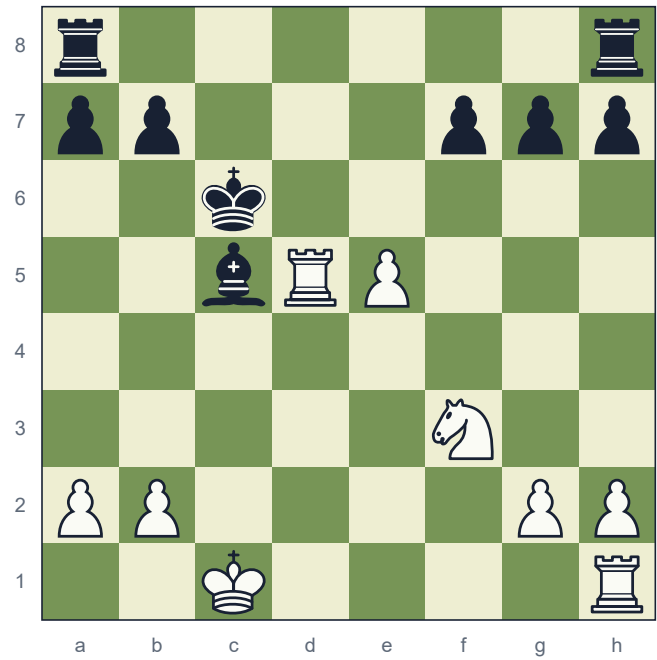
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

KG-LAB-05 / play and explain 2

16. O-O-O c6 17. Nxd5 cxd5 18. Qa4+ Qd7 19. Qxd7+ Kxd7 20. Rxd5+ Kc6



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

16. O-O-O

Moves the king toward shelter and brings a rook toward the center. Check the resulting open lines before assuming the king is safe.

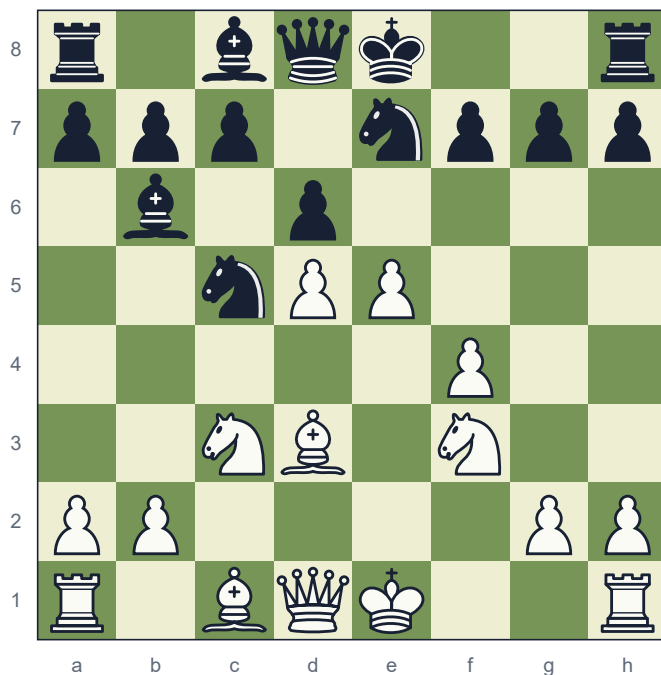
18. QA4+

Gives check with the queen on a4. The opponent must answer the check; inspect legal king moves, captures and blocks.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

KG-LAB-05 / decision 1



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Bc2 and Bc4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns f4, d5, e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns d6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE BC2

11. Bc2 Search estimate: +0.51 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE BC4

11. Bc4 O-O 12. Be3 c6 13. dxc6 Nxc6 14. Qxd6 Qxd6 Search estimate: +0.12 from White's perspective.

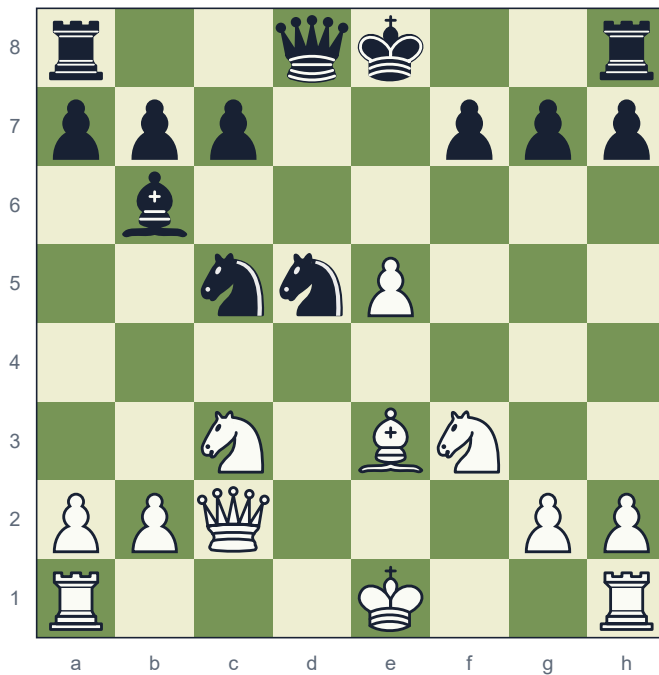
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the bishop on c2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-05 / decision 2



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Bxc5 and O-O-O. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE BXC5

15. Bxc5 Bxc5 Search estimate: +0.10 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE O-O-O

15. O-O-O Nxe3 16. Rxd8+ Rxd8 17. Qe2 O-O 18. Kb1 Ne6 Search estimate: +0.07 from White's perspective.

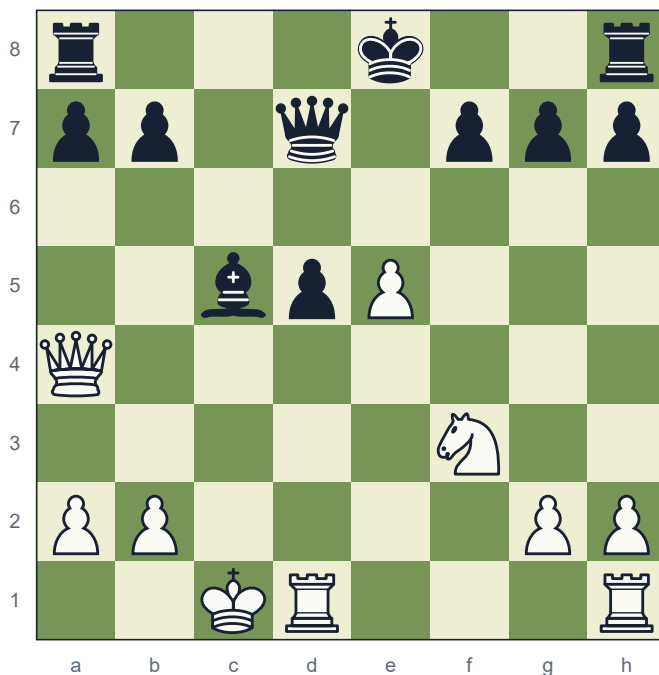
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The bishop captures a knight on c5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-05 / decision 3



COMPARE CANDIDATES

Qxd7+ and Qb3. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king c1; central-file pawns e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns d5, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE QXD7+

19. Qxd7+ Kxd7 20. Rxd5+ Kc6 21. Rhd1 Rac8 22. R5d3 Rhe8 Search estimate: +0.00 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE QB3

19. Qb3 Rd8 Search estimate: -1.25 from White's perspective.

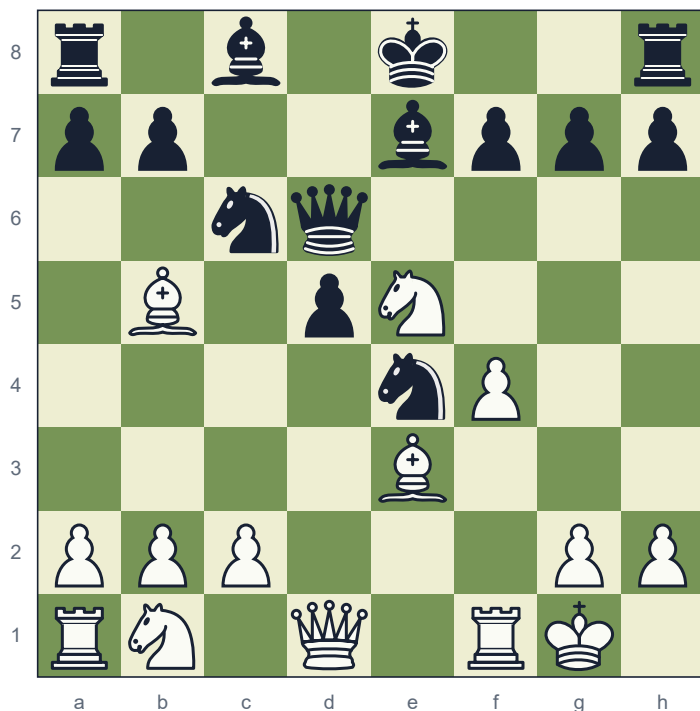
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The queen captures a queen on d7. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-06 / Falkbeer: the ...e4 wedge



Laboratory start - White to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

Black ignores the offered f-pawn and builds an advanced e4 wedge. d3 challenges it directly; exchanges change the position into a development battle.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f4. Black king e8; central-file pawns d5, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

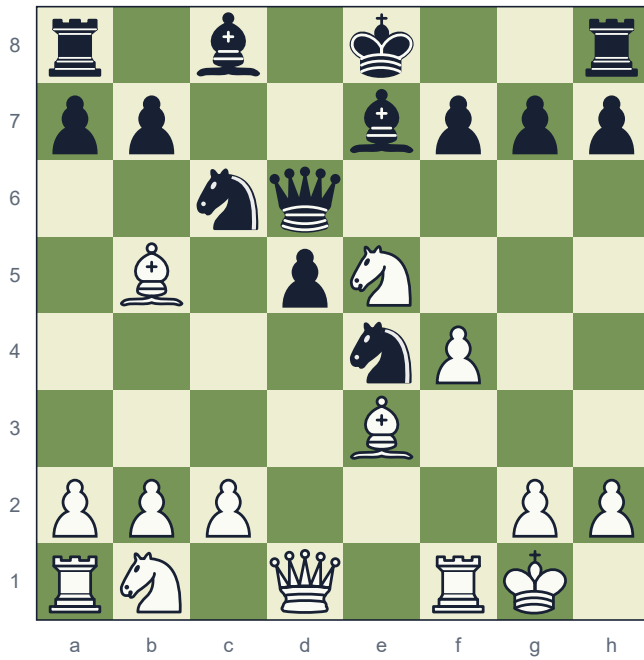
Black's development can be rapid and the king remains on e1. A greedy attempt to keep every extra pawn can allow a central attack. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

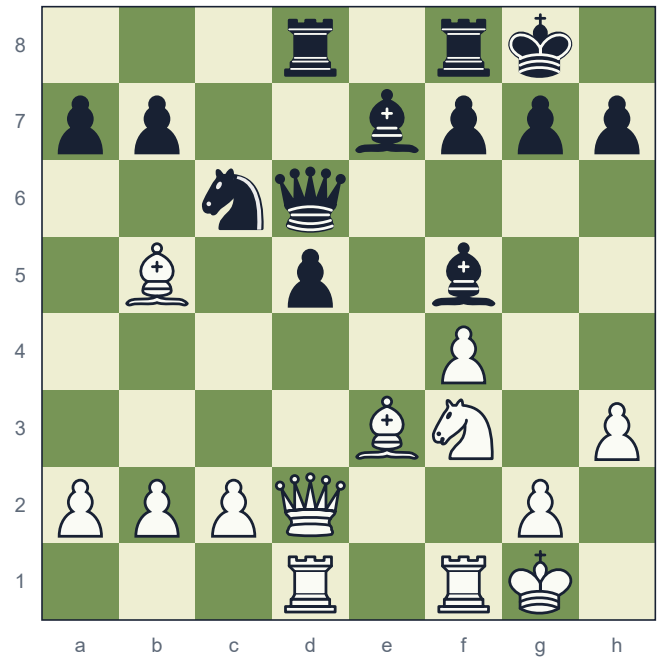
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

KG-LAB-06 / play and explain 1

11. Nd2 Nxd2 12. Qxd2 O-O 13. Nf3 Bg4 14. h3 Bf5 15. Rad1 Rad8



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

11. ND2

Places the knight on d2, attacking knight on e4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

13. NF3

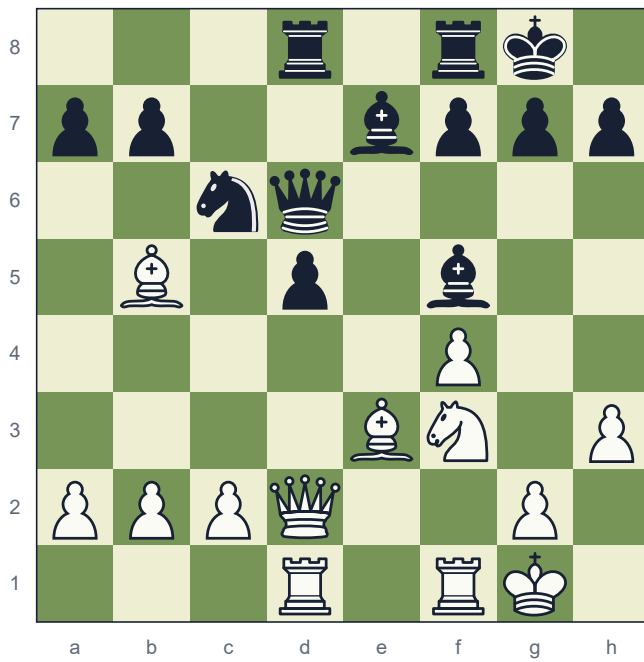
Develops the king knight toward e5 and d4. In the King's Gambit it also controls h4, making an immediate queen check there unattractive.

REASSESS

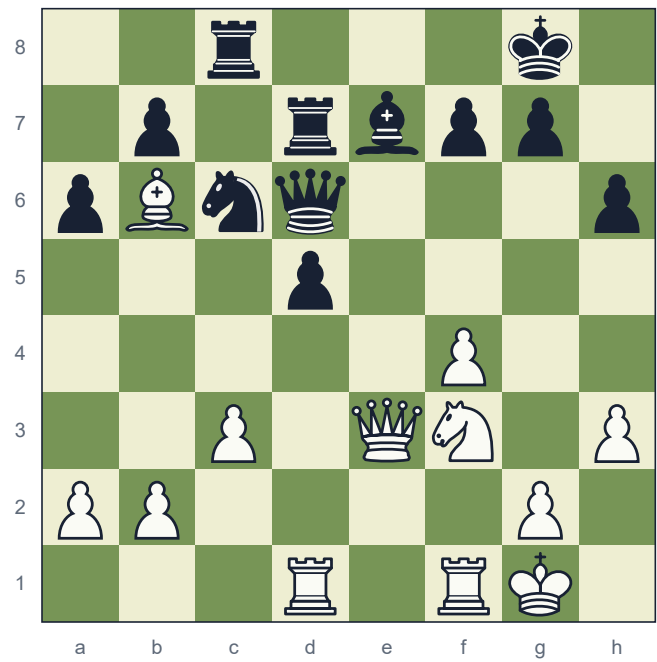
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

KG-LAB-06 / play and explain 2

16. c3 a6 17. Bd3 Bxd3 18. Qxd3 h6 19. Bb6 Rd7 20. Qe3 Rc8



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

16. C3

Places the pawn on c3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

18. QXD3

The queen captures a bishop on d3. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

KG-LAB-06 / decision 1



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nd2 and Bd3. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f4. Black king e8; central-file pawns d5, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE ND2

11. Nd2 Nxd2 12. Qxd2 O-O 13. Nf3 Bf5 14. c3 Be4 Search estimate: +0.03 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE BD3

11. Bd3 Nxe5 Search estimate: -0.25 from White's perspective.

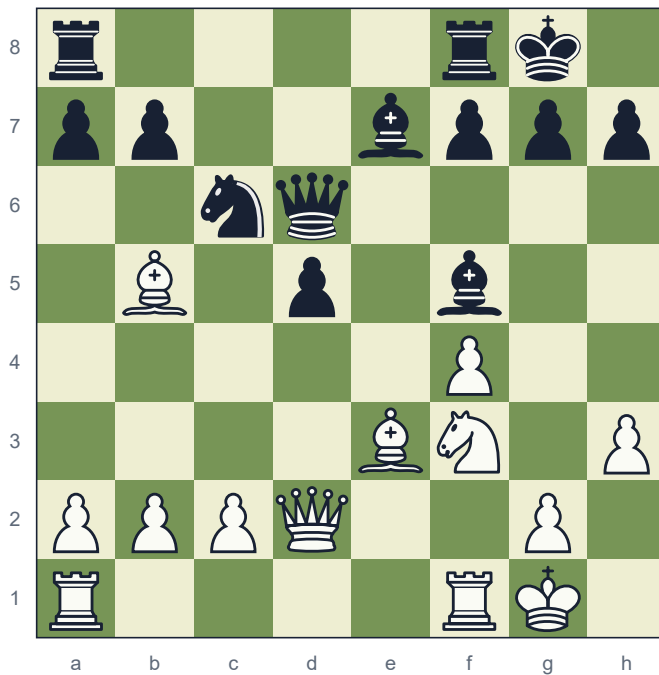
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the knight on d2, attacking knight on e4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-06 / decision 2



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Rad1 and c3. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f4. Black king g8; central-file pawns d5, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE RAD1

15. Rad1 Qg6 Search estimate: +0.13 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE C3

15. c3 h6 16. Rad1 Be4 17. Bd3 Qe6 18. Nd4 Nxd4 Search estimate: +0.04 from White's perspective.

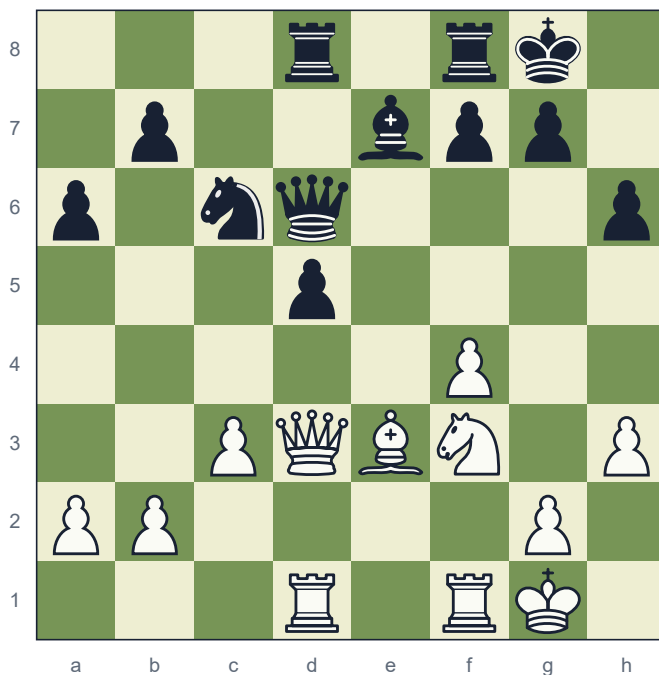
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the rook on d1. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

KG-LAB-06 / decision 3



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Bb6 and Qf5. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c3, f4. Black king g8; central-file pawns d5, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE BB6

19. Bb6 Rd7 20. Qe3 Rc8 21. Rd3 Qg6 22. Rfd1 Bd6 Search estimate: +0.16 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE QF5

19. Qf5 Bf6 20. Nh2 Ne7 21. Qh5 Rfe8 22. Ng4 g6 Search estimate: +0.08 from White's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the bishop on b6, attacking rook on d8. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

48 exercises / instructions

THREE KINDS OF QUESTION

Questions 1-24 test opening recall, 25-36 test plans and defense, and 37-48 compare concrete candidates from the laboratories. These are not all tactical puzzles and do not all have one uniquely best move.

WORK WITHOUT THE ANSWER

Use a board and write your answer. Spend two to five minutes on a recall question and five to ten on a candidate comparison. Name the opponent's threat before choosing your own move.

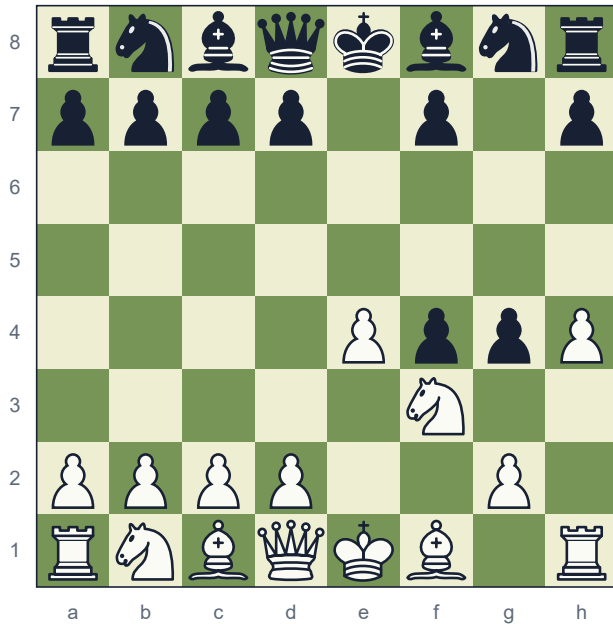
MARKING

Award one point for a legal, relevant choice or plan; one for a clear reason; one for recognizing the opponent's resource; and one for a supporting variation or accurate description of the structure. Maximum: 192. Do not reward memorized notation that you cannot explain.

ANSWERS ARE LATER

The question pages come first, followed by explained answers and sample continuations. In planning questions the sample answer is a guide, not an exhaustive list of reasonable plans.

Exercises 1-2



White to move

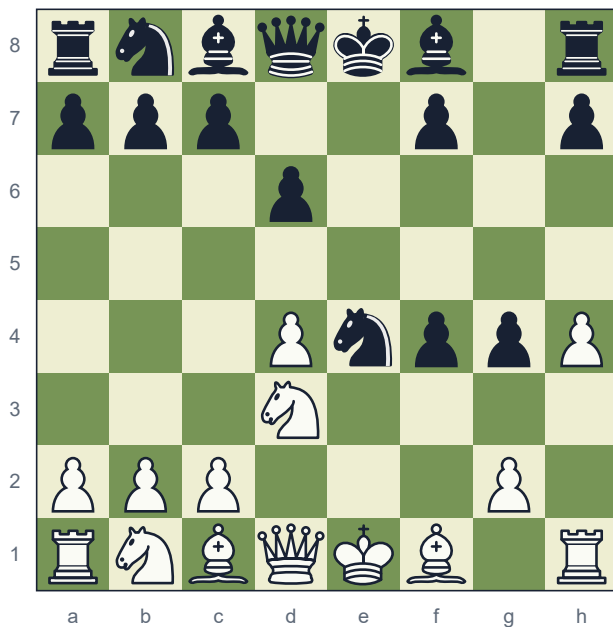
01 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

02 / OPENING RECALL

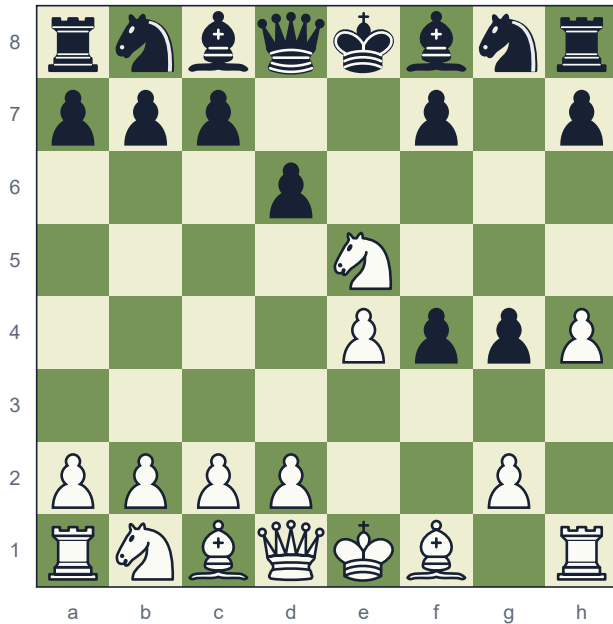
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 3-4



White to move

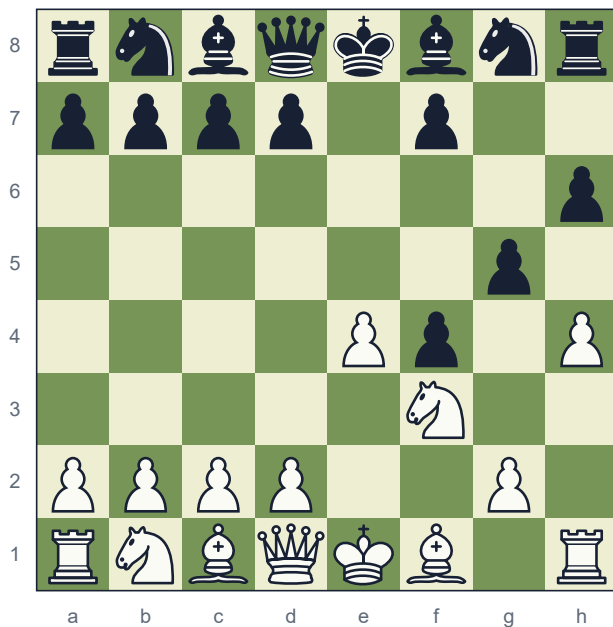
03 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

04 / OPENING RECALL

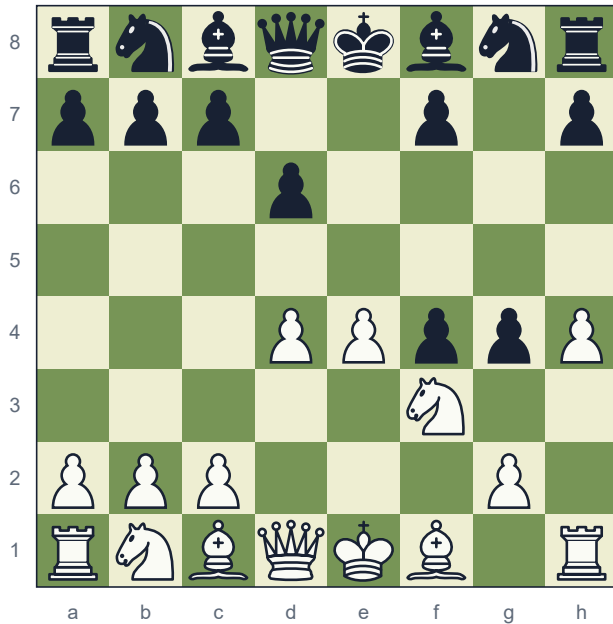
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 5-6



White to move

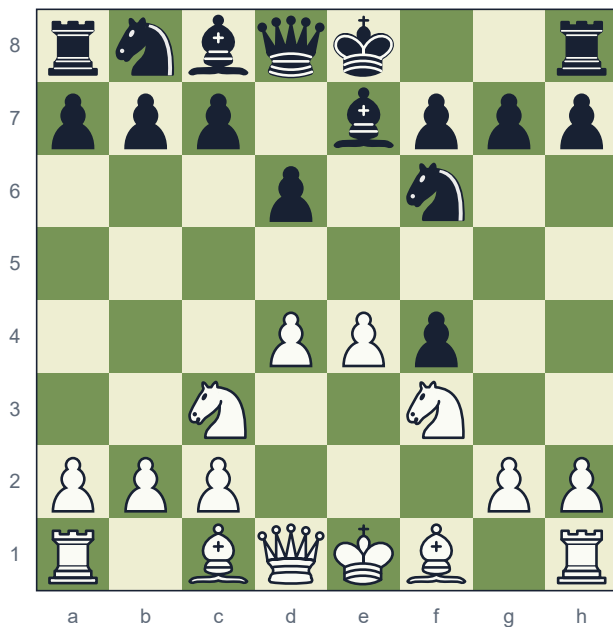
05 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

06 / OPENING RECALL

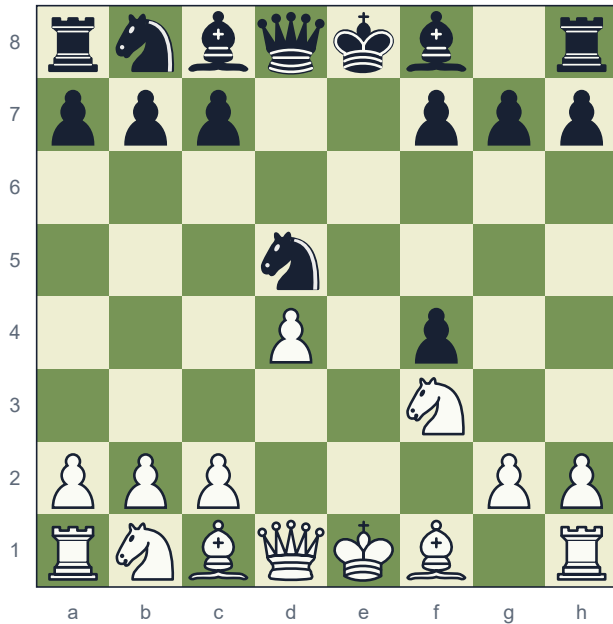
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 7-8



White to move

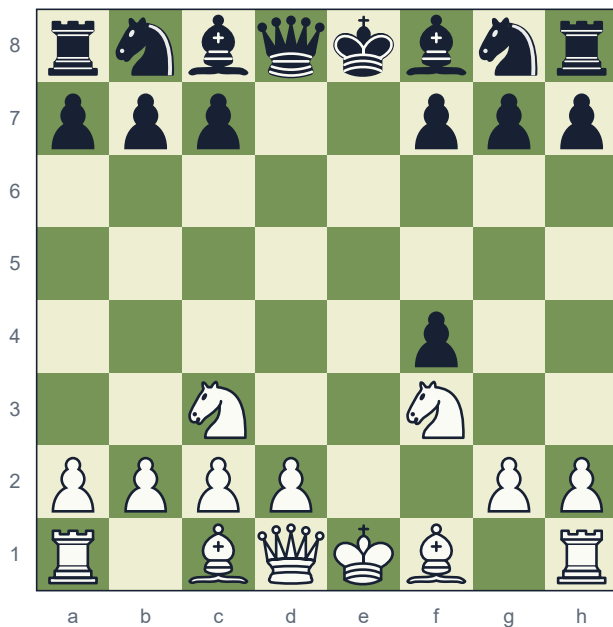
07 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

08 / OPENING RECALL

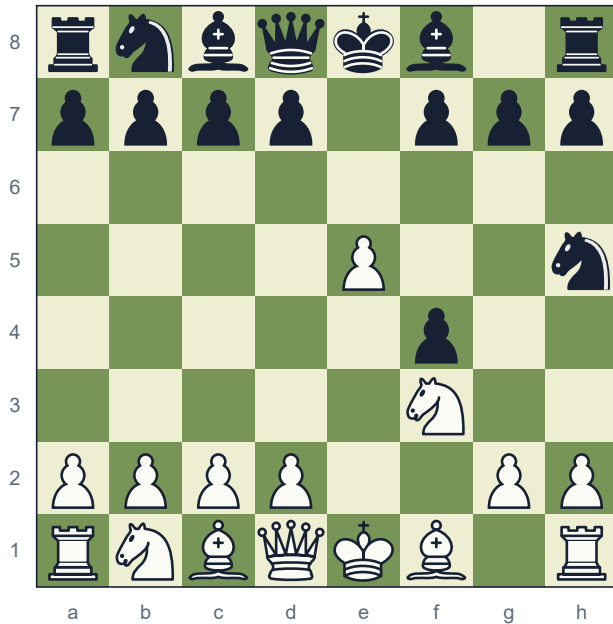
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 9-10



White to move

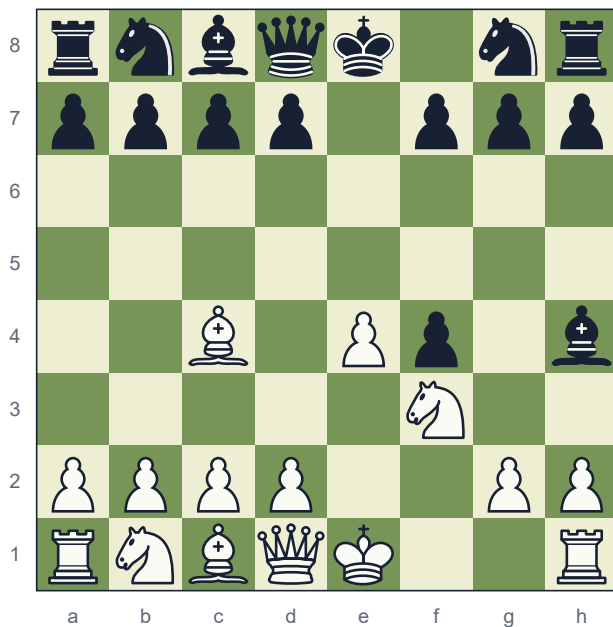
09 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move - in check

10 / OPENING RECALL

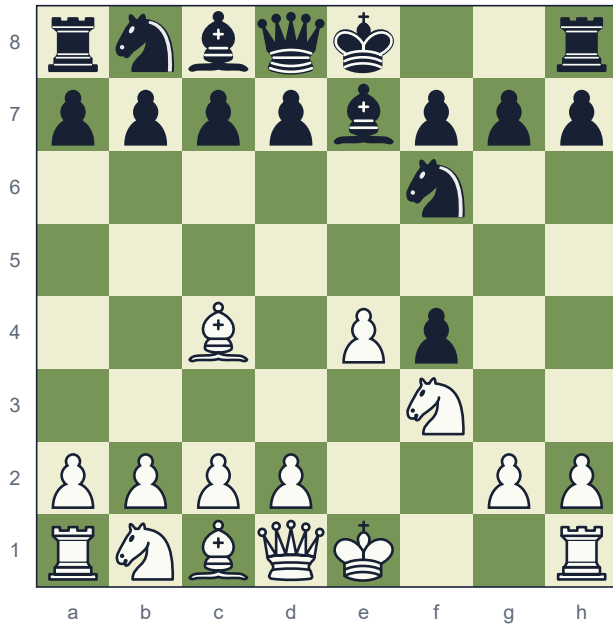
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 11-12



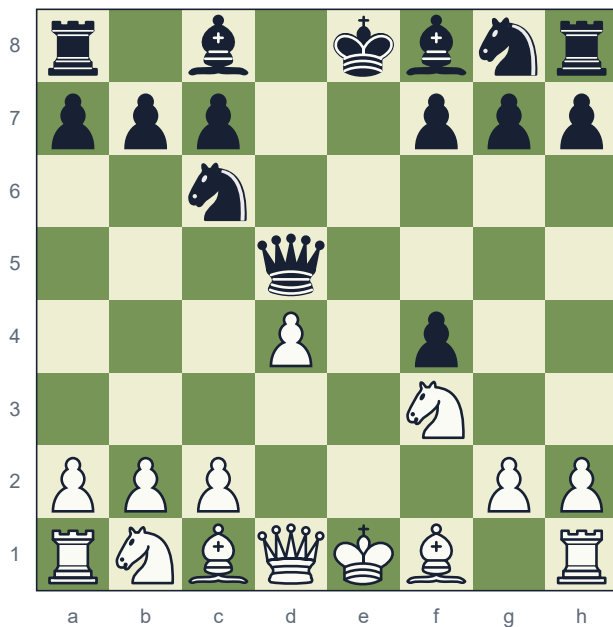
11 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



12 / OPENING RECALL

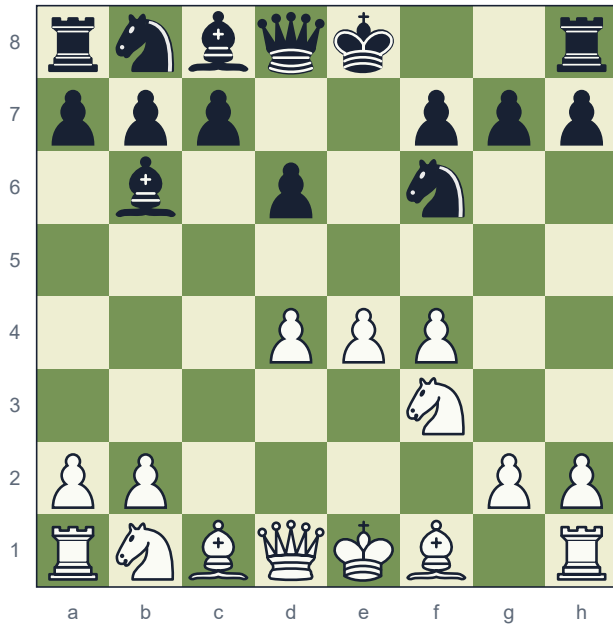
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 13-14



White to move

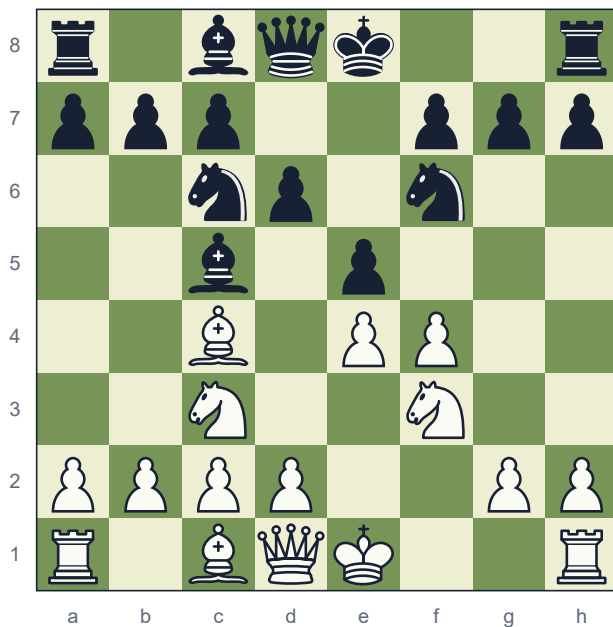
13 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

14 / OPENING RECALL

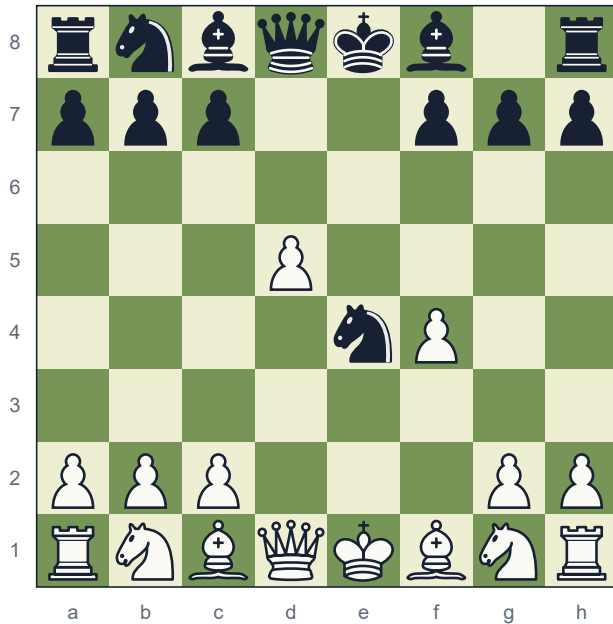
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 15-16



White to move

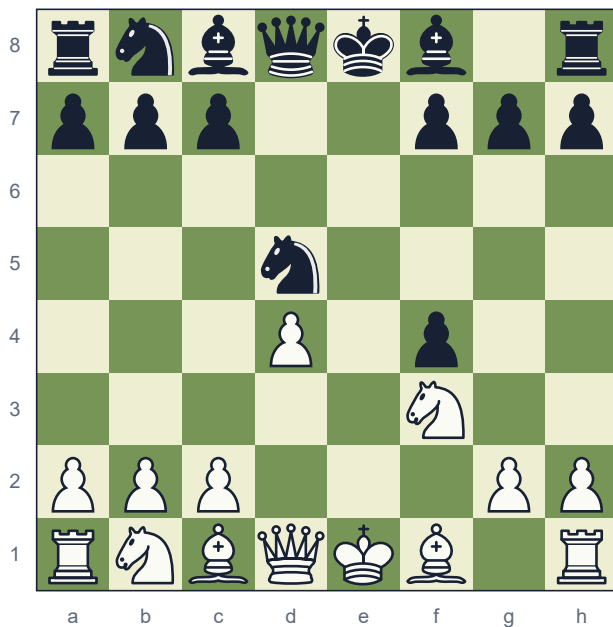
15 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

16 / OPENING RECALL

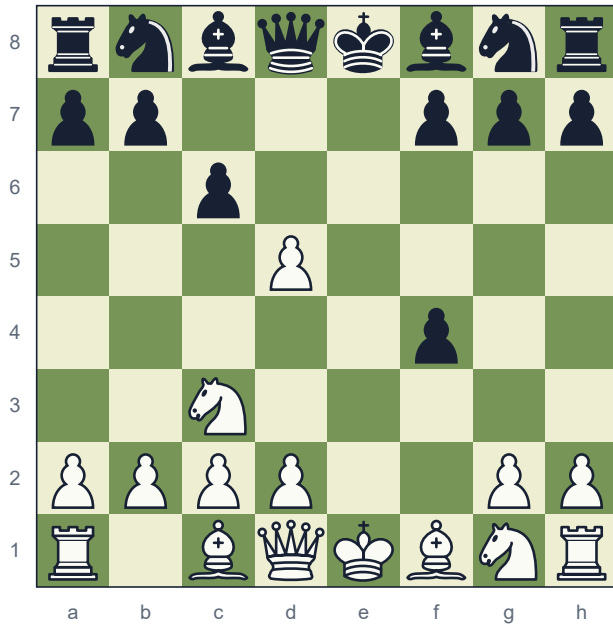
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 17-18



White to move

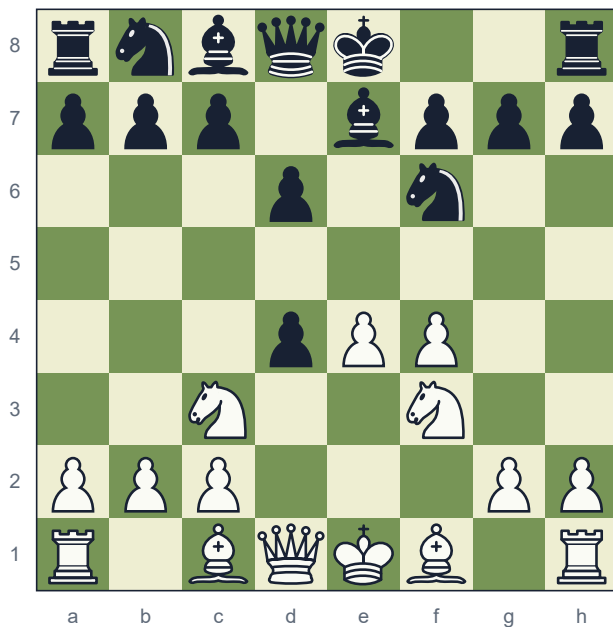
17 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

18 / OPENING RECALL

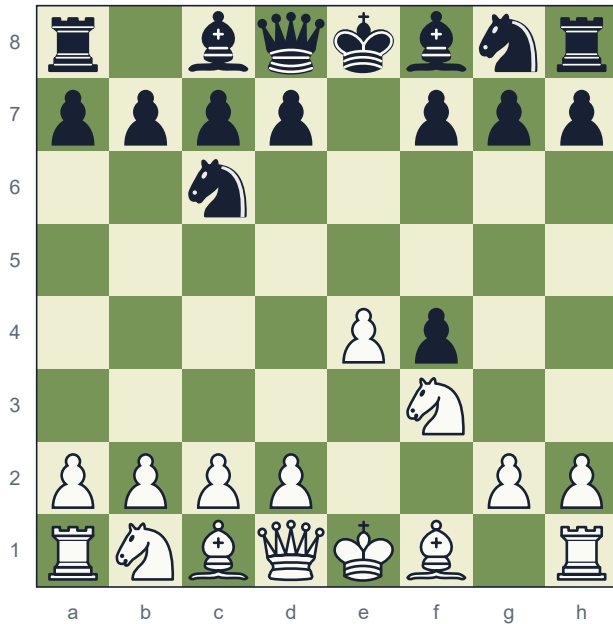
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 19-20



White to move

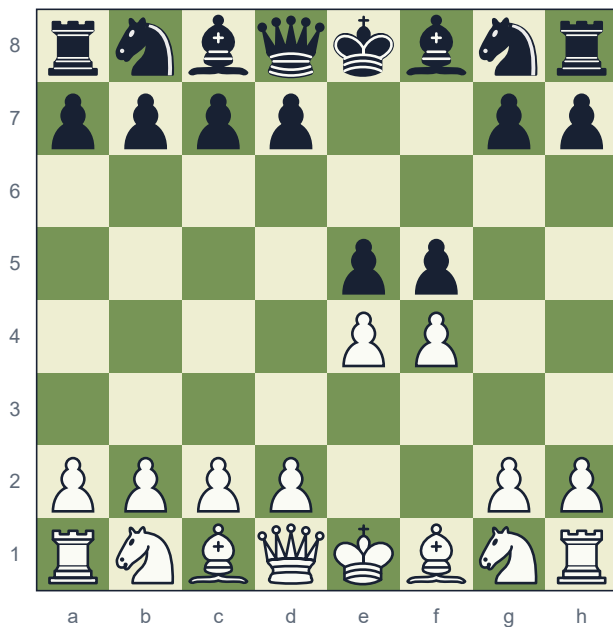
19 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

20 / OPENING RECALL

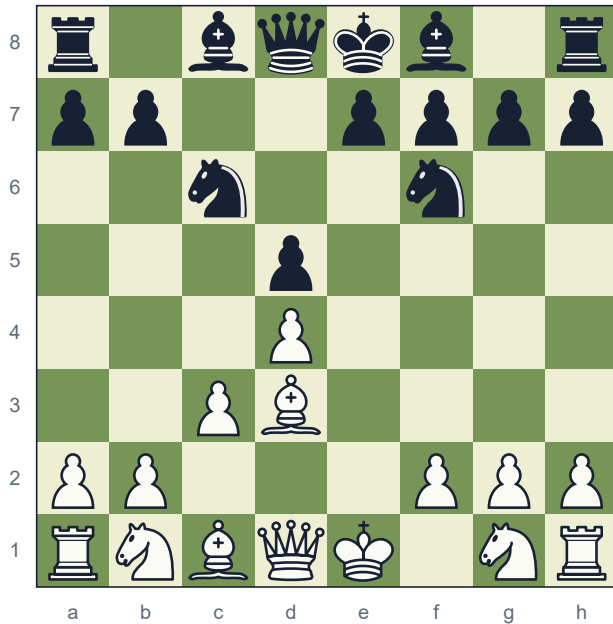
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 21-22



White to move

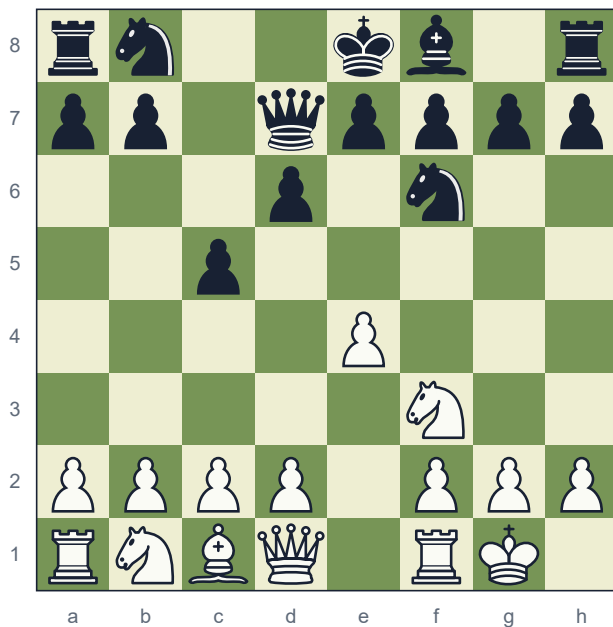
21 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

22 / OPENING RECALL

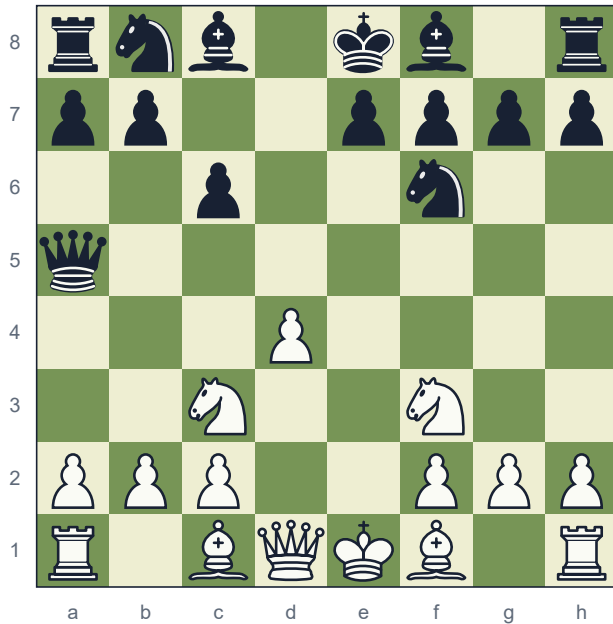
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 23-24



White to move

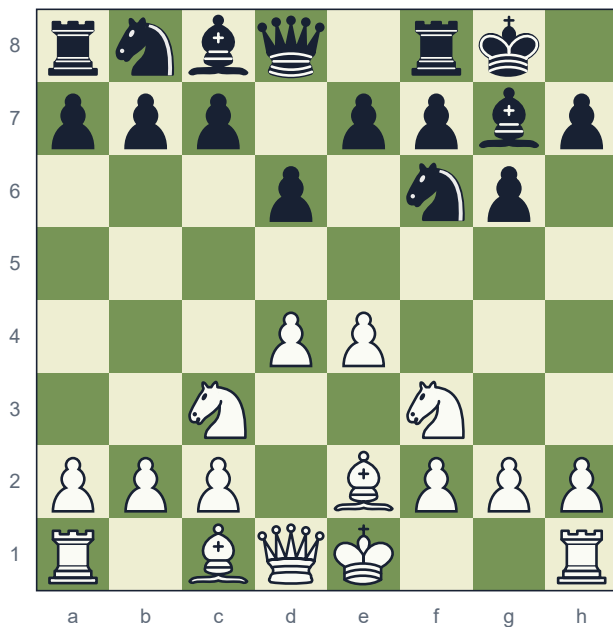
23 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

24 / OPENING RECALL

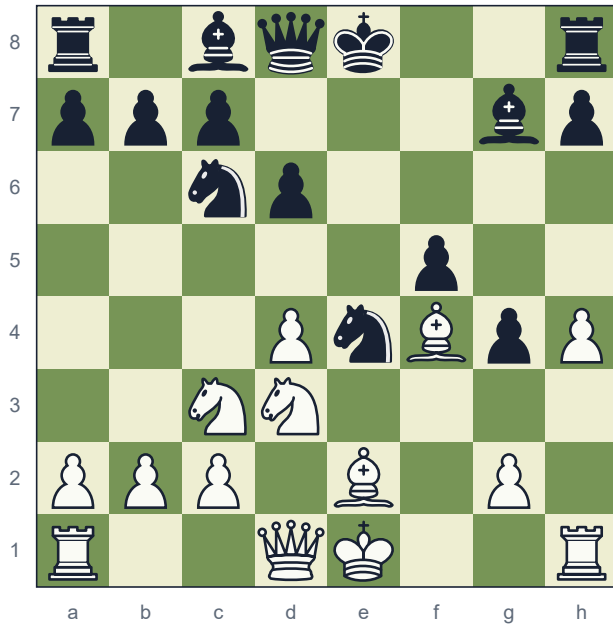
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 25-26



White to move

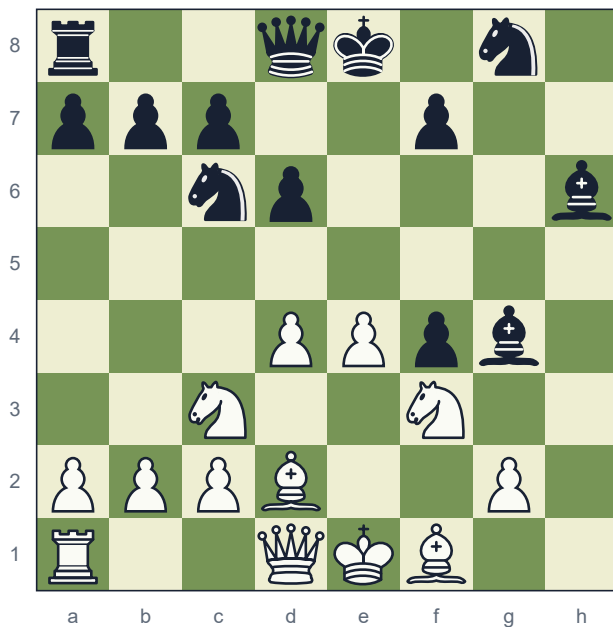
25 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

26 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

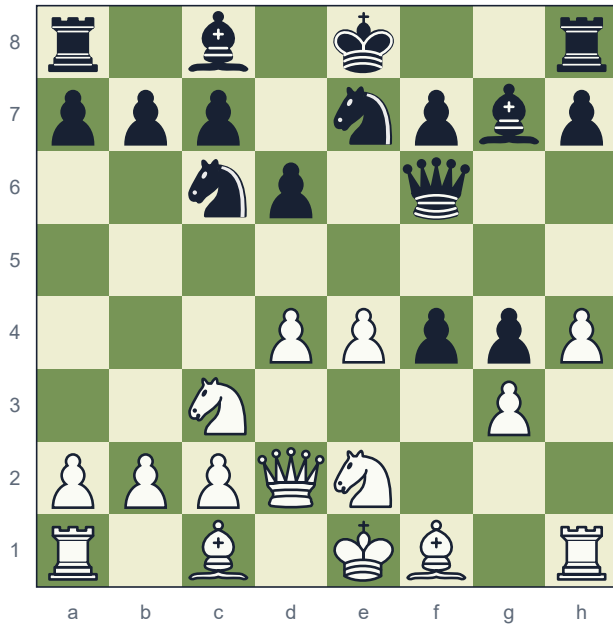
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 27-28



White to move

27 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

28 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

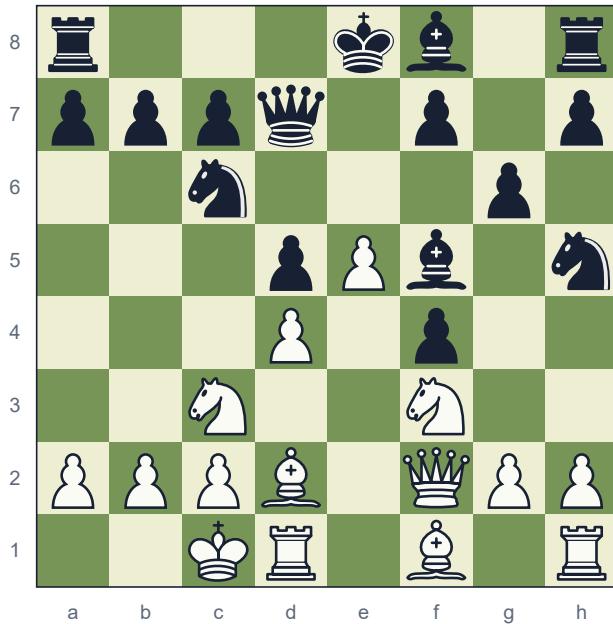
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 29-30



White to move

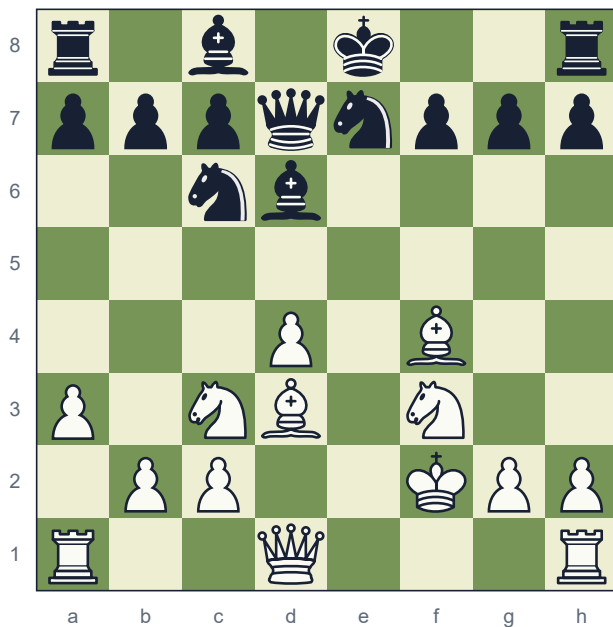
29 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

30 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

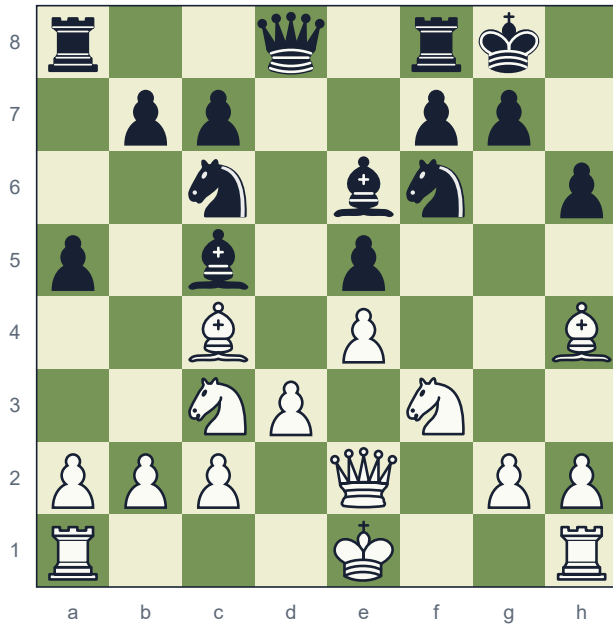
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 31-32



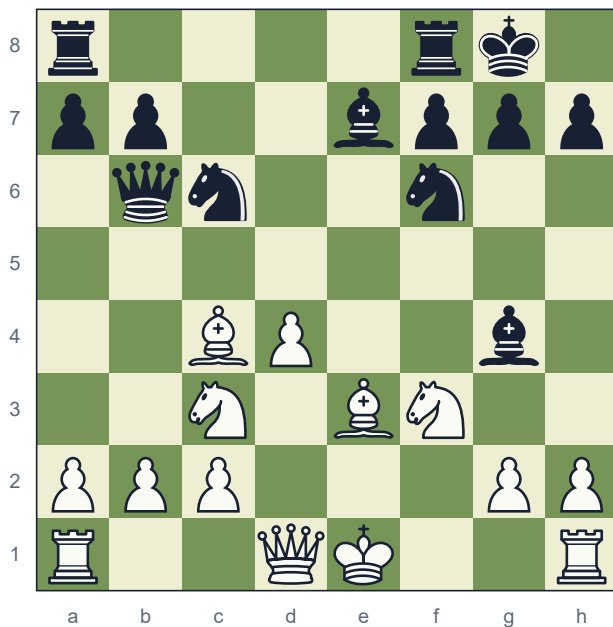
31 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



32 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

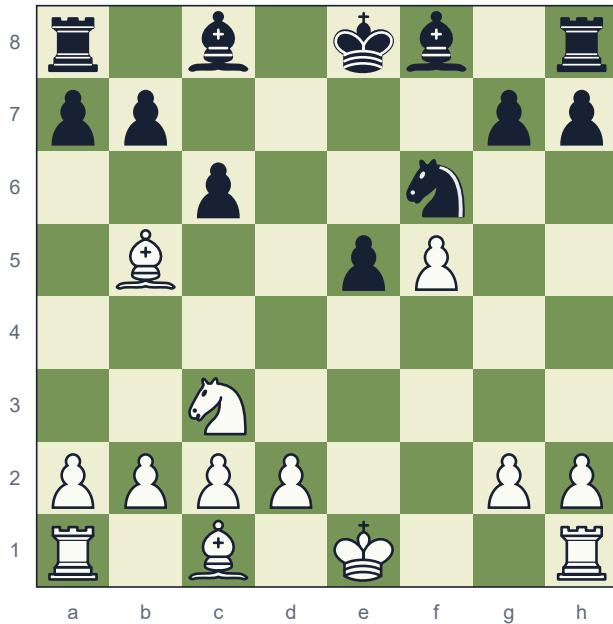
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 33-34



White to move

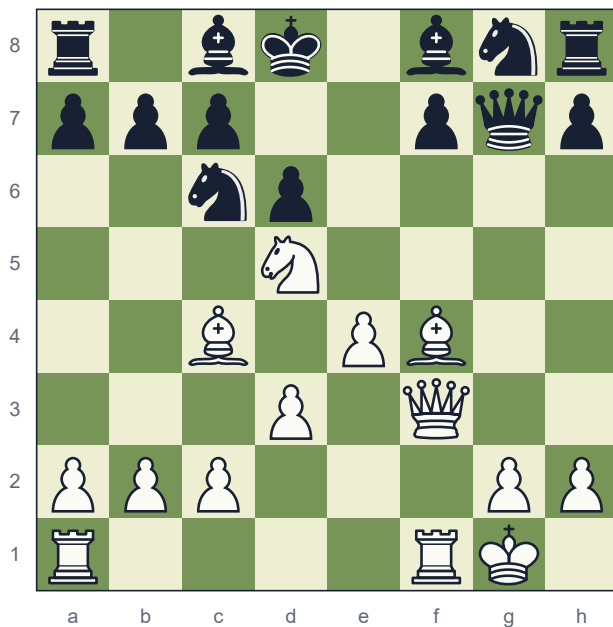
33 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

34 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

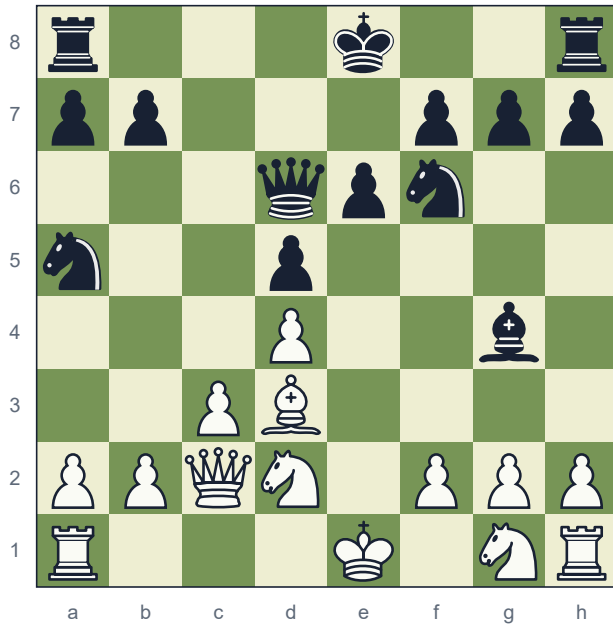
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 35-36



White to move

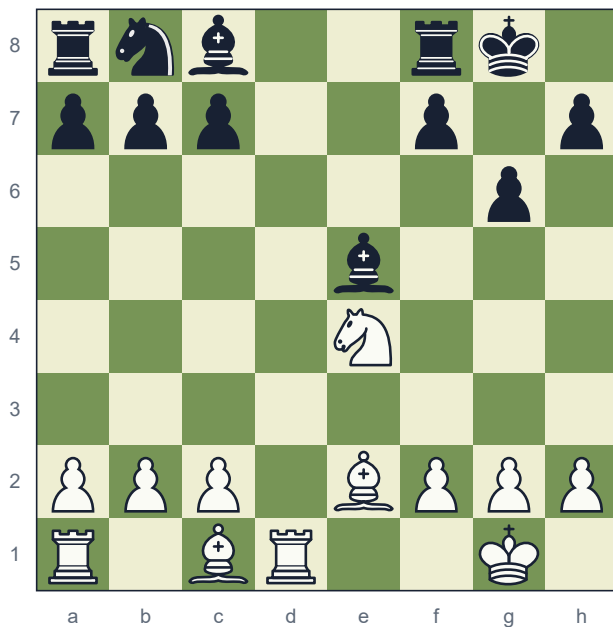
35 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

36 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

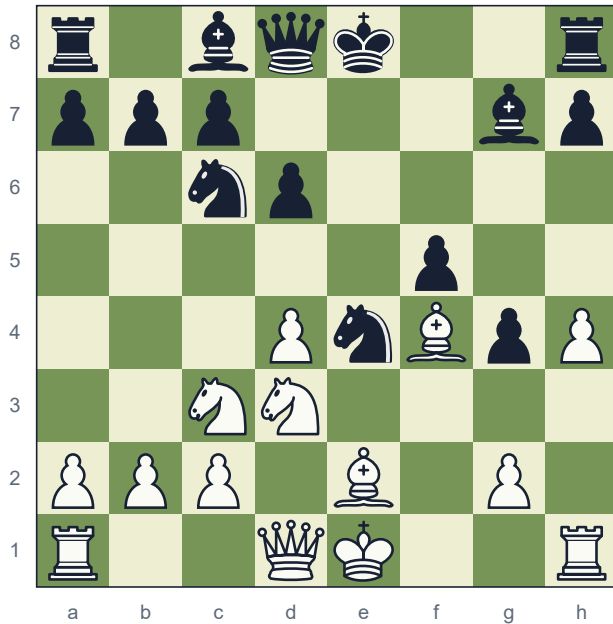
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 37-38



White to move

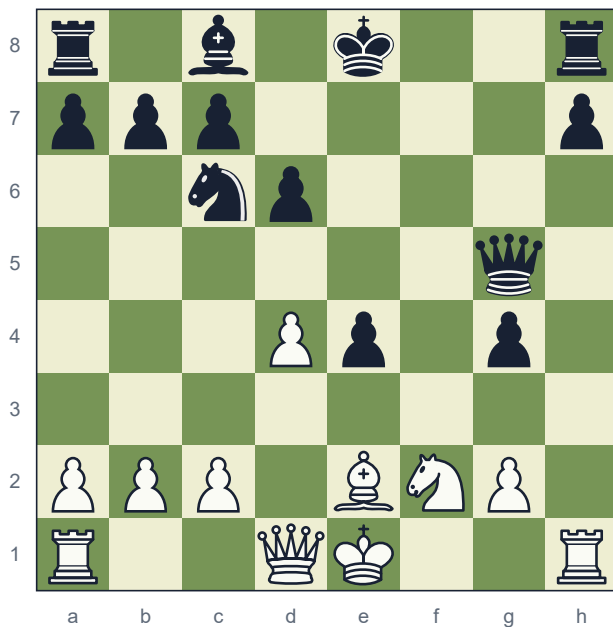
37 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Bxg4 with Nxe4. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

38 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

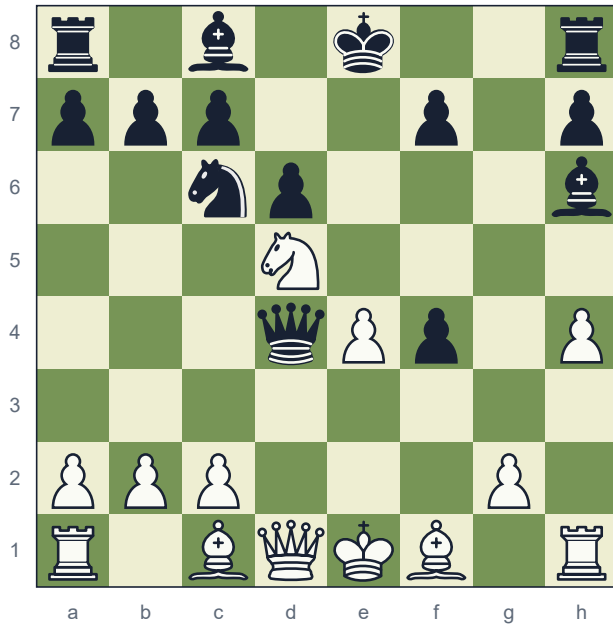
Compare Nxe4 with d5. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 39-40



White to move

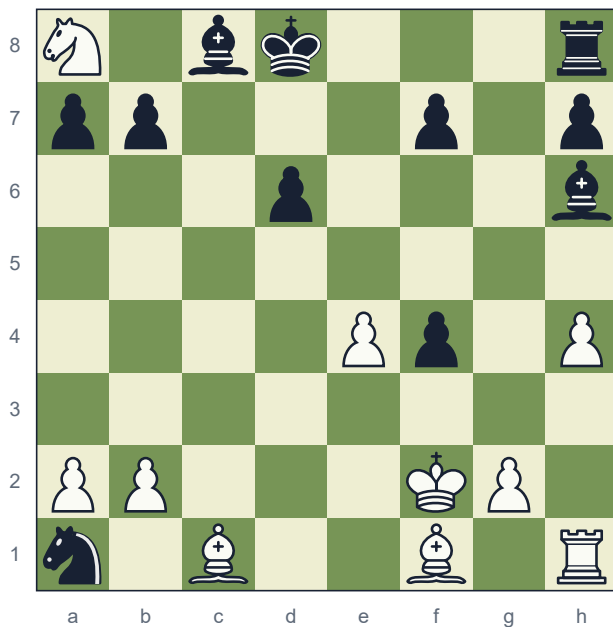
39 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Qxd4 with Nxc7+. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

40 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

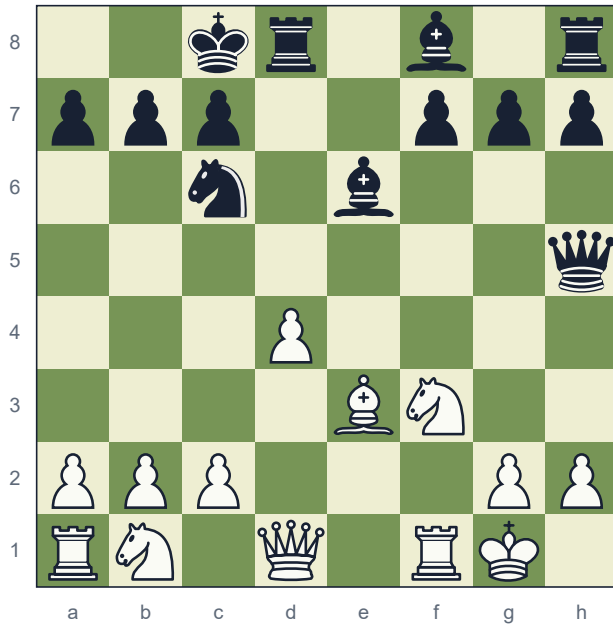
Compare Bd3 with b3. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 41-42



White to move

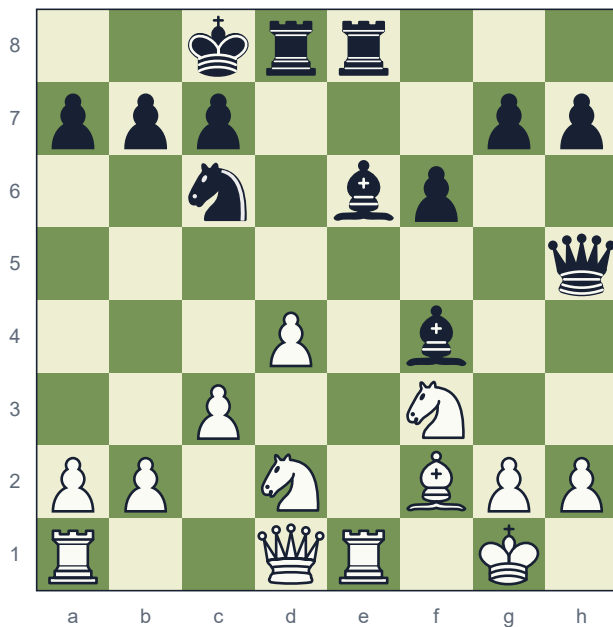
41 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare c3 with Nbd2. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

42 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Nf1 with Bg3. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 43-44



White to move

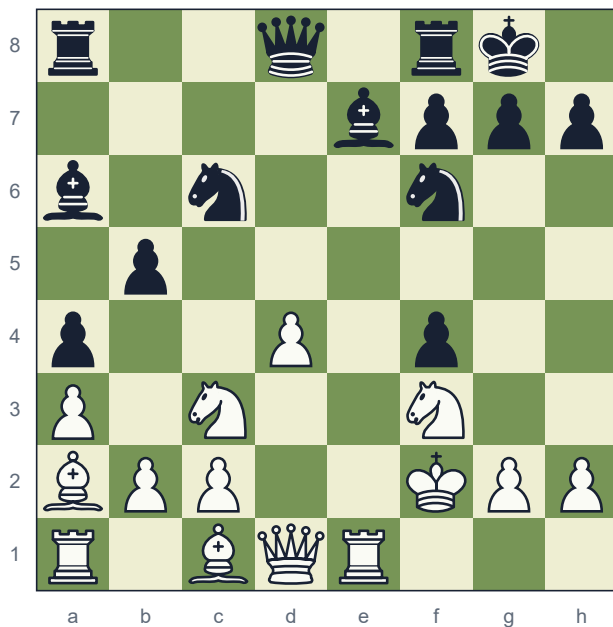
43 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Bxf4 with exd5. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

44 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

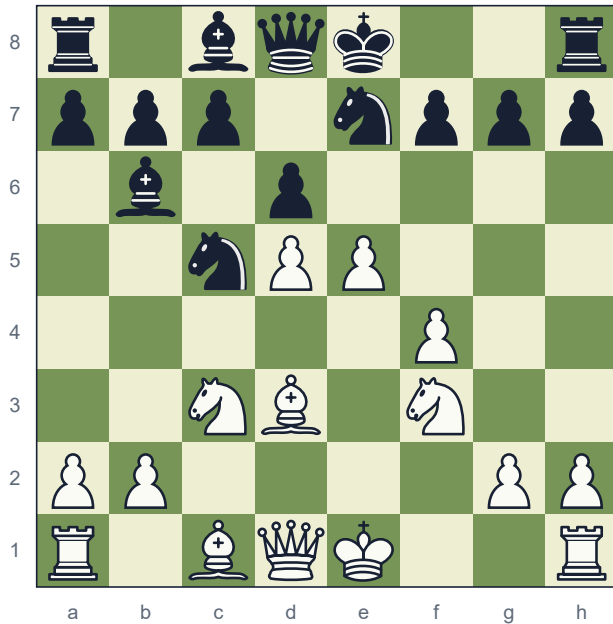
Compare Bxf4 with Kg1. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 45-46



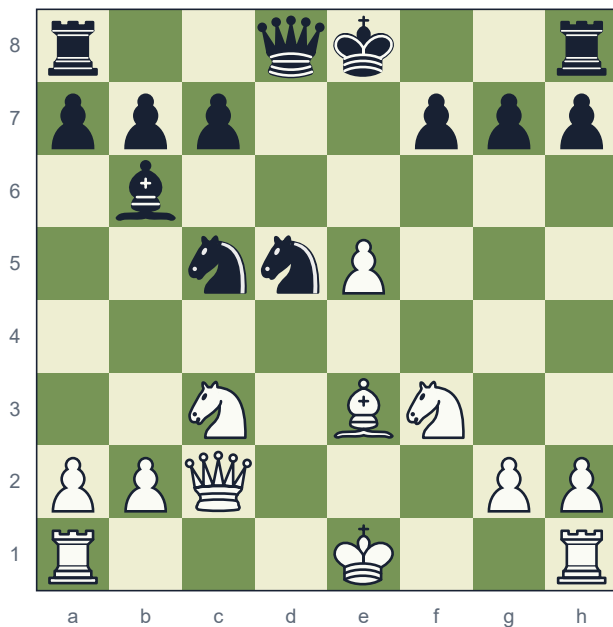
45 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Bc4 with Bc2. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



46 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

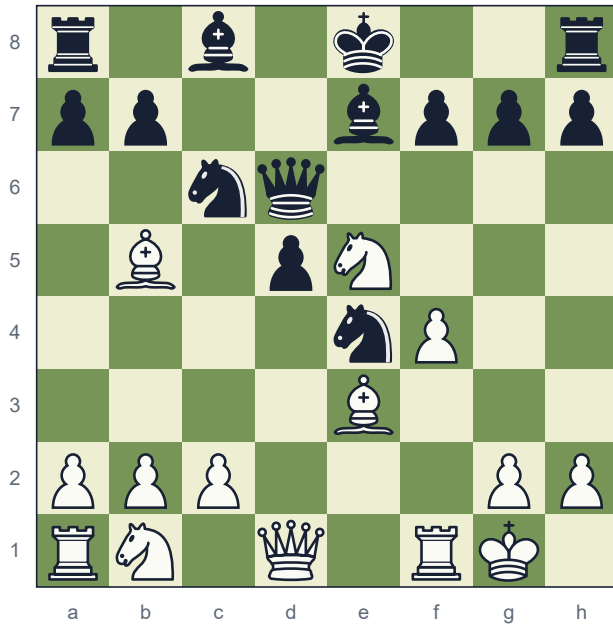
Compare Bxc5 with O-O-O. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 47-48



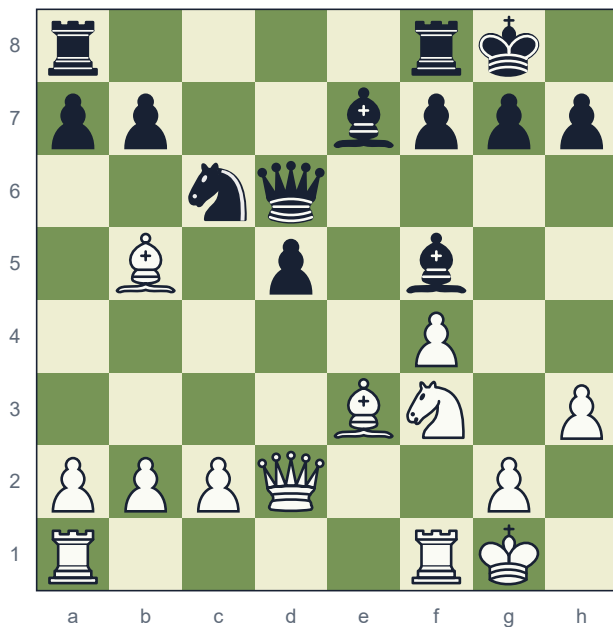
47 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Bd3 with Nd2. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



48 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Rad1 with c3. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Answers 1-2

01 / KG-01

Course move: 5. Ne5. Nf3 prevents an immediate queen check on h4. Black uses ...g5 to keep f4, so h4 attacks the supporting chain. After ...g4 the knight must move; Ne5 takes an active central post.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. Ne5 Nf6 6. d4 d6 7. Nd3 Nxe4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can play ...Nf6 against e4 and ...d6 against Ne5. Count the defenders of e4 before chasing f7.

02 / KG-02

Course move: 8. Bxf4. The retreat Nd3 keeps the knight protected and allows the bishop to recover f4. Black takes e4, so material recovery alone has not won the opening.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

8. Bxf4 Qe7 9. Be2 Nc6 10. Nc3 Nxc3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black's knight is active and your king remains central. A speculative attack on f7 can lose time against ...Bg7 and ...O-O.

Answers 3-4

03 / KG-03

Course move: 6. Nxg4. Black attacks Ne5 with the d-pawn, but the knight can capture the advanced g4 pawn while escaping. This concrete resource is stronger than mechanically retreating to d3 in this exact position.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Nxg4 Nc6 7. Nc3 Nf6 8. Nxf6+ Qxf6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

A similar position with an extra black developing move can change the tactics. Do not treat Nxg4 as universal whenever ...d6 attacks Ne5.

04 / KG-04

Course move: 5. hxg5. White captures on g5 immediately, testing the supporting pawn chain before building d4. The exact recapture matters because the h-file and rook on h8 can become tactically relevant.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. hxg5 Bg7 6. gxh6 Rxh6 7. Rxh6 Bxh6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black may develop with ...Bg7 or use the center. A careless capture can open a rook line against an undeveloped position.

Answers 5-6

05 / KG-07

Course move: 6. Ng1. Black's ...d6 controls e5, so the Kieseritzky knight jump is unavailable. Ng1 is a deliberate retreat preserving the knight after the g-pawn advance.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Ng1 Qf6 7. Nc3 Ne7 8. Nge2 Bh6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Playing Ne5 as if ...d6 were absent simply leaves the knight vulnerable. Black also threatens to complete development while you spend another knight tempo.

06 / KG-08

Course move: 6. Bxf4. Black returns the extra pawn to develop smoothly. White obtains a center and normal pieces, but should not expect a forced attack.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Bxf4 O-O 7. Bd3 Nc6 8. a3 Bg4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can challenge the center with ...d5 or ...c5. An undefended e4 pawn can become the target of ...Nxe4 tactics.

Answers 7-8

07 / KG-09

Course move: 6. Bc4. Black exchanges central pawns and develops toward the returned material. Bc4 creates pressure while White builds a useful d4 center.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Bc4 Be6 7. Bxd5 Qxd5 8. O-O Nc6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can exchange pieces and neutralize the initiative. Do not sacrifice more material merely because the opening began as a gambit.

08 / KG-10

Course move: 6. d4. Nc3 develops while attacking the queen. After her retreat White has gained time, but still needs to complete development and address f4.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. d4 Bd6 7. Bc4 Bf5 8. O-O Nc6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

A queen chased once is not trapped. Black can catch up if White spends several moves trying to hunt it.

Answers 9-10

09 / KG-12

Course move: 5. d4. e5 attacks the knight, which heads to h5 to help preserve f4. Black challenges the advanced e-pawn with ...d6.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. d4 d6 6. Qe2 d5 7. Nc3 Nc6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

The h5 knight still influences f4 and g3. Do not push g4 without calculating ...fxg3 en passant when legal and the effect on king safety.

10 / KG-13

Course move: 5. Kf1. The bishop reaches h4 with check along the diagonal to e1. Kf1 answers it without pushing more kingside pawns, but permanently gives up castling.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. Kf1 c6 6. Nc3 b5 7. Bb3 a5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can open the center with ...d5. Do not continue a routine castling plan after the king has moved.

Answers 11-12

11 / KG-14

Course move: 5. e5. White gains space with e5 and Black places the knight actively. The g4 knight can create threats against e5 or f2; its location is more important than a general developing rule.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. e5 Ng4 6. O-O O-O 7. d4 d5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Bxf7+ is not automatically sound. Black's king may survive while your pieces lack support.

12 / KG-15

Course move: 6. Nc3. Black develops and then hits the center. Nc3 gains a queen tempo, but the exchanges also release Black's pieces.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Nc3 Bb4 7. Bd3 Qe6+ 8. Kf2 Nge7

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can answer a threat with a check or a capture. Verify the queen's active squares before assuming a free attack.

Answers 13-14

13 / KG-17

Course move: 7. Nc3. White uses c3 to support d4 while the bishop keeps pressure on the king side. Exchanging in the center gives White space but opens lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7. Nc3 Nc6 8. e5 Nd7 9. d5 Ne7

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

The c5-b6 bishop watches the sensitive f2 square. Capturing e5 at the wrong time may permit ...Qh4+ and a king attack.

14 / KG-18

Course move: 6. d3. Both sides develop naturally. White keeps the option of a later f-pawn exchange without forcing an immediate central confrontation.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. d3 a5 7. fxe5 dxe5 8. Bg5 h6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can use ...Bg4 to pin Nf3 or open the center. Do not weaken the king with repeated pawn moves while pieces remain at home.

Answers 15-16

15 / KG-19

Course move: 6. Nf3. Black ignores the offered f-pawn and builds an advanced e4 wedge. d3 challenges it directly; exchanges change the position into a development battle.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Nf3 c6 7. Be3 cxd5 8. Bb5+ Nc6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black's development can be rapid and the king remains on e1. A greedy attempt to keep every extra pawn can allow a central attack.

16 / KG-20

Course move: 6. Bc4. Capturing f4 after ...d5 produces the same type of position as the Modern Defense. The move order differs, but the central exchanges and piece tasks converge.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Bc4 Be6 7. Qe2 Bb4+ 8. c3 Be7

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

An extra tempo or a different knight square can break a transposition. Compare the actual board before importing a memorized continuation.

Answers 17-18

17 / KG-21

Course move: 5. Nf3. White declines to spend another tempo taking a wing pawn and develops. Black sacrifices or returns material to obtain central and diagonal activity.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. Nf3 Be7 6. Bc4 Nf6 7. dxc6 Nxc6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Capturing c6 blindly can give Black easy development with ...Nxc6. The point is the resulting activity, not the label countergambit.

18 / KG-22

Course move: 6. Nxd4. Black supports e5 and later exchanges it. White recaptures actively with the knight and gains space without an immediate sacrifice.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Nxd4 O-O 7. Be2 c5 8. Nf3 Nc6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black's restrained setup can still strike with ...d5. Do not assume that a passive-looking opening removes tactical obligations.

Answers 19-20

19 / KG-23

Course move: 4. d4. Black may decline for one move and accept later. The position enters accepted-gambit territory with the queen knight already developed.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

4. d4 Nf6 5. Qe2 Bd6 6. e5 O-O

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Memorizing only move two misses the transposition. Black may choose ...d5 before trying to defend f4.

20 / KG-24

Course move: 3. exf5. Capturing e5 is not the only way to respond to Black's central pawn action. exf5 exchanges the advanced f-pawn and leaves a concrete position to calculate.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

3. exf5 Qe7 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Nc3 Nf6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

The exposed kings and open diagonals make routine moves unreliable. A queen check can be more urgent than recovering another pawn.

Answers 21-22

21 / KG-29

Course move: 6. Bf4. The Exchange Caro-Kann bridge creates a clear pawn structure. Bf4 develops the queen bishop before e3 would block it.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Bf4 Bg4 7. Qb3 Na5 8. Qc2 e6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can exchange the light-squared bishop or challenge the center. This is a companion starting line, not a complete Caro-Kann repertoire.

22 / KG-30

Course move: 6. Re1. Against ...d6 the check on b5 is a practical bridge. The bishop exchange simplifies development but gives up the bishop pair.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Re1 Nc6 7. c3 e6 8. d4 cxd4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black's queen recapture affects d4 and the d-file. This line cannot stand in for all Sicilian variations.

Answers 23-24

23 / KG-31

Course move: 6. Bc4. White gains a developing tempo against the queen and occupies the center. This normal response complements the gambit repertoire when Black immediately attacks e4.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Bc4 Bg4 7. h3 Qh5 8. Be2 e6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black often plays ...Bf5 and ...e6. A pin on the c3 knight can affect whether d4 is actually defended.

24 / KG-32

Course move: 6. O-O. White takes the center and develops normally against a fianchetto. This bridge does not require sacrificing the f-pawn or launching an immediate attack.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. O-O e5 7. dxe5 dxe5 8. Nxe5 Nxe4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

A large center can become a target. The g7 bishop becomes active when central pawns exchange.

Answers 25-26

25 / KG-01

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns f5, d6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop Bc4 or d4 according to Black's reply, then solve king safety. The h-file may open for either side; do not assume the rook alone creates an attack.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can play ...Nf6 against e4 and ...d6 against Ne5. Count the defenders of e4 before chasing f7. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

26 / KG-04

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, d4, e4. Black king e8; central-file pawns f4, d6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Follow the printed continuation and finish development. Recount material after the whole exchange rather than assuming every pawn contact has an automatic recapture.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black may develop with ...Bg7 or use the center. A careless capture can open a rook line against an undeveloped position. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 27-28

27 / KG-07

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, d4, e4. Black king e8; central-file pawns f4, d6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Use the broad center and develop the bishops. The knight must return to play, often through e2 or h3 according to the concrete line.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Playing Ne5 as if ...d6 were absent simply leaves the knight vulnerable. Black also threatens to complete development while you spend another knight tempo. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

28 / KG-09

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king c8; central-file pawns c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Castle, develop Nc3 and decide whether the f4 pawn is worth a separate tempo. A lead in development is valuable only if the pieces have targets.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can exchange pieces and neutralize the initiative. Do not sacrifice more material merely because the opening began as a gambit. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 29-30

29 / KG-12

White to move. White king c1; central-file pawns c2, d4, e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns f4, d5, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop Bc4 or Bd3 as appropriate and examine exd6 only after considering the recapture. White must maintain central support while the knight is offside.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

The h5 knight still influences f4 and g3. Do not push g4 without calculating ...fxg3 en passant when legal and the effect on king safety. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

30 / KG-15

White to move. White king f2; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Complete development and compare queen retreats before choosing a bishop square. A broad center is useful only while it remains defended.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can answer a threat with a check or a capture. Verify the queen's active squares before assuming a free attack. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 31-32

31 / KG-18

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, d3, e4. Black king g8; central-file pawns e5, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Castle, identify whether d4 is achievable and improve the least active piece. A quiet maneuvering game is a normal outcome of a gambit being declined.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can use ...Bg4 to pin Nf3 or open the center. Do not weaken the king with repeated pawn moves while pieces remain at home. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

32 / KG-21

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Stabilize the d-pawn if it is useful, otherwise let material return for development. Check the c-file and queen routes after any dxc6 capture.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Capturing c6 blindly can give Black easy development with ...Nxc6. The point is the resulting activity, not the label countergambit. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 33-34

33 / KG-24

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, d2, f5. Black king e8; central-file pawns e5, c6. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop Nf3 and choose d4 when safe. Study Black's checks and central captures before treating the extra pawn as secure.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

The exposed kings and open diagonals make routine moves unreliable. A queen check can be more urgent than recovering another pawn. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

34 / KG-26

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, d3, e4. Black king d8; central-file pawns d6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Calculate forcing play against f7 and e8 before making another sacrifice. Compare attack speed with Black's defensive resources and possible queen exchanges.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black need not cooperate with a famous mating pattern. If the attack stops, White is a piece down rather than merely a pawn down. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 35-36

35 / KG-29

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns f2, c3, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns d5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Finish development and castle. Watch the c-file and choose a useful knight square without obstructing your own pieces.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can exchange the light-squared bishop or challenge the center. This is a companion starting line, not a complete Caro-Kann repertoire. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

36 / KG-32

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2. Black king g8; central-file pawns c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Complete development and support e4 before choosing d5 or a kingside expansion. Black's ...c5 and ...e5 are the breaks to monitor.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

A large center can become a target. The g7 bishop becomes active when central pawns exchange. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 37-38

37 / KG-LAB-01

The finite search prefers Nxe4 (-0.94 from White's perspective), compared with Bxg4 (-1.89 from White's perspective). The knight captures a knight on e4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. Nxe4 fxe4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. Bxg4 O-O 12. Bf3 Nxd4 13. Ne2 Re8 14. c3 Nxe2

38 / KG-LAB-01

The finite search prefers Nxe4 (-0.82 from White's perspective), compared with d5 (-1.55 from White's perspective). The knight captures a pawn on e4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Nxe4 Qg6 16. Ng3 Bd7 17. Qd3 O-O-O 18. Qxg6 hxg6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. d5 Ne5 16. Nxe4 Qg6 17. Ng3 h5 18. Qd4 h4

Answers 39-40

39 / KG-LAB-02

The finite search prefers Nxc7+ (+0.31 from White's perspective), compared with Qxd4 (+0.32 from White's perspective). The knight captures a pawn on c7. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. Nxc7+ Kd8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. Qxd4 Nxd4 12. Nxc7+ Kd8 13. Nxa8 Nxc2+ 14. Kf2 Nxa1

40 / KG-LAB-02

The finite search prefers Bd3 (+0.04 from White's perspective), compared with b3 (-0.81 from White's perspective). Places the bishop on d3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Bd3 Rg8 16. Bd2 Rg3 17. Bb5 Nc2 18. Rc1 Ne3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. b3 Nc2 16. Bb2 Rg8 17. Bf6+ Kd7 18. Bb5+ Ke6

Answers 41-42

41 / KG-LAB-03

The finite search prefers Nbd2 (-0.64 from White's perspective), compared with c3 (-0.68 from White's perspective). Develops the queen knight while leaving the c-pawn free. The knight supports e4 and may seek c4 or a route through f1.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. Nbd2 Bd6 12. Ne4 Be7 13. c3 Rhe8 14. Ng3 Qg6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. c3 f6 12. Re1 Bd6 13. Nbd2 Rhe8 14. Bf2 g5

42 / KG-LAB-03

The finite search prefers Nf1 (-0.63 from White's perspective), compared with Bg3 (-0.72 from White's perspective). Places the knight on f1. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Nf1 Bd5 16. Rxe8 Rxe8 17. Ng3 Bxg3 18. hxg3 Nd8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. Bg3 Bh6

Answers 43-44

43 / KG-LAB-04

The finite search prefers exd5 (+0.17 from White's perspective), compared with Bxf4 (+0.02 from White's perspective). The pawn captures a pawn on d5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. exd5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. Bxf4 Nf6 12. exd5 O-O 13. dxc6 Nxc6 14. Nxb5 Na7

44 / KG-LAB-04

The finite search prefers Bxf4 (+0.53 from White's perspective), compared with Kg1 (+0.00 from White's perspective). The bishop captures a pawn on f4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Bxf4 b4 16. Ne4 bxa3 17. bxa3 Bxa3 18. Bb1 Bb2

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. Kg1 Bd6 16. Ne5 Qb6 17. Bxf4 Qxd4+ 18. Qxd4 Nxd4

Answers 45-46

45 / KG-LAB-05

The finite search prefers Bc2 (+0.51 from White's perspective), compared with Bc4 (+0.12 from White's perspective). Places the bishop on c2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. Bc2

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. Bc4 O-O 12. Be3 c6 13. dxc6 Nxc6 14. Qxd6 Qxd6

46 / KG-LAB-05

The finite search prefers Bxc5 (+0.10 from White's perspective), compared with O-O-O (+0.07 from White's perspective). The bishop captures a knight on c5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Bxc5 Bxc5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. O-O-O Nxe3 16. Rxd8+ Rxd8 17. Qe2 O-O 18. Kb1 Ne6

Answers 47-48

47 / KG-LAB-06

The finite search prefers Nd2 (+0.03 from White's perspective), compared with Bd3 (-0.25 from White's perspective). Places the knight on d2, attacking knight on e4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. Nd2 Nxd2 12. Qxd2 O-O 13. Nf3 Bf5 14. c3 Be4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. Bd3 Nxe5

48 / KG-LAB-06

The finite search prefers Rad1 (+0.13 from White's perspective), compared with c3 (+0.04 from White's perspective). Places the rook on d1. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Rad1 Qg6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. c3 h6 16. Rad1 Be4 17. Bd3 Qe6 18. Nd4 Nxd4

A 12-week course you can repeat

WEEKLY WORKLOAD

Aim for four study sessions of 30-45 minutes and two slow practice games. If that is too much, stretch each week to two weeks. Consistency and review matter more than finishing on a deadline.

A 35-MINUTE SESSION

Spend 5 minutes recalling yesterday's position, 10 minutes learning one decision, 15 minutes calculating or playing a position, and 5 minutes writing the lesson. Keep the answer hidden during recall.

USE A MASTERY GATE

Move on when you can reconstruct the main branch, explain its plan and name the opponent's counterplay on two different days. If not, repeat the decision with a changed opposing reply.

DO NOT STUDY EVERY BRANCH EQUALLY

Prioritize the first line of each family and the lines your opponents play. Optional alternatives are comparison material after the main repertoire is stable.

Weeks 1-3

WEEK 1 / BOARD SKILLS AND THINKING ROUTINE

00 foundations; practice coordinates, legal moves, notation and the blunder check. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 2 / FIRST OPENING FAMILY

01 family 1. Learn its main route, then two alternatives. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 3 / SECOND OPENING FAMILY

01 family 2. Compare the opponent's central choices. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 4-6

WEEK 4 / THIRD OPENING FAMILY

01 family 3. Add common deviations and one warning position. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 5 / FOURTH FAMILY AND BOUNDARIES

01 family 4. Distinguish the main repertoire from optional branches and bridges. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 6 / PAWN STRUCTURES

02 strategic lessons 1-4. Identify the correct break from the actual center. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 7-9

WEEK 7 / DEFENSE AND TACTICS

02 remaining lessons and calculation audits. Practice checks, captures and opponent resources. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 8 / FIRST THREE LABORATORIES

03 laboratories 1-3. Play each starting position from both sides. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 9 / LAST THREE LABORATORIES

03 laboratories 4-6. Compare candidates before revealing the engine lines. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 10-12

WEEK 10 / ENDGAME TRANSITIONS

02 endgames. Analyze one legal exchange sequence from your own game. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 11 / FULL RETRIEVAL TEST

04 questions 1-48. Write explanations before looking at answers. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 12 / CONSOLIDATE YOUR OWN REPERTOIRE

Repair recurring errors and build a small personal file of the positions you actually meet. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Pocket reference / 1

ACCEPTED: THE G-PAWN DEFENSES

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

KG-01 The main choice: meet ...g5 with h4

Attack the pawn chain, then move the attacked knight.

KG-02 Kieseritzky: the developing ...Nf6

Count both sides' captures, not just the pawn you recovered.

KG-03 Kieseritzky: an immediate ...d6

An attacked piece may escape by capturing a target.

KG-04 Black reinforces with ...h6

Calculate the h-file before choosing the recapture.

KG-05 Black develops the bishop early

Track a pawn's new file after every capture.

KG-06 Quiet alternative: the Vienna-style approach

A development move can concede a forcing pawn tempo.

KG-07 Fischer Defense: build the center

...d6 changes the knight's retreat square.

KG-08 Fischer Defense: Black develops first

If the pawn is returned, play the resulting position.

Pocket reference / 2

ACCEPTED: CENTRAL AND DEVELOPING DEFENSES

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

KG-09 Modern Defense: ...d5 at once

Central counterplay can matter more than retaining the extra pawn.

KG-10 Modern Defense: the queen recaptures

Gain a tempo and spend it on development.

KG-11 Abbazia: an early pawn exchange

A check can help the defender develop.

KG-12 Schalopp Defense

An offside knight may still perform a concrete defensive job.

KG-13 Cunningham: meet the bishop check

Surviving the check changes the whole king-safety plan.

KG-14 Cunningham: Black chooses ...Nf6

Count attackers and defenders on f2 as well as f7.

KG-15 The ...Nc6 developing defense

Development with tempo must still be tactically safe.

KG-16 The ...h6 waiting move

Match the position, not just the opening name.

Pocket reference / 3

DECLINED AND COUNTERGAMBITS

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

KG-17 Classical Declined: ...Bc5

Respect the diagonal before taking e5.

KG-18 Declined: ...Bc5 with ...Nc6

A declined gambit can become a normal development contest.

KG-19 Falkbeer: the ...e4 wedge

Challenge the wedge before it binds your pieces.

KG-20 Falkbeer transposes to the Modern

Transpose by position, including whose turn it is.

KG-21 Falkbeer: ...c6 counter gambit

You do not have to accept a second gambit.

KG-22 Declined with ...d6

Gain space, then finish development.

KG-23 Declined with ...Nc6

The opening can change family a move later.

KG-24 The ...f5 counter gambit

Against counter gambits, check forcing moves first.

Pocket reference / 4

ALTERNATIVES AND REPERTOIRE BOUNDARIES

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

KG-25 Bishop's Gambit: optional route

Bc4 first permits the check Nf3 would prevent.

KG-26 Muzio: understand the sacrifice

Distinguish a deliberate piece sacrifice from normal development.

KG-27 Simple warning: the exposed king

Check the queen's diagonal before chasing a pawn.

KG-28 If Black plays the French

No ...e5 means no King's Gambit.

KG-29 If Black plays the Caro-Kann

Choose a real response to Black's first move.

KG-30 If Black plays the Sicilian

A bridge line has a defined move-order boundary.

KG-31 If Black plays the Scandinavian

Meet a central challenge with development and calculation.

KG-32 If Black plays a modern setup

Take space, then make it sustainable.

A practical game-analysis worksheet

GAME DETAILS

Date: _____ Opponent: _____ Time control: _____ Result: _____

FIRST UNFAMILIAR POSITION

Move number: _____ Relevant line ID: _____

What did the opponent's last move threaten? Write the FEN or save the position in your chess program.

MY CANDIDATES

Candidate A and a reply: _____

Candidate B and a reply: _____

Why did I choose the move I played?

DIAGNOSIS

Was the main error opening recall, missed tactics, the wrong pawn break, king safety, an exchange decision or time management? Choose the earliest cause that explains the later problem.

REPAIR

Write one concrete rule tied to the position. Add a short legal variation and schedule the next review. Do not add twenty engine moves that you cannot explain.

Glossary

ANCHOR

The authored move sequence defining a branch; later printed moves may be an illustrative continuation.

COMPENSATION

Activity, king pressure or structural advantages that may offset a material deficit.

COUNTERPLAY

Active threats or pressure that make the opponent address your ideas.

EN PRISE

A piece is available to be captured; check whether the capture is actually safe.

FIANCHETTO

Developing a bishop to b2, g2, b7 or g7 behind a moved b- or g-pawn.

INITIATIVE

The ability to pose threats that influence the opponent's replies.

ISOLATED PAWN

A pawn with no friendly pawn on either adjacent file.

Glossary / continued

MINORITY ATTACK

A pawn advance by fewer pawns against a larger pawn group to create weaknesses.

OUTPOST

A useful supported square for a piece, often difficult for enemy pawns to challenge.

PROPHYLAXIS

A move that anticipates and reduces the opponent's useful plan.

TEMPO

One move of time; useful tempi are gained when threats force helpful replies.

TRANSPOSITION

Different move orders reaching the same position with the same side to move and relevant rights.

ZWISCHENZUG

An intermediate move, often forcing, played before an expected recapture.

Sources and attribution

OPENING NAMES AND ROUTES

Lichess chess-openings is a CC0 reference for established names and entry move orders. The course commentary, study routes and practice curriculum are original. Some Hippo routes use descriptive teaching labels because opening-name databases use that term inconsistently.

<https://github.com/lichess-org/chess-openings>

ENGINE AND LEGAL-MOVE TOOLS

Stockfish 18 supplies finite tactical comparisons and illustrative continuations. python-chess 1.11.2 validates moves, positions and PGN.

<https://stockfishchess.org/download/>

<https://python-chess.readthedocs.io/>

PIECE ARTWORK

The Cburnett piece designs are by Colin M. L. Burnett, as distributed by python-chess. Adapted SVG sources, attribution and the GPL-2.0 license are included in Artwork_Credits_and_Sources. The palette and PDF drawing scale are adjusted; the original piece silhouettes are retained.

<https://python-chess.readthedocs.io/en/latest/svg.html>

Research scope and verification

KING'S GAMBIT CONTEXT

The Modern Defense accepts f4 and challenges the center with ...d5, often returning material for development. This source was used for context; the detailed branches and explanations here were independently constructed.

<https://www.chess.com/openings/Kings-Gambit-Accepted-Modern-Defense>

WHAT WAS CHECKED

All 130 course anchors across the five courses were legally replayed. Repertoire-side decisions after the opening commitment received 80,000-node best-move and played-move comparisons; apparent losses above 1.00 were rechecked at 600,000 nodes. Flagged choices were revised. Warning lines deliberately contain mistakes and are marked.

ILLUSTRATIONS AND LIMITS

Short anchors were extended to about move ten using 140,000-node searches. Endpoints used 400,000 nodes; laboratory positions used 500,000 nodes per search. These are finite checks, not proofs of equality or exhaustive modern theory. Optional gambits and full Hippo formations retain practical and strategic risks.

WHAT THE NUMBERS MEAN

Laboratory estimates are expressed from your course side's perspective, so higher is better for that side. They are not literal pawn counts or guaranteed winning probabilities. Close candidate values should be treated as comparable, and deeper analysis may change the ordering.

PUBLICATION CHECKS

PDF text, page geometry, board legality and PGN replay are checked. Every combined-volume page is rendered for visual review. The supplied verification manifest records the final page counts and file hashes.